HT BENGALURU

Tuesday, November 3, 2026

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Indian stocks' foreign ownership hits 15-yr low ▶P1

RIL's best day since 2020, relief hopes on LTCG lift mkts ▶P1

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HT BENGALURU VOL.1 NO.81

Tuesday, November 3, 2026

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Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

SBI to Binance: financial giants face a cyber siege

BY SHELLEY SINGH

Incidents involving Binance and State Bank of India highlight cyber risks facing financial institutions. As banks and crypto platforms adopt sophisticated technologies, hackers are exploiting gaps to steal customer data and facilitate fraud and financial crime. *Mint* explains.

BLOOMBERG

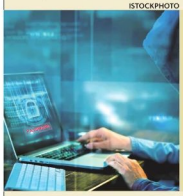
1 What happened at Binance recently?

In the biggest crypto attack in history, cyber criminals siphoned $6.3 billion from Binance in 20 minutes on 29 October, manipulating internal systems linked to transactions, approvals and withdrawals. On 1 November, the US Federal Bureau of Investigation traced the theft to TraderTraitor, a North Korean hacking group that converted stolen assets into Ethereum. Binance said about 95% of the stolen assets have since been covered. Founded in China in 2017, Binance allows users to buy, sell and trade digital assets. It had 335 million registered users globally and $162.8 billion in assets in 2025.

2 How did the SBI data breach unfold?

SBI, India's largest bank, disclosed a suspected data breach on 21 October after alerts from its threat intelligence provider, CERT-In and the Defence Cyber Agency. About 375,000 records were found on the dark web, including 3,897 customer records that SBI identified as containing personally identifiable information. Details included names, addresses, mobile numbers, dates of birth, emails and loan-related metadata. While core banking operations were unaffected and no money was stolen, the data could be exploited for phishing, impersonation and social-engineering attacks. An independent probe is under way.

ISTOCKPHOTO



3 What system vulnerabilities lead to such attacks?

Weak passwords, compromised credentials, phishing and vulnerable third-party networks expose interconnected financial systems to cyberattacks. Customer databases, ageing infrastructure and newer digital and AI platforms also widen security gaps. Data theft can stem from malware or partner networks, without a direct breach.

4 Will there be more cyberattacks?

Yes. As financial services become more digital and AI-powered, cyberattacks are expected to rise, with criminal groups increasingly using AI to scale attacks. Banks, fintech firms and crypto exchanges must strengthen defences through zero-trust systems, multi-factor authentication, data encryption and real-time network monitoring. Regular security audits, employee training, customer awareness, threat intelligence sharing and rapid incident response are also critical.

5 Is quantum computing a threat to finance?

Yes, potentially. Powerful quantum computers could eventually break some of today's widely used encryption standards, though such capabilities are not yet commercially available at scale. Banks should begin testing quantum-resistant algorithms and plan migration strategies, while building the flexibility to replace encryption methods as standards evolve. The SBI and Binance incidents underscore that cybersecurity is a systemic financial risk, not merely an IT concern.

QUICK EDIT

Fiscal stress

Over the past few months, bond yields have spiked globally owing to concerns over rising public debt. Public debt levels in India appear reasonable compared to the developed world but they are high by emerging market standards. The spike in the global commodity cycle has raised concerns about fiscal slippages because of higher subsidy payouts. Rising inflation has raised prospects of further rate hikes.

India's benchmark 10-year central government bond yield (G-sec) has risen nearly 40 basis points (0.4 percentage points) over the past three months to reach 7.3%. Given the global context, the rise does not seem alarming. Yet, it signals growing concerns about high government spending. Corporate bond yields have also risen in tandem, raising borrowing costs for firms.

As the finance ministry prepares for the next budget, it must ensure that line ministries keep expense plans modest for the next fiscal year. Given the super El Niño impact on rural livelihoods, some funds would have to be set aside for a rural boost. Other expenses may have to face cuts. The divestment programme should be fast-tracked to boost revenues.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

If India had not created renewable energy capacity in the last 10 years, then the energy crisis in India could have been worse than in other parts of the world... India's economic growth is high despite the ongoing West Asia crisis.

NARENDRA MODI
PRIME MINISTER

He was speaking at a renewable energy summit in New Delhi.

INSIDE

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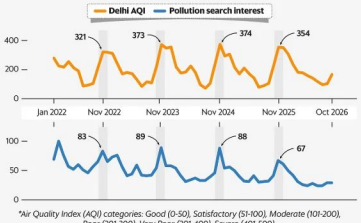
Global | U.S. pushes to restore Russian gas sales to Europe via Ukraine >P12
Money | Festive splurge: celebrate without compromising financial security >P15
Views | Empowering mayors to lead Indian cities >P16
Views | India is escaping poverty but is it turning economically secure? >P17

mint | DATA BITES

WHEN DO INDIANS SEARCH THE MOST ABOUT POLLUTION?

India's air quality generally reaches its worst level in November and remains elevated throughout the winter. Search interest for 'pollution' shows a similar pattern, with levels peaking in November before tapering off.

AQI* levels for Delhi and Google search interest** for 'pollution', monthly



*Air Quality Index (AQI) categories: Good (0-50), Satisfactory (51-100), Moderate (101-200), Poor (201-300), Very Poor (301-400), Severe (401-500).
**Search interest is measured on a scale of 0 (lowest) to 100 (highest).*

Data: Anjishnu Das
Graphic: Prateek Kumar

Source: Google Trends, Central Pollution Control Board

COLUMNS

AJIT RANADE
DON'T GIVE UP CAPITAL GAINS TAX DUE TO RUPEE WEAKNESS >P16

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MAKE WAY FOR A NEW 'FRAGILE FIVE' GROUP OF COUNTRIES >P17

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PLAIN FACTS

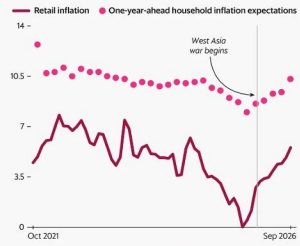
INDIA'S THREE POLICY TRADE-OFFS IN 2026

BY DEEPA VASUDEVAN | feedback@livemint.com

India has three major economic challenges to tackle: balancing affordability with free market pricing, keeping savers and borrowers happy, and attracting foreign investment without compromising its fiscal health.

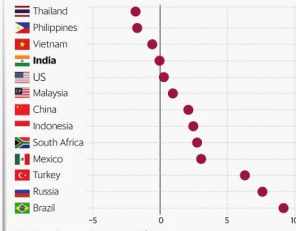
Household inflation expectations have risen with surging costs amid West Asia war

Figures in %



India has one of the lowest real policy rates among emerging markets

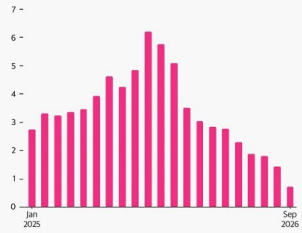
Real policy rate* (in %)



*Current policy rate minus current inflation.

With rising inflation, real returns on bank deposits have declined sharply

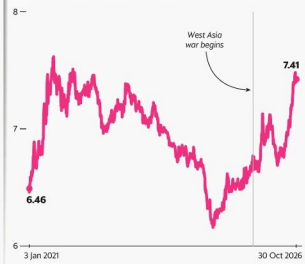
Real deposit rate* (in %)



*Deposit rate minus inflation. The deposit rate used for the calculation is the month-end data on the interest rate paid on one-year standard term deposits by the State Bank of India.

Yields on benchmark government bonds have risen steeply since the West Asia war

India 10-year government bond yield (in %)



Source: Reserve Bank of India, Bank for International Settlements, respective central banks, State Bank of India, CMIE, author's calculations

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MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

AT A GLANCE

- Balancing conflicting economic priorities requires flexible policy strategies, particularly as global shocks and the West Asia war distort market pricing and heighten inflation risks.
- Fuel price curbs may briefly ease pressure of inflation on homes, but can distort market signals, compress corporate margins, and necessitate eventual hike in interest rates.
- Increasing rates helps curb persistent inflation and benefits household savers, yet higher rates elevate debt servicing costs and could exacerbate capital outflow pressures.
- So, policy makers must manage these trade-offs with practical decisions that balance consumer protection, foreign investor confidence, and long-term fiscal discipline.

Policymaking usually involves trade-offs. Monetary policy has to choose between inflation and growth. Fiscal policy must balance prudence with deficit spending. Currency policy faces a choice between supporting the exchange rate and protecting foreign exchange reserves. The more uncertain the times, the harder it becomes to balance competing objectives. Today, more than ever, policymaking is as much art as science, and policies must remain flexible and adaptable to changing circumstances.

Among the many challenges facing India, three difficult trade-offs stand out.

AFFORDABILITY VS MARKET FORCES

The reconciliation between affordability and free-market price determination has become difficult since the West Asia war, especially in the context of fuel prices. The government has kept the retail price of petrol and diesel down to insulate households from soaring fuel prices. Holding prices artificially low distorts price signals in the market: There is less incentive to reduce fuel consumption when prices are controlled. On the other hand, it lowers the cost of living, improves affordability and maintains consumer confidence. Of course, price controls cannot keep inflation down forever—they can only delay the inevitable.

The West Asia war is now over six months old, and businesses are already passing on some price rises to consumers. The July-September quarterly results illustrate such pressures. Leading fast-moving consumer goods companies have reported margin compression despite robust sales volumes and selective price hikes. The cement sector saw sharp margin contractions despite price adjustments. Domestic air passenger traffic has slowed amid rising airfares. At this point, restrained price hikes have pushed inflation up, but government interventions have kept prices from spiralling.

However, households and businesses are fully aware of incipient price pressures. Wholesale inflation is now at 11.4%, and the impact of a super El Niño is apparent. Expectations of inflation are building up, approaching the highs last seen during the 2022 inflationary period.

This means either the Reserve Bank of India hikes interest rates to curb inflation and thereby bring down inflation expectations, or retail fuel prices must be raised. The former has already started, and energy experts are of the view that retail pump prices may be raised post-Diwali, if international crude prices remain elevated.

SAVERS VS BORROWERS

The second one is a trade-off between optimizing for savers and borrowers: savers benefit from high interest rates, while borrowers prefer low rates. Households are the largest net savers in the economy, but their savings have been depleted—first by the pandemic, and then by inflationary shocks in the following years. Bank deposits, the largest individual component of household financial assets, have given declining real returns over the past year.

The government is the largest borrower in the economy, followed by the corporate sector. If the RBI hikes rates, it could deliver both lower inflation and better returns to households. However, higher rates would raise the government's interest burden, putting further pressure on its fiscal health. Higher rates may also moderate the otherwise robust growth in bank credit to industry.

FOREIGN FLOWS VS FISCAL HEALTH

The final challenge is to strike a balance between attracting foreign capital inflows and maintaining fiscal health. On the external front, dwindling capital inflows are India's main problem. Until 2023-24, we received an annual average of $50 billion in net capital flows. However, flows dropped steeply to a net inflow of just over $1 billion in 2025-26, and a net outflow of $5.5 billion in Apr-Jun 2026.

Not surprisingly, the rupee has depreciated by about 6% against the US dollar since the start of 2026. India's stock markets have underperformed its peers in recent months-gross return on the MSCI India index during Jan-Sept 2026 was -9.1%, compared to 32% for the MSCI emerging market index. We also have among the lowest real policy rates in the emerging market universe.

Given that safe US Treasury bond yields are 5% or higher, it is hard to find reasons for hot portfolio flows to stay in India. This signals why the government has shown openness to making the tax regime favourable for foreign investors. From April 2026, foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) were exempted from withholding income tax and capital gains tax on investment in government securities. It may be time to do for equities as well. Market analysts argue that reducing taxes on sale, purchase, and profits from equity could increase the returns on FPI investments.

A tax cut may or may not bring FPI inflows back, but it would certainly reduce the government's revenue receipts. At the same time, higher fertilizer prices are expected to push up fertilizer subsidies, El Niño-related agricultural distress may increase rural spending and food assistance, and excise duty cuts on petrol and diesel could bring down excise collections. In sum, the fiscal deficit may be higher than budgeted, which would mean higher government borrowing.

These concerns are particularly relevant given the recent run-up in government yields: the benchmark 10-year rate has gained 82 bps in ten months, the steepest rise in recent years. With interest outgo at 38% of revenue receipts, a rise in borrowing rates would add to fiscal pressures.

These three challenges highlight that policymaking is all about competing priorities. Keeping prices low, attracting foreign capital, maintaining fiscal discipline, protecting the interests of savers, and creating a credit-positive environment are all important objectives, but focusing on one can come at the cost of another. The real challenge is to manage these trade-offs with practical and balanced policies.

The author is an independent writer in economics and finance.

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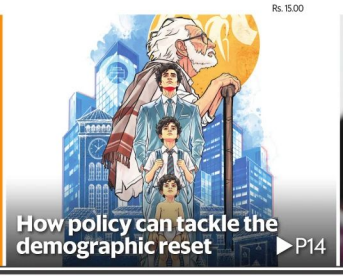

How policy can tackle the demographic reset ▶P14

Cigarette tax burns a hole in ITC's profits ▶P4

SENSEX **75,692.81** ↑ **1,233.28** | NIFTY **23,440.8** ↑ **387.7** | DOLLAR **₹94.84** ↑ **₹0.08** | EURO **₹106.46** ↓ **₹0.13** | OIL **$107.95** ↓ **$3.78** | POUND **₹127.37** ↑ **₹0.14**

Indian stocks' foreign ownership hits 15-yr low

FPI share falls to just 14.02% in Q2; local institutions help absorb foreign selling

Mayur Bhalerao
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MUMBAI

Foreign investors' ownership of India's listed firms has fallen to its lowest level in nearly 15 years amid valuation concerns, geopolitical uncertainty, and elevated US bond yields, even as they returned to the market as net buyers in the September quarter.

Mint's analysis of 5,638 BSE-listed firms sourced from the CMIE database showed that foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) held 14.02% of shares at the end of the September quarter, their lowest since December 2011. Their ownership fell nearly 0.4 percentage points sequentially and 1.54 basis points over the past year. It is now 6.07 percentage points below its December 2020 peak of 20.09%, reflecting a sustained retreat by overseas investors.

FPIs, however, turned net buyers during the September quarter, net investing ₹13,970 crore. They had pulled out ₹1.43 trillion in the June quarter and ₹1.31 trillion in the March one. Their net outflows for 2026 so far are at ₹2.9 trillion.

FPIs withdrew ₹76,619 crore in July-September 2025. Net outflows for the first nine months of 2025 were at ₹1.5 trillion.

To be sure, in the final week of October, FPIs bought stocks worth more than ₹14,000 crore. However, they remained net sellers for the month, pulling out ₹34,843 crore, as per NSDL data.

Mayur Shah, head of PMS and fund manager at Anand Rathi Advisors, attributed the decline in foreign holdings to higher US bond yields, stronger dollar, geopolitical haze and concern over Indian valuations. Earnings growth has not always kept pace with elevated valuations, particularly in largecaps, while other emerging markets offer competing opportunities.

The valuation gap remains stark. The MSCI India index trades at 16.59 times one-year forward earnings, more than twice the 7.54 times multiple for MSCI Emerging Markets and well above the 9.43 times for MSCI AC Asia Pacific.

Early earnings data, meanwhile, suggests corporate performance has remained robust. The 188 companies that have so far announced their September quarter results reported an aggregate revenue growth of 21.64% year-on-year, with net profit up 22.43%.

As foreign ownership receded, domestic mutual funds took their shareholding to a new high: to 11.59% in September from 11.50% in June and 10.79% a year ago. The gap between foreign portfolio and mutual fund ownership narrowed to 2.43 percentage points, from 4.77 percentage points a year earlier, according to CMIE data.

Domestic institutional investors (DIIs) invested a net ₹1.7 trillion in Indian equities during the Sep-

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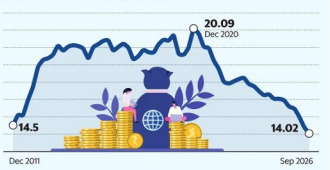
Foreign appetite for IPOs hits 5-year low >P4

MARKET SHIFT

Foreign investors' ownership of India stocks has fallen amid valuation concerns, geopolitical uncertainty, and elevated US bond yields.

Foreign portfolio investors' stakes (in %) in listed firms



Based on a rolling sample of 5,638 listed firms.
Source: Mint analysis, CMIE

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FOREIGN RETREAT

FPIs' ownership fell 154 basis points over the past year

IT's 6.07 percentage point below its Dec 2020 peak of 20.09%

FPIs' net outflows for 2026 so far stand at ₹2.9 trillion

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

RIL's best day in 6 years, LTCG relief hopes lift markets

Dipti Sharma
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MUMBAI

A rally in Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL) shares and growing optimism over a possible rollback of long-term capital gains (LTCG) tax for foreign investors gave Dalal Street plenty to cheer about on Monday, lifting both benchmark indices nearly 2%. Buying picked up through the session, with RIL seeing its biggest intraday gain since April 2020.

Citing sources, *Reuters* reported on Monday that market regulator Sebi had mooted scrapping LTCG tax for foreign investors as India seeks to revive its equity markets. The regulator has also proposed an LTCG exemption for mutual fund investors who sell existing holdings to reinvest in other funds, the report said.

There is, however, no word from Sebi on the matter as yet.

Sebi's proposal is a step in the right direction, but tax efficiency alone will not bring foreign capital back to India, said Nirav Karkera, head of research and fund manager at W by Groww, a wealth manager. While lower capital gains taxes would lift post-tax returns, reduce friction and make India more competitive against other emerging markets, the primary drivers of foreign flows remain earnings growth, valuations, currency stability, and India's relative attractiveness within emerging markets, he said.

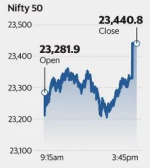
On Monday, Nifty 50 closed 1.68% higher at 23,440.80 and Sensex ended 1.66% up at 75,692.78. RIL, which carries a 7.3% weight in the Nifty 50, surged 11.6% on NSE, its biggest single-day gain since it jumped 11.9% on 7 April 2020, according to *Bloomberg* data.

The index started the week on a strong note, opening with

TURN TO PAGE 8

Street cheer

Nifty 50 closed 1.68% higher at 23,440.80 on Monday.



Source: Bloomberg

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PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

DON'T MISS

High airport fees, taxes pinch airlines: IndiGo CEO Walsh

IndiGo chief executive William 'Willie' Walsh has called for lower airport charges and taxes in India, warning that high operating costs could constrain aviation growth as airlines grapple with record jet fuel prices and rising airport tariffs. >P5

Prosus looks to strengthen India bets on platforms, marketplaces

Amsterdam-based Prosus is looking to invest in firms with platform or marketplace-led business models as it seeks to deepen its presence in India's financial services sector and other consumer-facing businesses, a senior company executive said. >P3

Telecom regulator makes complaint rules stricter

The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India notified tighter consumer grievance redressal rules, its first overhaul of the framework in 12 years. The changes introduce penalties for improperly closed complaints and shorter resolution timelines. >P2

Airlines contest Adani's planned 5 million passenger capacity cut

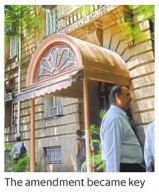
A proposed reduction in Mumbai airport's capacity from April 2027 has intensified a standoff between airlines and Adani Airport, with foreign carriers resisting a plan to shift part of their international operations to the newly opened Navi Mumbai airport. >P13

Behind the rule that stung key Tata trust

Nehal Chaliawala, Varun Sood & Satish John
MUMBAI/BENGALURU

The Maharashtra Charity Commissioner did not propose the rule that has paralysed Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT), the second-largest shareholder in Tata Sons, for nearly six months. The rule that resulted in the suspension of the trust's board proceedings was introduced by the state government and invoked by the commissioner on 15 May this year, as per the public trusts regulator's office.

In response to a *Mint* query under the Right to Information Act, 2005, the charity commissioner's office said it had sent no proposal to the state's Law and Judiciary Department regarding the Maharashtra Public Trusts (Amendment) Ordinance, 2025.



The amendment became key to the dispute on 28 April. MINT

Promulgated on 1 September 2025, the ordinance capped the number of perpetual trustees at

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Khambata exits Trusts, slams 'day of infamy' >P8
Settle Tata dispute out of public view: Sitharaman >P8

Tata JV's China director leaves

Ayaan Kartik
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NEW DELHI

The sole representative of Agratas Energy Storage Solutions Pvt. Ltd's Chinese-owned technology partner, AESC Apollo, has stepped down from the board of the Tata Group's battery venture less than two years after joining it and just ahead of the firm's move towards commercialization, regulatory filings show.

The departure of Gordon Louis Chin comes amid a decline in outstanding payments for its services and equipment to AESC and Agratas building its own manufacturing capabilities. The move marks a shift in the partnership's board-level representation just as the Tata firm prepares to scale up manufacturing in India and the UK.

The exit comes less than two years after joining. AFP

Agratas is building a 40 GWh battery plant in Somerset, UK, and a 20 GWh facility in Sanand, Gujarat. Its research and development expenditure increased to £20.9 million in FY26 from £7.7 million in FY25 as it develops both LFP and NMC battery technologies.

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Bollywood fails to pen advance ticket story

Lata Jha
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NEW DELHI

As Marvel's upcoming superhero feature *Avengers: Doomsday* opens advance ticket sales nearly three months ahead of release and generates $125 million worldwide, entertainment industry experts highlight a stark contrast with the Indian theatrical market.

Indian movies seldom offer advance booking for more than two weeks. Even a high-profile release like *Pathaan*, starring Shah Rukh Khan, limited advance sales to five days prior to release as a calculated strategy to build concentrated buzz.

The difference stems largely from the mechanics of Indian exhibition and distribution, where release dates are not always treated as sacrosanct, and delays in production or censorship are common.

Avengers: Doomsday carries decades of connected storytelling, so audiences commit the moment a date drops, no trailer needed. AP

Additionally, multiplex screens are shared across Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam, Hollywood, and regional releases, with several major titles frequently clashing within the same fortnight. Show allocations therefore remain subject to negotiation until right before release.

"To sell a ticket a hundred days out you need three things locked: the date, the film and the price. Hollywood locks all three a year out. *Doomsday*'s date hasn't moved since May last year, the runtime was public before general sales opened, and the premium formats were carved up months ago. In India all three are settled in the last fortnight," said Ashish Misra, head of commercialisation, Cinépolis India.

Release dates frequently shift around box-office clashes and festival windows. Recently, the Kannada action film *Toxic* changed its release date more than once before hitting theatres. Additionally, censor certificates arrive just days before release, and exhibition schedules cannot be built for ticket sales without a confirmed runtime. Ticket pricing for major Indian films is also finalized during release week. Beyond operational hurdles, an established industry habit acts as a deterrent: advance sales function as a public report card, tracked hourly by the trade, where soft initial numbers are quickly reported as a box-office failure.

"Nobody wants a hundred days of that, so producers open late, when the trailer has done its job and the number comes

TURN TO PAGE 13

MINT SHORTS

Govt seals ₹53,000 crore contracts to procure 8 warships for Navy

New Delhi: The defence ministry on Monday said it has sealed contracts worth ₹53,866 crore with two state-run shipbuilders to procure eight next-generation warships for the Indian Navy, in a major push to strengthen maritime security and bolster its combat capabilities, especially in the Indian Ocean, amid China's increasing forays into the region. **PTI**

'Renewable energy investments helped India avert energy crisis'

PTI

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday linked India's ability to weather the energy disruptions caused by the West Asia conflict to its investments in renewable energy, making the case for accelerating the country's clean energy transition. The government aims to add 500 GW of non-fossil fuel capacity over the next 10-11 years, he said. **RITURAJ BARUAH**

Renewables attract $67 bn in investments over two years: Joshi

New Delhi: Renewable sector has attracted $67 billion in the last two years, one of the largest investments in a sector, Union Minister Pralhad Joshi said on Monday. The sector will play an important role in meeting the country's future power demand, the minister for new and renewable energy said while addressing the Bharat Renewable Energy summit & expo 2026. **PTI**

Gadkari pushes alternative fuels to cut India's import bill

PTI

New Delhi: India is looking to accelerate the production of alternative fuels and reduce dependence on imported fossil fuels as geopolitical developments expose the economy to volatility in global energy prices, road transport and highways minister Nitin Gadkari said on Monday. **SUBHASH NARAYAN**

Petronet in talks with Qatar for delivery of delayed LNG cargoes

New Delhi: India's top gas importer Petronet LNG is in talks with Qatar to secure delivery of some of the at least 90 liquefied natural gas cargoes delayed chiefly by the West Asia crisis, said the company's chief executive officer A.K. Singh. Qatar, India's largest LNG supplier, has a contract to supply Petronet with 7.5 million metric tons of the fuel annually, equivalent to about 9-10 cargoes a month. However, 75-80 cargoes under the existing contract have been delayed so far by the war in the Middle East, Singh said, in addition to 15-16 cargoes not delivered in 2015-16 due to pricing disputes. **REUTERS**

PSU oil firms seek 150 mn litres of biodiesel at ₹88/litre

New Delhi: Indian Oil Corp., Bharat Petroleum Corp. and Hindustan Petroleum Corp. have invited bids to procure 150 million litres of biodiesel, or B100, for November 2026-January 2027, according to a joint tender issued on 30 October. The state-run oil marketing companies have set a base price of ₹88 per litre as they step up purchases of the renewable fuel. Bids are due by 7 November. The procurement covers biodiesel manufactured from used cooking oil (UCO) and other feedstocks. **PTI**

Drug regulator steps up cough syrup input checks

Drug makers backed the tighter tracking, though they fear delays in getting clearances

Priyanka Sharma
priyanka.sharma@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's drug regulator has told makers and suppliers of key cough syrup ingredients that no batch can leave the factory until it is registered and cleared online, according to two officials and a government document reviewed by *Mint*.

"...it shall be ensured that no batch of pharmaceutical grade of these solvents (propylene glycol, glycerine, sorbitol, etc.) should be distributed without uploading the required details sought on the DMS (digital monitoring system) and obtaining system-generated NOC (no objection certificate)," the directive said. State drug controllers have been told to make this a top priority, so every batch can be traced from the factory to the finished medicine.

The order from the Drugs Controller General of India (DCGI) covers propylene glycol, glycerine, maltitol and sorbitol. These ingredients are used in liquid medicines, and regulators treat them as high-risk for contamination.

Before shipping, a maker must now upload how much it produced, the lab test results for the batch and who bought it. The online system then issues a clearance.

The move follows the deaths of at least 24 children in Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan last year after they took cough syrups contaminated with toxic industrial chemicals, diethylene glycol (DEG) and ethylene glycol (EG). The chemicals damage kidneys and can be fatal. In 2022, the Gambia and Uzbekistan cough syrup incidents caused the deaths of dozens of children due to DEG and EG contamination.

Queries emailed to the spokesperson of the ministry of health and family welfare, DCGI office, Sun Pharma, Cipla, Mankind on Sunday and Zydus Lifesciences on Monday remained unanswered till press time.

India's pharmaceutical market is valued at $60 billion, ranking third globally by volume and eleventh by value, with annual exports at $30.5 billion. India also produces 20% of the world's generic medicines by volume and supplies over 60% of global vaccine demand, according to government data.

"The CDSCO has established a Digital Monitoring System on the Online National Drug Licensing System (ONDLS) portal to ensure robust oversight of the supply chain integrity and quality parameters of high-risk pharmaceutical solvents and excipients such as propylene glycol, glycerine, sorbitol, etc," DCGI Rajeev Singh Raghuvanshi said in a letter to state and Union Territory drug controllers on 27 October.

The regulator told state drug controllers to direct manufacturers and suppliers of pharmaceutical-grade high-risk solvents to register on the ONDLS portal and upload batch-wise data, including quantities manufactured, Certificates of Analysis (CoA), quantities supplied, vendor details and distribution trails, as required by the portal.

Drug makers backed the tighter tracking, though they fear delays in getting clearances. Nikkhil K. Masurkar, chief executive officer - ENTOD Pharmaceuticals said batch-level traceability of high-risk solvents is essential to prevent contamination and safeguard public trust in Indian medicines. The company specialises in ophthalmic drugs.

"The key challenge will now be to ensure seamless portal operations and timely NOC generation without disrupting manufacturing or raw material supplies," Masurkar said. "This measure will help prevent solvents that do not conform to pharmacopoeial grade from entering the pharmaceutical manufacturing supply chain," said Viranchi Shah, national spokesperson at Indian Drugs Manufacturers Association representing 1,200 companies.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Before shipping, a maker must now upload how much it produced, the lab test results for the batch and who bought it. BLOOMBERG

20% India's share of generic medicines by volume globally

60% of global vaccine demand is met by India.

Trai makes complaint rules stricter

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NEW DELHI

The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (Trai) on Monday notified tighter consumer grievance redressal rules, its first overhaul of the framework in 12 years. The changes introduce penalties for improperly closed complaints, shorter resolution timelines and round-the-clock customer support requirements for operators.

Under the Telecom Consumers Complaint Redressal (Fourth Amendment) Regulations, 2026, operators will face penalties of ₹1,000 for every improperly closed complaint and ₹5,000 for every improperly closed appeal, capped at ₹20 lakh per quarter for each Licensed Service Area (LSA).

The overhaul comes amid rising complaints against telecom operators. Direct complaints received by Trai rose 63% to 73,081 in FY26 from 44,733 in FY24, after reaching 55,978 in FY25, according to Trai data.

The new framework replaces provisions introduced in 2012 and amended in 2012, 2013 and 2014. Trai released the draft amendments in May, citing changing consumer behaviour and growing use of apps, websites, chatbots and other digital channels.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

India manufacturing growth eases in Oct

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India's manufacturing sector growth maintained momentum in October, but eased marginally from the previous month due to softer increase in output and new orders, a private survey showed.

According to the HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) released on Monday, the seasonally adjusted index fell to 54.7 in October from 55.1 in September and remained below the flash figure readings of 54.9. But the index was comfortably above the neutral mark of 50 and its long-run average, signalling improvement in the sector's health.

Growth of new export orders, which reached a six-month high, and easing price pressures provided support, with companies continuing to add jobs and build inventories, although hiring remained subdued and business confidence weakened. A sustained improvement in demand was reflected in a further sharp rise in new business, the survey said. "Growth eased only marginally from September's seven-month high and remained strong by historical standards. Panel members cited favourable demand trends, new client wins and successful marketing campaigns."

A sustained improvement in demand was reflected in a further sharp rise in new business

Strong international demand pushed growth of new export orders to a six-month high, said Pranjul Bhandari, chief India economist at HSBC. "Producers also increased input inventories to the greatest extent in eight months, building precautionary buffers to mitigate potential shortages and meet rising production requirements amid a volatile global environment.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Bank chiefs confident of credit growth

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Six state-run banks have signalled confidence in credit growth in the second half of FY27 even as they face pressure on net interest margins (NIM) from deposit costs and competitive funding conditions.

Strong demand from retail, agriculture, micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) and companies, along with festive-season borrowing, is expected to support loan growth, while foreign currency non-resident (bank), or FCNR (B), deposits have provided lenders with an additional source of funding, the chiefs of Punjab National Bank, Bank of Baroda, Canara Bank, Indian Bank, Indian Overseas Bank and Uco Bank said in interviews to *Mint*.

The Indian banking sector is navigating a trade-off between protecting profitability and sustaining loan growth, with festive demand expected to provide an additional boost. Together, the six lenders hold deposits of ₹64.5 trillion, which accounts for about 41% of the total public sector bank deposit base of ₹156.3 trillion.

While floating-rate loans are repriced relatively quickly, deposit costs tend to adjust with a lag. Competition for term deposits and the need to sustain funding momentum could weigh on margins in the coming quarters. However, bank managements are not signalling any broad-based slowdown in credit demand, with growth estimates ranging from 11% to 15%. But, rising funding costs and competition for deposits remain key challenges.

Banking sector is navigating a trade-off between profitability and sustaining loan growth

Uco Bank managing director and chief executive officer in-charge Rajendra Kumar Saboo cited current account and savings account mobilization as a concern amid changing savings and investment patterns.

Canara Bank flagged the potential mark-to-market impact of rising government security yields, which have increased from 6.75% in June to 7.38%.

Despite these pressures, the bank chiefs remain confident about sustaining loan growth, supported by improving asset quality, resilient domestic demand and alternative funding sources. Maintaining a balance between deposit costs and lending yields will remain central to profitability in the second half of FY27.

Punjab National Bank MD and CEO Ashok Chandra expects the lender's credit growth to remain at 14-15% in the coming quarters, supported by retail, agriculture and MSME lending. Its domestic NIM increased 10 basis points sequentially to 2.74% in the September quarter. Chandra expects the recent 25-basis-point repo rate increase to contribute an additional 7 basis points to margins.

Indian Bank raised its FY27 advance growth guidance to 13-14% from 11-13% earlier, while increasing its deposit growth outlook to 11-12% from 9-11%. Advances grew 16.4% year-on-year to ₹7.22 trillion as of 30 September, while deposits increased 12.5% to ₹8.74 trillion.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Banks are balancing profitability with the need to maintain funding momentum and support credit expansion. ISTOCKPHOTO

Meghalaya's fish farming model raises hope for the north-east region

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NEW DELHI

An initiative to promote the culture of major carp fish species in Meghalaya's Ri-Bhoi district appears set to emerge as a wider fisheries development model for India's northeast region.

According to government data reviewed by *Mint*, carp production in Meghalaya has jumped from 1.5 tonnes per hectare in 2025 to 4 tonnes in 2026 under the Indian Council of Agricultural Research's (ICAR) Aqua Village Model promoting quality fish seed, formulated pelleted feeds and scientific stocking practices.

"Aqua village represents the transformative potential of Indian agricultural research in addressing complex development challenges. Our focus is not just on enhancing productivity, but on building integrated, science-led livelihood systems that connect research with farmers, strengthen rural economies and create sustainable opportunities for communities," said M. L. Jat, secretary, Department of Agricultural Research and Education (DARE) and Director General of the Indian Council of Agricultural Research.

The Centre has pushed major carp varieties, including Amur common carp, Gonius and silver barb, with the aim of strengthening local fish production and encouraging sustainable aquaculture practices, according to two people aware of the development.

The Aqua village model also connects increased fish production with several broader development priorities such as nutritional security, livelihood diversification, women's economic participation, efficient resource use and sustainable rural development.

In Meghalaya, where water is abundant but aquaculture productivity has traditionally remained limited, the science-led intervention is demonstrating how the same pond can deliver substantially more fish, better livelihood opportunities and a stronger foundation for entrepreneurship.

Implemented in Ri-Bhoi district in November 2025, the initiative combines scientific fish farming with integrated resource management and community participation. Roiland Mukhim, a woman farmer, has demonstrated improved fish farming productivity in her 1,000 square metre pond.

Previously, her pond recorded a productivity of approximately 1.4 tonnes per hectare. Following a stocking density of 10,000 fish seeds per hectare and around 11 months of culture, the fish have attained an average weight of 450 g. She now anticipates a total harvest of 340-400 kg from the pond.

"Aqua village is not merely about increasing fish production; it is about strengthening livelihoods, creating entrepreneurial opportunities for women and youth, and enhancing the resilience of tribal communities," said Anupam Mishra, vice-chancellor, Central Agricultural University, Imphal.

Fisheries exports from India rose from Rs 46,663 crore in 2019–20 to Rs 73,890 crore in 2025–26.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Aqua Village covers the entire fish value chain, from pond management to harvesting and value addition. REUTERS

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First published in February 2007 to serve as an unbiased and clear-minded chronicler of the Indian Dream.

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MINT SHORTS

Oracle plans $20 bn fundraise to finance AI and cloud expansion

Bengaluru: Oracle plans to raise $20 billion through bond and share sales, regulatory filings showed, as the software giant taps investors to fund its costly AI and cloud infrastructure build-out. Its shares fell 4% in premarket trading, extending a roughly 33% dip this year through Friday. The proceeds would be used for general corporate purposes, including capital spending, debt repayment, acquisitions, dividends and share buybacks. **REUTERS**

Spotify and Lovable investor Creandum raises $750-mn fund

AFP

New York: Creandum, a Swedish venture capital firm that has backed some of Europe's most successful technology companies, has raised a new $750 million fund to invest in early-stage startups. The company plans to make about 30 investments with the new fund over the next two years, according to partner Fredrik Cassel. Creandum was an early backer of Klarna Group Plc., Spotify Technology SA and AI coding startup Lovable. **BLOOMBERG**

Fireside says its co-founder Vinay Singh has stepped down

Mumbai: Fireside Ventures on Monday announced that Vinay Singh, co-founder and partner, will transition out of the firm after close to a decade of co-building India's flagship consumer venture capital fund. "As AI reshapes commerce faster than most of us expected, I want to spend more time exploring the frontiers of agentic commerce and its implications for the future of consumption," said Singh. **PRIYAMVADA C.**

Emirates NBD bets big on India

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MUMBAI

A little over a year after its $2.7 billion majority acquisition of RBL Bank, UAE-based Emirates NBD is now looking to deepen its India presence, including scouting for minority investments in Indian startups through its venture capital platform. Neeraj Makin, group head of strategy, analytics, and venture capital at Emirates NBD and an RBL Bank board member, discusses the rationale of the acquisition, the bank's India ambitions and its next phase of growth in an interview to *Mint*. *Edited excerpts:*

What makes India an attractive market for Gulf-based capital today?

India is one of the fastest-growing major economies in the world, with a population of approximately 1.4-1.5 billion. From a UAE perspective, the relationship with India is particularly significant. Indians account for about 35-40% of the UAE's population, and the two countries have built a strong economic partnership, supported by robust trade agreements. India is the UAE's second-largest trading partner, while UAE is India's third largest. Recent transactions and investments by players such as ADIA, Mubadala and IHC are further indicators of the growing confidence and long-term interest in the Indian opportunity.

What gave you the confidence to undertake the RBL transaction?

When evaluating the India opportunity... one of the key exercises we undertook was to study China's growth story and the corresponding growth of its banks. We looked at where some of its leading banks stood in 2000 and how they had grown over the following two decades. Some Indian banks today have asset bases of $50-100 billion, while their Chinese counterparts, which were at a similar scale in 2000, have since grown nearly 17-20x to $1 trillion to $1.3 trillion. This gave us a sense of the potential ahead and the possibility of 15-20x growth over the long term.

Why RBL? How are you thinking of scaling the asset today?

RBL's scale was one of the factors that made it particularly attractive to us. It gave us the opportunity to enter India in a measured way while retaining the flexibility to shape and grow the bank around our strategy.

The initial capital commitment was also more manageable compared with some of the other opportunities we considered. Another important consideration was that our investment was going directly into the bank, providing fresh capital that can now be used to support and accelerate RBL's growth.

Are you thinking of bolt-ons for the asset? What are the gaps?

We see opportunity to strengthen RBL's existing platform through bolt-on acquisitions. There are a few gaps in its current offering, particularly in wealth management, investment banking and other ancillary businesses. On the corporate banking side, RBL has largely focused on mid-sized corporates and has had limited access to larger clients due to its higher cost of funding and the resulting margin constraints.

> We see opportunity to strengthen RBL's existing platform through bolt-on acquisitions
>
> **Neeraj Makin**
> Group head, strategy, VC & analytics, Emirates NBD

On the retail side, RBL already has a well-established credit card business, and we see opportunities to create greater alignment and synergies with the bank's broader retail platform... Any future acquisitions would focus on adjacent businesses such as investment banking, institutional equities, retail broking, wealth management and asset management.

Can you elaborate on Emirates NBD's investment banking arm?

We are now looking to strengthen our investment banking business. In advisory and ECM, the key is to bring in the right people. Institutional equities, however, requires greater scale, strong institutional relationships, and an established brokerage platform. Therefore, acquiring an existing institutional equities or retail broking capability could make sense.

What kind of returns are you expecting from the investment?

Indian banks typically deliver RoEs of around 12-15% and ROAs of 1.5-2%. Naturally, we would want RBL to reach similar levels of performance, with a potential to do even better over time. However, this will take time, and that is our long-term ambition.

Could you tell us about your venture arm?

Our corporate venture fund was established in 2023 with a corpus of $100 million. We typically invest between $0.5 million and $5 million in Series A, Series B and early-stage startups. We have been evaluating opportunities in India even before entering the market and are now actively exploring investments here.

A key principle of our corporate venture strategy is that every investment should have a potential use-case within the bank, either in our existing markets or in the future. We focus on fintech and startups offering technology, products or services that add value to our banking operations.

So far, we have made around 10 investments across blockchain, AI and digital platforms, spanning Switzerland, Singapore, Israel, the UAE, and Turkey with a couple more in the pipeline. India is an emerging focus, and we expect to explore more opportunities now that we have a larger presence here.

'India showed resilience amid trade and geopolitical tensions'

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NEW DELHI

KPMG India chief executive Yezdi Nagporewalla. KPMG

India has displayed resilience in the face of rising geopolitical tensions, global trade uncertainties and supply-chain disruptions, sustaining strong economic growth and domestic consumption, said Yezdi Nagporewalla, chief executive officer (CEO) of KPMG in India.

He cautioned that geopolitical uncertainty and its impact on global trade and supply chains are likely to persist. The key question, Nagporewalla said, is how effectively India can navigate this environment while sustaining growth and innovation.

"If you look at GDP (gross domestic product) growth and the broader economic indicators, India has demonstrated sustainability and resilience. Despite global challenges, we have continued to grow, supported by the strength of domestic consumption," Nagporewalla told *Mint* on the sidelines of ENRich 2026, KPMG's annual conference on energy and natural resources being held in New Delhi on 2-3 November.

India's real GDP grew 7.8% year-on-year in the April-June quarter of FY27, compared with 6.9% in the corresponding quarter a year earlier, according to data released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation.

Nagporewalla said that the world is moving away from the model of globalisation that prevailed a decade ago, as countries become more inward-looking and forge new trade relationships with other markets.

"The USA has traditionally been a key trading partner, but recent developments have reinforced the need for India to diversify its trade relationships, strengthen global supply chains and build greater domestic resilience. This also presents an opportunity to enhance India's attractiveness as a global trade and investment destination," he added.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Prosus to scale India bets on platforms and marketplaces

Sneha Shah & Mansi Verma
MUMBAI

Following its $100 mn investment in Navi, Prosus looks to deepen its financial services thesis, says India head Ashutosh Sharma.

Amsterdam-based Prosus is looking to invest in companies with platform or marketplace-led business models as it seeks to deepen its presence in India's financial services sector and other consumer-facing businesses, a senior executive said.

The tech-focused investment firm, which recently infused $100 million in Sachin Bansal's fintech platform Navi, is looking to deepen its financial services thesis, Ashutosh Sharma, India head at Prosus, told *Mint* in an interview.

Last week, the Competition Commission of India (CCI) approved Prosus's $100 million (around ₹940 crore) investment in Navi for an 8.5% stake. The entirely primary investment, one of the first institutional capital infusions into the company, values Navi at more than ₹13,000 crore.

Prosus counts companies such as PayU, Vastu Finance, Mintifi and GrowXCD, among others, as part of its financial services portfolio. However, consumer-facing fintech was a missing piece [until the Navi deal], said Sharma.

"If you look at the gaps in our portfolio, most consumer categories are spoken for. In food, we have something; in quick commerce, we have something; in mobility, we now have Rapido; in travel, we have an OTA (online travel agency) through Ixigo; in e-commerce, we have Meesho; and in services, we have Urban Company. But one big gap was a consumer-facing fintech platform. PayU is in our portfolio, and we own all of PayU, but it is largely a B2B payments and B2B credit business. So, a B2C fintech platform was a missing piece in our portfolio," Sharma said.

Founded in 2018 by Flipkart co-founder Sachin Bansal, Navi offers UPI, credit, insurance and broking services through a single platform. For the financial year ended 31 March 2026, its operating revenue rose 16.2% year-on-year to ₹2,981.7 crore.

The company reported a consolidated net loss of ₹466 crore in FY26, compared with ₹126.4 crore in FY25, according to Tracxn data. Navi Finserv, the group's lending arm, had assets under management of ₹13,138 crore in FY26, which have already risen to more than ₹23,440 crore by the middle of this year.

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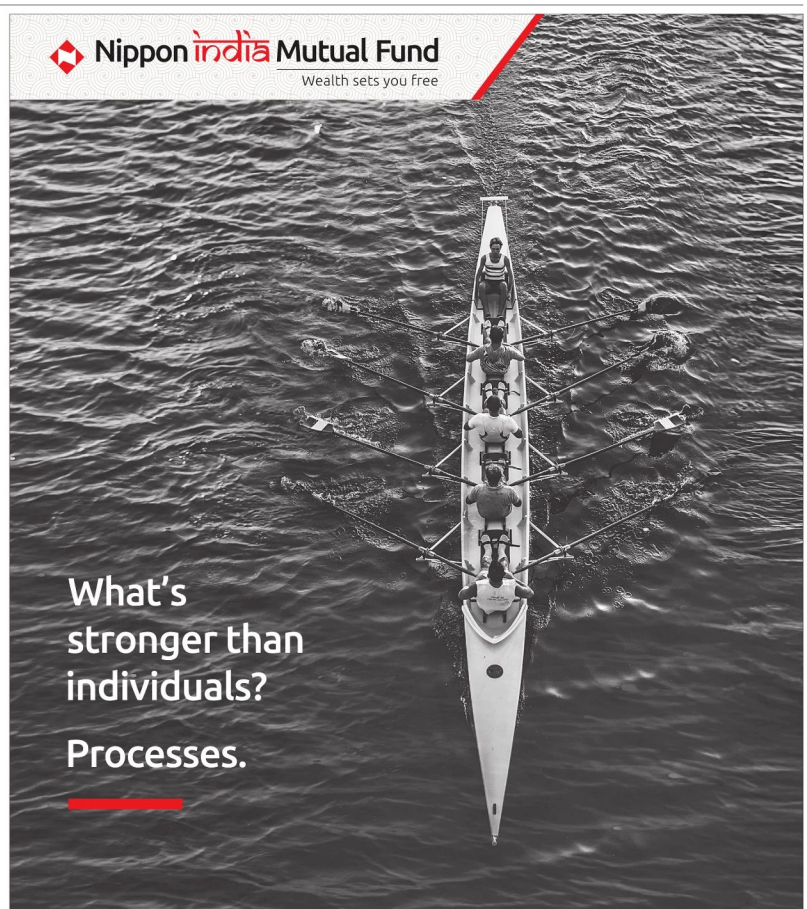

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BSE Sensex		Nifty 50		Nifty 500		Nifty Next 50		Nifty 100		BSE 150 MidCap		BSE 250 SmallCap	
CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE
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74,459.53	75,178.24	23,053.10	23,222.30	21,895.90	22,009.85	67,709.10	67,967.25	23,971.55	24,132.15	15,521.49	15,560.14	6,557.02	6,573.14
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75,692.78	74,978.12	23,440.80	23,207.05	22,242.55	22,006.40	68,971.10	67,964.45	24,382.65	24,129.40	15,754.67	15,560.14	6,678.61	6,552.52

RIL growth baton to shift in FY28

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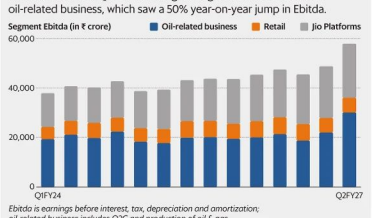
Reliance Industries Ltd's investors are in a dilemma after the Q2FY27 results: should they celebrate the strong earnings of the oil-to-chemicals (O2C) segment or worry about the weak profitability of the retail business? This predicament assumes even more relevance as the O2C segment currently enjoys abnormal profit, raising doubts about its sustainability.

The Q2 refining margin in the two main transportation fuels—petrol and diesel—is at least twice the five-year average. In this backdrop, the O2C segment Ebitda per tonne (based on production meant for sale) soared 68% year-on-year (y-o-y) and 28% quarter-on-quarter to ₹13,924. This mainly drove Reliance's consolidated Ebitda growth of 23% y-o-y, surpassing most brokerages' expectations, to ₹56,616 crore.

Global oil demand outlook is weak for 2026. A rebound is anticipated in 2027, but demand is still likely to be marginally lower than the 2025 level.

On fire

RIL's consolidated Q2FY27 results got a big boost from traditional oil-related business, which saw a 50% year-on-year jump in Ebitda.



Ebitda is earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortization; oil-related business includes O2C and production of oil & gas

Source: Company

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Even if the geopolitical scenario improves, weak demand is not good news for margins. Also, O2C is usually assigned lower valuation multiples because of its commodity nature, so a few quarters of high profit do not lead to a re-rating.

In contrast, the retail business, which enjoys higher valuation multiples, saw a 10 basis points (bps) dip in Ebitda margin sequentially to 7.34% in Q2, while revenue was flat at ₹80,220 crore. The margin fall is a worry even if a y-o-y comparison is ignored due to the shift in festival season this year to Q3 from Q2 in FY26.

According to the management, the online retail margin is lower than offline retail, but the online return on capital employed is higher.

For perspective, Eternal's quick commerce business Blinkit has a steady state margin target of 6%. Reliance Retail's mix of offline and online means its margin could eventually settle at a slightly higher level than that of Blinkit.

Despite the disappointing retail business, Reliance's growth trajectory should continue. O2C's profitability is likely to stay strong in the near term, before the new energy segment takes over the growth baton in FY28. The management is confident that H2 FY27 for O2C would be as good as the first half with annual Ebitda estimated at ₹80,000 crore.

Low global inventories of refined oil products should support margins. Also, recovery of output from refineries in West Asia is expected to be gradual. The ethane and naphtha cracking differential was up 2.3x from the 2025 average.

Jio Platforms' average revenue per user grew 1% QoQ, while Ebitda increased by 5% to ₹21,879 crore. Investors who are more upbeat on Jio Platforms, primarily telecom, are better off betting on it directly now that it has listed separately.

HIT AND MISS

O2C segment Ebitda per tonne soared 68% y-o-y and 28% quarter-on-quarter to ₹13,924

RETAIL Ebitda margin fell 10 bps sequentially to 7.34%, as revenue remained flat at ₹80,220 crore

Reliance's 65% stake in Jio Platforms, adjusted for holding company discount of 25%, means Reliance's investors can capture only 50% of the latter's potential upside in market capitalization (mcap).

If Jio Platforms and Reliance Retail's value, is deducted from Reliance's mcap, then O2C, exploration and production (E&P), new energy, FMCG and the media businesses have a net mcap of ₹7.4 trillion.

That does not look expensive as the oil-related businesses—O2C and E&P—alone had generated an Ebitda of almost ₹76,000 crore in FY25, the lowest in four years post-covid, i.e. the FY23-26 phase.

ITC profit falls 17% as cigarette taxes burn a hole

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MUMBAI

ITC's agri business picked up pace after a slump. MINT

Higher cigarette taxes took a toll on ITC Ltd's earnings in the September quarter, as falling volumes and shrinking margins outweighed the strong growth in its packaged foods business. Despite a pickup in demand for biscuits, snacks and packaged staples, the company's profit fell 17% from a year ago even as revenue jumped nearly 4%, underscoring the weight of its cigarette business.

Consolidated profits after tax before exceptional items were at ₹4,249 crore, down 17% from ₹5,121 crore a year ago, while consolidated revenue from operations jumped nearly 4% to ₹30,578 crore, ITC announced after market hours on Monday. Consolidated Ebitda fell 15.7% year-on-year to ₹5,645 crore.

Analysts at brokerage Nuvama said ITC's Ebitda margin of 28% for the reporting quarter was 665 basis points (bps) lower than a year ago, but 134 bps higher from the previous quarter. Ahead of the results, shares of ITC closed 0.3% higher on Monday, lagging benchmark Nifty 50 that ended 1.7% higher.

Much of the growth came from value-added products, including export-grade spices, fruits, vegetables

ITC's cigarette business grew 1.78x to ₹15,536 crore year-on-year, although margins were squeezed as the operating income fell more than 27% year on year to ₹3,813.45 crore. Brokerage Nuvama estimated ITC's cigarette volumes had fallen 7-8% year-on-year during the quarter.

"Legal industry volumes remain under pressure due to unprecedented increase in tax," ITC said in a press release, adding that the sharp increase in taxes had led to lower domestic demand, weighing on the company's leaf tobacco business, which is part of ITC's agri business vertical.

Late last year, India approved a law that replaced the 28% goods and services tax (GST) on cigarettes along with a compensation cess with an additional excise duty over and above the 40% GST tax slab reserved for 'sin' goods. The new tax rates kicked in from 1 February this year, leading to an immediate price rise of ₹22-25 per pack of 10 cigarettes.

However, the overall agri business picked up pace after a slump. Revenue from the segment grew to ₹4,452 crore, up 12% from a year ago despite supply chain disruptions and input cost rise triggered by the West Asia war. Much of the growth came from value-added products, including export-grade spices and fruits & vegetables, it said. Revenue from the paper and packaging business was up 36% to ₹3,016 crore, largely due to the acquisition of Aditya Birla Group's Century Pulp and Paper.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Muthoot's solid gold loan AUM loses sheen amid asset stress

Harsha Jethmalani
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Muthoot Finance shares slid to a new 52-week low of ₹2,305 on the National Stock Exchange on Monday as investors tried to digest the asset quality deterioration in Q2FY27 with rising loan delinquencies. This was when its main gold loan assets under management (AUM) rose by 43% year-on-year, backed by higher prices, better tonnage and client additions.

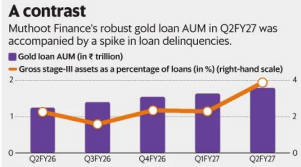
Better yields led to a 152 basis points sequential rise in net interest margin (NIM) to 11.93%. On the flip side, credit costs rose, with risky stage-III assets soaring sequentially to ₹7,268 crore in Q2 from ₹3,926.5 crore in Q1, and stage-II assets up at ₹23,466 crore from ₹1,876 crore in Q1 and ₹1,062 crore in Q4FY26.

After implementation of the Reserve Bank of India's revised regulations effective 1 April, Muthoot introduced structured monthly interest-servicing gold loan schemes. Earlier, it offered bullet repayment loans, where customers could pay interest at any point during the loan tenure without any prepayment penalty.

This transition led to missed payments and consequently, a sharp movement into stage-II and stage-III buckets. As customers got accustomed to the new repayment cycle, the management expects asset quality stress to ease. It doesn't view this spike as an indication of underlying borrower stress. But a pivot toward monthly interest repayment, which necessitates higher collection efforts, raises the risk of a compression in yields and NIM for NBFC gold financers. Motilal Oswal Financial Services said RBI's new rules on gold lending have brought in a trade-off between growth and yields.

A contrast

Muthoot Finance's robust gold loan AUM in Q2FY27 was accompanied by a spike in loan delinquencies.



AUM is assets under management; gross stage-III assets are loans that are overdue for more than 90 days

Source: Company, Nuvama Research

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

"In addition, the highly competitive intensity and aggressive foray of multiple deep-pocketed AAA (or AA-rated) NBFC franchises into gold loans could result in market share losses for incumbents," it said.

Muthoot raised its FY27 gold loan AUM growth guidance to 25% from 15% earlier. HIFY27 gold loan AUM is up 16%. NIM is seen in the 10.5-11% range. However, with gold prices consolidating now, rising funding costs and competitive pressures could weigh on the gold AUM growth trajectory.

While Muthoot should continue to deliver industry-leading profitability, with return on assets of 5.6-5.8% and return on equity of 26%, loan growth could moderate from extraordinary levels in the previous year, said Nirmal Bang Institutional Equities.

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Foreign ownership of Indian stocks hits a 15-year low

FROM PAGE 1

tember quarter, compared with net inflows of ₹13,970 crore from FPIs. The divergence underscores the growing role of domestic capital in supporting the market.

Strong domestic institutional participation has helped absorb foreign selling, said Vishad Turakhia, CEO of Equirus Securities. But that support does not resolve the concerns keeping overseas investors cautious. A fall in stock prices alone may not be enough to bring them back. Foreign investors also want earnings upgrades, improved returns on capital and evidence that India's valuation premium over other markets is justified, he added.

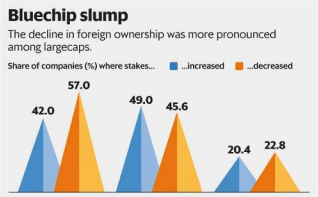
Shah said lower US rates could improve global liquidity and encourage investment in the emerging markets. Sustained inflows into India, however, would also require more reasonable valuations and greater confidence in earnings. "In our view, a combination of supportive global liquidity and stronger domestic earnings fundamentals will be essential for a durable revival in foreign investor participation," he said.

In the final week of October, foreign portfolio investors bought stocks worth more than ₹14,000 crore

The decline in foreign ownership was more pronounced among largecaps. *Mint* analysis of 100 largecaps showed FPIs reduced stakes in 57% of them sequentially in July-September, raised holdings in 42% and left them unchanged in the remaining 1%.

Bluechip slump

The decline in foreign ownership was more pronounced among largecaps.



Tracking sequential change in September 2026 quarter
Source: *Mint* analysis, ACE Equity

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

Their size and liquidity make these companies a natural source of funds when foreign investors cut exposure. Largecaps account for a substantial share of overseas portfolios and are easier to sell when funds rebalance, reduce emerging market allocations or meet redemptions, said Turakhia. "The issue is not necessarily a loss of confidence in India's long-term growth story. Rather, foreign investors are becoming more selective about the price they want to pay for that growth."

Meanwhile, domestic MFs increased their stakes in 55% of largecaps sequentially in the September quarter and reduced in 43%. Retail investors raised holdings in 47% of largecaps, reduced them in 52% and left them unchanged in the remaining 1%.

The picture was more balanced among BSE-listed midcaps. Of the 147 firms analyzed, foreign holdings rose in 49% and declined in 45.6%, making this the only segment where the increases outnumbered. Holdings were unchanged in the remaining 5.4%.

Mutual funds raised their stakes in 54.4% of midcaps and reduced them in 43.5%. Retail investors raised their holdings in 44% and cut them in 57%.

The ownership trends played out against divergent market performance. During the September quarter, the BSE largecap index fell 3.46% and the midcap index declined 2.15%, while the smallcap index gained 8.51%.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

UPL Q2 net profit down 26% on lower sales

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NEW DELHI

Global agriculture firm UPL Ltd on Monday posted a 26.14% drop in its consolidated net profit to ₹452 crore for the second quarter of 2026-27 on lower sales.

The company had clocked a net profit of ₹612 crore in the same period last year, according to a regulatory filing.

Total income fell 1.32% to ₹11,860 crore for the September-ended quarter of this fiscal year from ₹12,019 crore a year ago. Expenses were ₹11,298 crore, down from ₹11,573 crore in the same period last year.

The company said 50% growth was from specialty chemicals, while 12% in seeds and post harvest segment. Its subsidiary Advanta has agreed to acquire 99.9% of Misr Hytech Seed International, Egypt, for $110 million and the acquisition is expected to be completed on or before 31 January 2027, subject to regulatory approvals.

UPL Ltd chairman and group CEO Jai Shroff said the company's results for Q2 reflect the strength of the diversified model it has built.

"Despite a volatile global backdrop, our businesses continued to execute with discipline; Advanta and SUPER-FORM delivered strong growth," he said.

FII appetite for IPOs hits a 5-year low

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MUMBAI

Foreign investors have not completely turned away from Indian issuances but are being more selective. ISTOCKPHOTO

Foreign investors are growing cautious about India's initial public offerings (IPOs), with their share of anchor investments sliding to a five-year low amid concerns over rich valuations, weak market performance and a global shift in interest towards artificial intelligence (AI). As overseas investors get pickier, domestic institutions are taking on a bigger role, gradually shifting the balance of India's primary market.

Foreign portfolio investors' (FPI) investments as part of the total anchor book for initial public offerings (IPOs) slumped to its lowest in five years to 36.16% so far this year from its peak of 62.75% in 2021, according to data from Prime Database.

The previous low, as per the data, was 37.85% in 2022.

FPIs' share of the total IPO fundraising so far this year has also more than halved from its 2021 level to 11.61%, another five-year low.

The development has led to domestic institutional investors (DIIs) increasingly taking the place of foreign funds in anchor books. Mutual funds, insurance companies and other domestic institutions are emerging as important sources of capital, reducing companies' dependence on overseas investors to raise money.

However, not all issues have been deprived of foreign capital. "FPIs have continued to participate in larger transactions while being relatively selective about smaller deals," said Dharmesh Anil Mehta, managing director and chief executive officer at DAM Capital Advisors Ltd. "Also, global investors' interest is currently tilted towards AI and technology-related opportunities. India has had relatively fewer such offerings which has also contributed to lower FPI participation."

Of the 104 issues that entered the primary market in 2026, anchor investors contributed ₹49,771 crore

Mehta said DIIs now play a much larger role in anchor books, reducing the traditional dependence on foreign institutional capital. In the anchor book, institutional investors commit funds a day before an IPO opens for subscription. Their participation is closely tracked as it provides an indication of institutional demand and helps build confidence among other investors.

Of the 104 issues that entered the primary market so far in 2026, raising a combined ₹1.55 trillion, anchor investors contributed ₹49,771 crore.

FPIs accounted for just ₹17,998 crore of the anchor book, according to Prime Database. In 2021, companies had raised a total of ₹3.19 trillion. The total anchor book was ₹46,312 crore while FPIs contributed ₹29,059 crore.

Foreign investors are also pulling back from the secondary market. The Nifty 50 has declined around 12% so far this year, weighed down by geopolitical tensions, elevated crude oil prices, rising global bond yields and a stronger US dollar.

FPIs have remained net sellers in Indian equities, with outflows from the equity market amounting to ₹2.95 trillion so far in 2026, according to the data provided by the National Securities Depository Ltd (NSDL).

However, their participation in primary markets tells a different story. FPIs recorded net investments of ₹13,239.35 crore in the equity category of 'primary markets and others' in October, a 23% increase from the corresponding period last year. Their cumulative net investments under this category were at ₹68,763.15 crore in 2026 so far, NSDL data showed.

This suggests that foreign investors are being more selective about the companies and valuations they back.

"The composition has evolved significantly, with domestic mutual funds, insurance companies and other institutional investors becoming much larger participants," said Bhavesh A. Shah, managing director at Equirus.

Assets managed by mutual funds grew 9.3% to ₹82.64 trillion in September as compared to the same period a year ago. Monthly SIP contributions surged 10.7% to ₹32,490 crore in the same period, according to Association of Mutual Funds in India (Amfi) data.

The growing clout of domestic institutions is also changing how IPOs are prices, giving them greater say in valuations.

"The dominance of domestic players in IPOs has also led to scaling back of valuations. Domestic institutional investors are better at driving a better price in an IPO, and with the lack of foreign players, such bargaining power has increased," said Pranav Haldea, managing director of Prime Database.

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High airport fees, taxes pinch airlines: IndiGo CEO

Airport landing, parking and passenger UDF are among the costs factored into airfares

Abhishek Law
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NEW DELHI

IndiGo chief executive William 'Willie' Walsh has called for lower airport charges and taxes in India, warning that high operating costs could constrain aviation growth as airlines grapple with record jet fuel prices and rising airport tariffs.

"Lower taxes, lower airport charges, that's the way forward," Walsh said at a media briefing on Monday, his first since taking charge as IndiGo chief executive in August.

Airport landing, parking and passenger user development fees (UDF) are among the costs factored into airfares. Indian airfares rose over 30% year-on-year in the second quarter (Q2) of fiscal year 2027 (FY27), primarily because of higher jet fuel prices, with airport charges and UDF also contributing.

The Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India (AERA) regulates aeronautical charges at major airports, including landing and parking fees and UDF, through periodic reviews. At Delhi airport, for instance, AERA approved higher landing and parking charges for the five-year period beginning April 2024.

IndiGo's airport fees and charges increased nearly 10% year-on-year and 2% sequentially to ₹1,660 crore in Q2FY27, according to its investor presentation. This was the second-highest year-on-year increase in charges for the country's largest carrier in the past four quarters.

"We're always looking for better value from the airport, so we'll continue to look for them to be much more competitive when it comes to pricing, given that they are effective monopolies," Walsh said.

Citing his experience with airport charges in other markets, he said, "I've worked positively with some airports around the world. Some, as you know, I've been very vocal. Heathrow being a primary example of that."

In 2021, Walsh, then head of the International Air Transport Association (IATA), had called Britain's Heathrow airport a "greedy monopoly hub" as it planned to raise airport charges. In 2024, he had flagged concerns about rising airport charges in India.

Amit Mittal, director at consultancy firm AeroIntellect Aviation, said India's limited airport and aircraft infrastructure compared with developed markets was relevant to the cost debate.

"To understand it contextually, let's look at some numbers: India has 44 airports per million sq. km, while the US has 334 airports per million sq. km. India has 0.11 airports per million people, whereas the US has 15 airports per million people. India has 0.58 commercial aircraft per million people, while the US has 20 aircraft per million people," he said.

"In purchasing-power-parity (PPP) terms, India's airport charges are often higher than comparable US charges for passengers, especially at major metro airports. For airline landing and parking charges, the comparison is mixed and depends heavily on the airport and aircraft size," he said.

The call for lower airport charges comes as IndiGo faces an unprecedented fuel-price environment. Its fuel bill rose 67% in the September quarter, while fuel cost per unit of capacity increased 69%. Revenue grew 26%, backed by fare hikes, but the airline still reported a net loss of ₹1,879 crore.

Walsh said fuel accounted for more than 40% of IndiGo's costs, compared with about 32% for the global airline industry, as Indian airlines remain exposed to the full volatility of jet fuel prices. Airlines here do not hedge their fuel costs.

IndiGo is evaluating fuel hedging as it prepares for long-haul expansion, but will not introduce it until a detailed internal review is completed.

"Hedging is about managing risk. It is not about betting on what the fuel price will be; it is about providing stability and managing risk," Walsh said.

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"Lower taxes, lower airport charges, that's the way forward," Walsh said at a media briefing on Monday, his first since taking charge as IndiGo CEO in August. REUTERS

TARIFF TURBULENCE

INDIAN airfares rose over 30% YoY in the Q2 of FY27, primarily because of higher jet fuel prices

AERA sets landing, parking and UDF charges at major airports through periodic reviews

WALSH said that fuel makes up over 40% of IndiGo's costs, versus 32% globally

INDIGO weighs fuel hedging ahead of long-haul expansion, pending internal review

SC rulings in Vedanta-Ravva case exposes arbitration gaps

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NEW DELHI

The SC criticised the Union government for prolonging a dispute involving a 22-year-old arbitral award in favour of Vedanta Ltd. PTI

India's ambitions to establish itself as a global arbitration hub face persistent challenges due to prolonged state-driven litigation and institutional delays. Repeated Supreme Court criticism over extended challenges to enforcement orders, frequently driven by state entities, underscores the stark gap between India's push for fast-track dispute resolution and its actual implementation.

These systemic shortcomings were brought into focus on Monday as the Supreme Court criticised the Union government for prolonging a dispute involving a 22-year-old arbitral award in favour of mining major Vedanta Ltd, saying its approach was frustrating enforcement of an arbitration decision.

A bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and Manmohan dismissed the Centre's appeal against a Delhi High Court order allowing Vedanta and Ravva Oil (Singapore) Pvt Ltd to enforce foreign arbitral awards in the Ravva oilfield dispute. "You are frustrating an arbitral award like this at the stage of enforcement. We talk about arbitration, the seat and all this. Nobody will trust you," the bench told the Centre's counsel.

The SC flags delays in arbitral award challenges and enforcement, especially by government entities

The bench said it found no error, much less an error of law, in the Delhi High Court's 1 July judgment. It observed that the high court had considered all relevant aspects of the matter.

The apex court's rebuke adds to its recurring criticism of prolonged challenges to arbitral awards and delays in enforcement.

Last week, the court asked the Law Commission to examine the framework for enforcing arbitral awards and recommend measures to expedite their execution. The direction came while hearing a separate dispute involving Royal Construction Company and National Projects Construction Corporation, in which parties were litigating more than 24 years after an arbitral award.

In May, while dismissing a challenge by the Madhya Pradesh Road Development Corporation to an arbitral award in favour of Jabalpur Corridor Pvt Ltd, the Supreme Court observed that "the government's role cannot be ignored" in undermining arbitration.

The latest remarks come as India seeks to position itself as an international arbitration hub through legal and institutional reforms. Amendments to the Arbitration and Conciliation Act in 2015, 2019 and 2020 sought to reduce court intervention and expedite proceedings. The government also established the India International Arbitration Centre (IIAC) in 2019 and provided for an Arbitration Council of India to grade arbitral institutions and promote professional standards.

The dispute stems from a 1994 contract to develop the Ravva oilfield. It centred on the accounting of ONGC's historical costs. After a partial award in 2004 and a final award in 2016, the Centre sought $99 million from Vedanta and Ravva Oil. The companies approached Indian courts to enforce the awards after they were upheld by Malaysian courts.

Queries to Vedanta and petroleum ministry remained unanswered.

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Marico raises growth targets after strong Q2

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MUMBAI

Marico Ltd reported one of its strongest quarterly performances in years as easing copra prices lifted margins and enabled the maker of Parachute coconut oil to post record growth in July-September.

The company also raised its full-year growth targets, projecting mid-twenties growth in earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortization (Ebitda).

Consolidated revenue from operations rose 12.9% year-on-year to ₹3,897 crore in the July-September quarter, while net profit increased 29.1% to ₹ 558 crore. Domestic volume growth stood at 10%.

Ebitda rose 27% to ₹709 crore, its fastest growth in 10 quarters, while the Ebitda margin expanded 200 basis points to 18.2%.

"Supported by robust business fundamentals and disciplined execution, we expect to deliver teens revenue growth this year and comfortably cross the ₹15,000 crore revenue mark. We expect to achieve mid-twenties Ebitda growth in fiscal year 2027 (FY27)," the company said in a statement.

This marks an improvement over its outlook after the first-quarter results in August, when the company had guided for double-digit revenue growth and high-teen Ebitda growth in FY27.

"This improvement is driven by favorable product portfolio mix, improving profitability across our new growth engines and the benefit of softer copra prices," managing director and chief executive officer Saugata Gupta said in the post-results earnings call. The company increased advertising expenses by 44% in the period from a year ago.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

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Extracts of unaudited Standalone and Consolidated financial results for the quarter and half year ended 30th September, 2026

(₹ in lakhs)

Sr. No.	Particulars	Standalone			Consolidated		
		Quarter ended		Half year ended	Quarter ended		Half year ended
		30.09.2026	30.09.2025	30.09.2026	30.09.2026	30.09.2025	30.09.2026
		Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited
1	Total income from operations	36913.28	33274.44	74001.61	36913.28	33274.44	74001.61
2	Net profit /(loss) for the period (before tax, exceptional and /or extraordinary items)	7713.45	8975.57	18875.81	7713.04	8975.57	18875.40
3	Net profit /(loss) for the period before tax (after exceptional and / or extraordinary items)	7713.45	8975.57	18875.81	7713.04	8975.57	18875.40
4	Net profit/(loss) for the period after tax (after exceptional and /or extraordinary items)	6177.76	7043.85	14939.37	6177.46	7043.85	14939.07
5	Total comprehensive income for the period [comprising profit/(loss) for the period (after tax) and other comprehensive income (after tax)]	4773.80	5775.35	12157.62	4773.50	5775.35	12157.32
6	Equity share capital (Face value of ₹10 each)	20348.52	20348.52	20348.52	20348.52	20348.52	20348.52
7	Reserve (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Balance Sheet	262733.91	249865.57	262733.91	262733.61	249865.57	262733.61
8	Earnings per share from continuing operations (Face value of ₹10 each)						
	Basic	3.04	3.46	7.34	3.04	3.46	7.34
	Diluted	3.04	3.46	7.34	3.04	3.46	7.34

Notes:

(1) The above results, reviewed by the Audit Committee, have been approved by the Board of Directors in its meeting held on 2nd November, 2026 and have been reviewed by Statutory Auditors of the company. This statement has been prepared in accordance with the Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules, 2015 (Ind AS) prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 and other recognised accounting practices and policies to the extent applicable.

(2) The above is an extract of the detailed format of financial results for the quarter and half year ended 30th September, 2026 filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. Financial results in detailed format are available on the websites of Stock Exchanges (www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and on the Company's website (www.moil.nic.in).

(3) The Board has approved an interim dividend of ₹ 2.20 per equity share for the financial year 2026-27.

Scan QR Code for detailed Results

Place : New Delhi
Date: 2nd November, 2026

For MOIL Limited
Sd/-
V Suresh
Chairman-cum-Managing Director
DIN: 10059734

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ITC Limited

Extract of Unaudited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results for the Quarter and Six Months ended 30th September, 2026

(₹ in Crores)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Standalone			Consolidated		
		3 Months ended 30.09.2026	6 Months ended 30.09.2026	Corresponding 3 Months ended 30.09.2025	3 Months ended 30.09.2026	6 Months ended 30.09.2026	Corresponding 3 Months ended 30.09.2025
1	Total Income from operations	29125.19	56713.75	20340.97	31085.76	61264.77	21840.26
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before tax and Exceptional items)	5507.41	10266.82	6759.27	5720.28	11175.25	6890.60
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional items)	5481.75	10241.16	6847.35	5694.62	11555.47	6978.68
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional items)	4137.12	7715.94	5175.70	4229.33	8738.12	5186.55
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	3958.85	7980.78	4987.38	4096.24	8970.74	5051.18
6	Equity Share Capital	1253.05	1253.05	1252.71	1253.05	1253.05	1252.71
7	Earnings Per Share (of ₹1/- each) (not annualised):						
	1. Basic (₹):	3.30	6.16	4.13	3.32	6.83	4.09
	2. Diluted (₹):	3.30	6.16	4.13	3.32	6.83	4.09

Note:

a) The above is an extract of the detailed format of the Statements of Unaudited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The unaudited Financial Results and Segment Results were reviewed by the Audit Committee, and approved by the Board of Directors of the Company at its meeting held on 2nd November, 2026. The complete Statements of Unaudited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results are available on the Company's website at https://itcportal.com/investors/quarterly-results.html and on the websites of the National Stock Exchange of India Limited (www.nseindia.com) and BSE Limited (www.bseindia.com). The same can also be accessed by scanning the QR Code provided below.

b) Exceptional items in the Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results for the quarter and six months ended 30th September, 2026 represent expenses of ₹25.66 Crores incurred in relation to acquisition of the pulp and paper business of Aditya Birla Real Estate Limited, operated under the name of 'Century Pulp and Paper', and for the quarter and six months ended 30th September, 2025 represent final settlement of the insurance claim of ₹88.08 Crores towards leaf tobacco stocks, which were destroyed due to fire at a third party owned warehouse in an earlier year.

Further, exceptional items in the Consolidated Financial Results for the six months ended 30th September, 2026 also include gain of ₹405.88 Crores on remeasurement of the Group's existing interest in Sproutlife Foods Private Limited ('Sproutlife') in accordance with Ind AS 103 - Business Combinations, upon Sproutlife becoming a subsidiary of the Company.

c) The Limited Review for the Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results, as required under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, has been completed by the statutory auditors of the Company, who have issued an unmodified report on the same which has been forwarded to the Stock Exchanges.

Registered Office:
Virginia House, 37 J.L. Nehru Road,
Kolkata 700 071, India
Dated: 2nd November, 2026
Place: Bengaluru, India

For and on behalf of the Board

Sd/-
Director & Chief Financial Officer
(DIN: 01804345)

Sd/-
Chairman & Managing Director
(DIN: 00280529)

The Financial Results along with the Limited Review Reports have been posted on the Company's website at www.itcportal.com and can be accessed by scanning the QR Code.

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CIN: L16005WB1910PLC001985

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Audi Vorsprung durch Technik

Khambata exits Tata Trusts, slams 17 Sep 'day of infamy'

Darius Khambata was sharply critical about the Tata Sons board and two fellow Trustees

Varun Sood & Satish John
BENGALURU/MUMBAI

Senior Supreme Court lawyer Darius Khambata has chosen not to seek another term as a trustee of the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust, the two principal Tata Trusts, and termed "astounding" the Tata Sons directors' rebellion against Tata Trusts chair Noel Tata, which he said is 'a day that will live in infamy'.

In a four-page letter sent to Noel and Tata Trusts chief executive officer (CEO) Siddharth Sharma on Monday, Khambata was sharply critical about the Tata Sons board and two fellow Trustees, Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh.

"The sad events of 17 September 2026, a day that will live in infamy, have sullied Tata Sons' reputation and have imperilled the image of corporate India. No spin doctoring can mask what happened," Khambata wrote.

"Would the board of Tata Sons have acted as it did on 17 September, had Ratan Tata still been alive? Of course not. But duties are owed to institutions, not to individuals. And as Ratan Tata used to say, the institution is always bigger than the individual".

"In April 2026, contrary to unanimous resolutions they had been party to, Vijay and Venu suddenly told the media, though not their co-trustees, that they favoured listing, disregarding the Trusts' interests. They have not shared their reasons for this volte-face with either," he said.

Khambata's stint at both SDTT and SRTT, which own 27.98% and 23.56%, respectively, of Tata Sons, ends later this week. With him leaving, SDTT will have five trustees, while SRTT will have four. Besides Noel, Srinivasan and Singh, SDTT's two other trustees include Noel's son Neville Tata and former Titan Co. CEO Bhaskar Bhat. SRTT's four trustees are Noel, Srinivasan, Pune-based businessman and philanthropist Jehangir H.C. Jehangir, and Jimmy Tata.

Khambata's stint at both SDTT and SRTT ends later this week. BLOOMBERG

BOARDROOM BATTLE

DARIUS Khambata has chosen not to seek another term as a trustee of SDTT and SRTT

KHAMBATA sent a four-page letter to Noel and Tata Trusts CEO Siddharth Sharma on Monday

WITH Khambata leaving, SDTT will have five trustees, while SRTT will have four

HE questioned Srinivasan's choice to ignore the Trusts' instructions a day before 17 Sep meet

Khambata also questioned Srinivasan's choice to ignore the Trusts' instructions a day before the 17 September board meeting, where Srinivasan's key vote supporting Tata Sons chair Chandrasekaran helped him secure a third term.

"It is now untenable to say that a nominee director of a public charitable trust, particularly a sitting Trustee, may act against the Trust's interests merely because he also owes a duty to the company; he sits on that board precisely to protect the Trusts," Khambata wrote, citing an earlier ruling by the Supreme Court in Tata's earlier case against former chairman Cyrus Mistry. "There cannot be two classes of trustees," he wrote.

On the question of listing Tata Sons, Khambata described the Tata model as a "living example of Mahatma Gandhiji's trusteeship idea: India's most famous industrial and charitable group, a national treasure where neither part is important without the other". "That this model is now threatened by those who, ironically citing its success, would decouple Tata Sons from the Trusts, is not objective judgement," he said.

Khambata praised Noel's leadership, calling his two-year period 'eventful', which he handled with 'calm dedication'.

"My stand and approach has at times differed from others', including Noel's; I appreciate Noel's democratic acceptance of this. That is the old Tata way," Khambata wrote.

Khambata's decision not to seek another term at Tata Trusts comes about eight months after former Citibank India head Pramit Jhaveri also chose not to seek reappointment at SDTT.

Trustee appointments and reappointments require unanimous approval from all trustees. However, because Srinivasan and Singh's views don't align with those of the other trustees, Khambata's reappointment could have become problematic, according to an executive. For this reason, Khambata, despite being asked by Noel to continue, decided not to seek another term.

Srinivasan's current term at SRTT also ends in December, although his tenure at SDTT will end in November 2028.

The letter lands weeks before a 26 November Tata Sons board meeting, after Noel Tata wrote to the board on 26 October challenging the validity of the 17 September resolution.

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Behind the Maharashtra rule that stung key Tata trust

FROM PAGE 1

Experts said it was unusual to amend a law without a proposal from the regulatory body responsible for implementing it. BLOOMBERG

one-fourth of a public trust's total board strength, where its trust deed does not specifically provide for their appointment. The earlier law did not prescribe such a numerical cap.

"In the above context, it is hereby informed that no proposal has been submitted by the Charity Commissioner, State of Maharashtra to the state's Department of Law and Justice," the commissioner's office said on 15 October in a response to the *Mint* RTI query.

"Therefore, the records in this regard are not available in this office," it said in a letter drafted in Marathi, which *Mint* has translated. The charity commissioner's office reiterated its position in a subsequent email to *Mint* on Monday, adding: "However, the deliberations were made in the Law and Judiciary Department."

The amendment has prevented SRTT from conducting board proceedings, contributed to a deadlock at Tata Sons and stalled the company's annual general meeting , complicating efforts to resolve a leadership dispute.

The state's Law and Judiciary Department, which issued the ordinance, declined to provide details of how the amendment was drafted. Asked for copies of Cabinet proposals, stakeholder representations and lobbying records, and inter-departmental correspondence relating to the ordinance, it said work on the file was "in progress at the Government level" and the information could not be provided "at present".

Khambata questioned Srinivasan's choice to ignore Trusts' instructions a day before the 17 Sep board meeting

The ordinance made several changes to the law governing public trusts. The state legislature ratified it in December 2025 as the Maharashtra Public Trusts (Second Amendment) Act, 2025.

Experts said it was unusual to amend a law without a proposal from the regulatory body that implements it.

"Generally, the introduction of law or any amendments to existing laws are introduced with consultation of the regulatory body (state or central) of that law because ultimately, such regulatory body ensures the effective implementation of the law or its amendments," said Gaurav Pingle, partner at Forefront Legal Consulting LLP.

"In case of amendments, there could be reporting or disclosure requirements which would require the overview of the concerned regulatory body," he said.

The charity commissioner's office, however, functions under the state's Law and Judiciary Department. This differs from the institutional structure of federal regulators such as the Reserve Bank of India and the Securities and Exchange Board of India, whose offices are outside government ministries, even though the Centre appoints their heads and can issue policy directions.

Emails sent to Maharashtra's Law and Judiciary Department seeking comment went unanswered until press time.

The amendment became central to the dispute on 28 April, when Tata Trusts vice chairman Venu Srinivasan complained to the charity commissioner that SRTT's three permanent trustees were violating the law governing public trusts. SRTT had six trustees at the time. On 15 May, the charity commissioner ordered that the Trust could not hold meetings or take decisions while an investigation was under way.

The paralysis at SRTT has had consequences beyond the trust itself. Tata Sons' rules require representatives of both Sir Dorabji Tata Trust (SDTT) and SRTT to be present for a general meeting to proceed. With SRTT unable to take decisions or send representatives, Tata Sons' AGM was adjourned on 18 August for lack of quorum. It has also prevented shareholders from resolving a separate disagreement over Tata Sons' leadership.

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Reliance's best day in six years, LTCG relief hopes lift markets

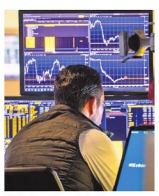
FROM PAGE 1

a gap-up and holding on to its gains through the session. RIL, Tata Steel and JSW Steel were best performers in the benchmark index.

"The index broke out of its recent consolidation range, extending its winning streak to three sessions and signalling an improvement in near-term buying sentiment," said Sudeep Shah, head of technical and derivatives research at SBI Securities.

He pointed out that the Nifty has also moved above the 38.2% Fibonacci retracement level after a sharp correction over recent months. This means the index has recovered over a third of its recent losses, indicating improving momentum and a potential turnaround in market sentiment.

From a technical perspective, Shah noted that RIL has seen a double-bottom neckline breakout on the daily chart, indicating a potential bullish trend reversal. The relative strength index (RSI) has moved sharply higher, reflecting a significant improvement in bullish momentum, he added.


Both benchmark indices rose nearly 2% on Monday. BLOOMBERG

Overall, Monday's move in Reliance has improved the near-term technical outlook for both the stock and the benchmark index, said Shah. However, a sustained move above the 200-day exponential moving average in Reliance, along with follow-through buying in the broader market, will be important to establish whether this recovery marks the beginning of a more durable trend reversal rather than just a sharp rebound, he said.

Positioning in RIL was "weak" ahead of Jio's listing, with some investors selling the conglomerate's shares to make room for Jio in their portfolios, said the managing partner of an advisory firm. "Monday's buying could partly reflect investors now moving to cover those positions," this person said.

RIL had undergone a prolonged correction time-wise and price-wise over the past few years and was trading near important long-term support levels, said Ruchit Jain, head - equity technical research, wealth management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services. The recent correction had also pushed momentum indicators into relatively oversold territory, he added.

Strong quarterly results have acted as a trigger for renewed buying interest, with the stock witnessing exceptional volumes, he noted. "Its strength is encouraging, although broader market participation will be important for a sustained recovery."

Although Brent crude fell nearly 4% to $108.64 a barrel on Monday as Iranian-Qatari talks raised hopes of easing Middle East tensions, oil prices remain a key variable for the market outlook.

Settle Tata dispute out of public view: FM

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Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday said the dispute within the Tata group should be resolved by the stakeholders themselves and kept out of the public eye, stressing that the conglomerate is too important to India's economy for a prolonged standoff.

"This is a very critical component of the Indian economy and therefore it has to be amicably settled among themselves," Sitharaman said at a *Financial Express* event in Mumbai. The issue "cannot be spilling out like this in the public," she added.

Calling the matter sensitive, the finance minister said a resolution would require business judgment and mutual goodwill. She declined to comment on whether the government would step in to facilitate talks between the two sides.

The dispute has centred on the reappointment of N. Chandrasekaran as chairman of Tata Sons and the debate over a potential IPO of the holding company. Tata Trusts, which owns 65.9% of Tata Sons, is opposed to a listing, although trustees Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh have supported the idea, *Mint* reported.

Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman. PTI

Senior Supreme Court lawyer Darius Khambata has chosen not to seek another term as a trustee of the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust, the two principal Tata Trusts, in a letter sharply critical of the Tata Sons board's 17 September decision to reappoint Chandrasekaran.

Calling the matter sensitive, she said a resolution would require business judgment and mutual goodwill

Speaking ahead of her tenth consecutive budget, Sitharaman also signalled that the government was listening to concerns over foreign portfolio outflows, though she stopped short of promising tax relief. She pointed out that the tax structure in 2023-24, when inflows hit a record, was the same as it is today, but said the situation had since shifted. "Circumstances have changed, challenges have grown, more FII (foreign institutional investor) outflows have happened," she said, adding that foreign investors had started returning.

The government had spent the last few years deepening the bond market, Sitharaman said, but there was now a demand that equities receive similar support. "I wouldn't want to say more at this stage, but I recognize the voice," she said, adding that taxation was only one part of the issue. Asked what the government could realistically do to win back foreign investors when US Treasuries offer attractive risk-free returns, she said it would first hear all stakeholders and then decide what it could act on.

On tax administration, the minister said the government's approach rests on trusting taxpayers, citing faceless assessment and the next-generation goods and services tax (GST) overhaul as examples, and that she would continue such reforms at the finance ministry.

Sitharaman also marked a shift in her view of private-sector investment.

Asked whether she was frustrated that industry kept seeking reforms without opening its purse strings, she said she would have agreed a couple of years ago. "But now I'm not going to say that, because I'm seeing industry come out," she said.

IDBI Bank employees strike over Fairfax acquisition

Bloomberg
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IDBI Bank Ltd employees started a two-day nationwide strike on Monday to protest against the planned privatization of the lender, calling on the federal government to scrap the sale to Fairfax Financial Holdings Ltd.

More than 10,000 staff across over 2,000 branches will participate in the agitation on 2 November and 3 November, according to a statement by the United Forum of IDBI Officers & Employees posted on social media platform X.

IDBI Bank's shares ended 2.1% lower in Mumbai on Monday compared to a 1.7% jump in the benchmark NSE Nifty 50 Index.

The strike comes just weeks after Canadian billionaire Prem Watsa-led Fairfax agreed to acquire a 60.72% stake in IDBI Bank, bringing the government's long-planned privatization of the lender a step closer to fruition.

The transaction will be the biggest foreign investment in India's financial services sector.

The employees questioned the transparency of the sale process.

The bank turned around following substantial public investment and sustained efforts by its workforce, the forum said, arguing that transferring control to a foreign entity raises "serious questions of public accountability and national interest."

After the deal was announced, Watsa assured employees there will be no job cuts, while the government pledged to protect their pension and service conditions, local media reported.

With themed meets, creators take the party offline to build brands

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MUMBAI

With millions of content creators competing for attention on social media, many are taking their digital communities offline through festivals, workshops, meet-ups and live events. The festive season has given this trend a further boost, with creators organizing themed gatherings around occasions such as Halloween and Diwali to engage followers. These events also offer creators an opportunity to diversify revenue streams beyond brand partnerships and platform monetization.

India's creator base has grown over fourfold, from 960,000 in 2020 to 4.12 million in 2025, according to a report by the Indian School of Business and HashFame.

"In a sea of content, a unique, well-executed offline experience is a powerful way for a creator to stand out, strengthen their brand and offer something truly exclusive. It's a move from a one-to-many broadcast model to a many-to-many community model," said Prachi Bali, executive vice-president & business head, Propagate India, Publicis Groupe India's full-stack digital agency.

Divay Agarwal, founder of Khoonl Monday, a horror storytelling YouTube channel with over 6 million subscribers, has taken his digital fandom offline with HorrorCon, a horror and pop-culture festival that taps into Halloween. Organized by his media firm The Mad Virus, the festival has live storytelling, cosplay, gaming and film screenings.

India's creator base has grown more than fourfold, from 960,000 in 2020 to 4.12 million in 2025. ISTOCKPHOTO

What began as a one-day pilot at Siri Fort in New Delhi in 2024 became a two-day festival at NSIC Grounds, Okhla, in 2025. This year, it was held at the same venue on 31 October-1 November, attracting over 25,000 people.

OFFLINE PIVOT

MANY creators are taking their digital communities offline through workshops, festivals, live events

CREATORS are organizing themed gatherings around occasions like Diwali to engage followers

Investment in HorrorCon rose 70% between 2024 and 2026, with over ₹3.4 crore spent on the festival's third edition in 2026, compared with approximately ₹2 crore in 2025.

"Ticket sales account for approximately 50% of HorrorCon's revenue, followed by brand partnerships at 40%. The rest comes from exhibitors, merchandise, retail and F&B partnerships," he said. HorrorCon's audience quadrupled from over 5,000 in 2024 to over 20,000 in 2025, while reported digital impressions across the editions exceeded 1.5 billion. The firm has an estimated valuation of over $10 million.

Creator-led live experiences are gaining traction as organised live events expand. The segment grew about 44% in 2025 to ₹14,500 crore, from ₹10,100 crore in 2024, and is seen at ₹19,600 crore by 2028, according to a Ficci-EY report.

For brands, these experiences also offer an opportunity to generate creator-led content that can be amplified. Travel influencer Isa Khan, with nearly 2 million Instagram followers, has partnered with brands such as Canon and Samsung to hold photography and content workshops. "This model allows creators to monetize their expertise... Brands in turn get an opportunity to engage with people genuinely interested," Khan said.

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The price of West Asia war is flashing on cement bags

Firms began raising cement prices in September, nudging them even higher in October

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The pressure comes as the turbulence in West Asia keeps the energy markets volatile. BLOOMBERG

Cement makers are banking on price increases to offset rising fuel costs, as higher energy expenses eat into margins amid steady demand and higher sales.

After keeping prices mostly unchanged during most of the quarter, companies began raising cement prices in September, nudging them even higher in October. The hikes are expected to boost December quarter realizations—net revenue from cement sales—helping manufacturers ease cost inflation pressure on profitability.

The pressure comes as the turbulence in West Asia keeps the energy markets volatile. With coal and petcoke accounting for a significant share of production costs, cement makers have limited room to absorb a sustained increase in fuel prices without compromising margins. Pet coke prices increased from $160 per tonne in March to $188 per tonne in October.

UltraTech Cement Ltd, India's largest cement maker, said average trade prices remained broadly stable during the September quarter, before beginning to recover towards the end of the period. In the second half of September, trade prices rose by ₹7-10 a bag from the preceding month, while non-trade prices saw sharper increases, chief financial officer Atul Daga said during the company's earnings call on 19 October. Trade prices are rates charged through dealers and retailers to individual customers, while non-trade prices are typically lower rates offered directly to bulk buyers such as infrastructure companies and large real estate developers.

Prices improved further in October, giving the company a better starting point for the December quarter.

"If demand overshoots supply, it leads to price improvements. If there is a structural change in cost for the industry, ultimately, the end customers will have to bear the cost," Daga said.

UltraTech's quarterly numbers show precisely the need for such pass-through. Its fuel and power expenses rose 24% year-on-year to ₹5,511 crore, while fuel cost increased to ₹51.50 a bag from ₹45, according to management.

Cement companies have taken price hikes primarily thrice this fiscal year. In April, prices were hiked by ₹10-15 per 50-kg bag, with some rollbacks in May and June. In July and August, prices remained stable, despite the monsoon season. In September, companies raised prices by ₹5-8/bag, and in October, by ₹10-12/bag, said Manish Valecha, co-head of research, Anand Rathi Institutional Equities.

Ambuja Cements Ltd, the country's second-largest cement maker, also expects the industry to push through further price increases as input costs rise. "We will see more progressive hikes expected in the coming months because the industry is going to pass on some of this cost to the customers if they are beyond a reasonable level," chief executive Vinod Bahety said during the company's earnings call on 29 October.

For Shree Cement, India's third-largest cement maker, the September quarter illustrated how higher volumes do not necessarily translate into better unit economics when costs rise faster than prices.

Domestic sales volumes grew 18% year-on-year to 9.31 million tonnes, while consolidated earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization rose about 4% to ₹1,016 crore.

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MARGIN HEAT

CEMENT prices rose ₹5-8 per 50-kg bag in September followed by ₹10-12 per bag in October.

PETCOKE prices climbed to $188 per tonne in October from $160 in March, adding to costs.

ULTRATECH'S fuel expenses jumped 24% year-on-year to ₹5,511 crore in the September quarter.

MANUFACTURERS expect further price hikes in the December quarter to protect margins.

Government vows to honour Scotch import commitments

Varuni Khosla
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NEW DELHI

All foreign companies import whisky from Scotland in large containers, bottle it at Indian facilities. ISTOCKPHOTO

The government has assured domestic liquor makers that the ambiguity over the customs classification of bulk Scotch whisky imports will be resolved amicably, three people aware of the matter said. The development came after the Union commerce secretary met industry representatives from the International Spirits & Wines Association of India (ISWAI) and the Confederation of Indian Alcoholic Beverage Companies (CIABC) on Monday.

The dispute centres on how bulk Scotch whisky imported into India should be classified for customs purposes. Under the FTA, import duty on eligible Scotch whisky fell from 150% to 75%, with a gradual reduction to 40% over 10 years. The industry argues that bulk Scotch, which is imported in large quantities and bottled here -- should also qualify for the lower rate because it remains Scotch whisky, irrespective of how it is shipped. But local tax authorities are exploring whether certain bulk imports should fall under a different Harmonized System of Nomenclature (HSN) classification that attracts the higher duty. The HSN code determines how an imported product is classified for customs purposes and, consequently, the duty payable.

The dispute centres on the customs classification of bulk Scotch whisky imported into India

Industry officials were informed that the government would honour its commitments under the India-UK free trade agreement (FTA), including on imports of bulk Scotch which came into effect 15 July, the people cited above said on the condition of anonymity.

"The ministry's commitment to honour FTA obligations, while safeguarding the interests of domestic alcobev industry, gives the sector the confidence it needs. We look forward to an early resolution that ensures business continuity," said CIABC director-general Anant S Iyer.

Queries sent to ISWAI and the commerce ministry went unanswered.

The industry bodies had earlier sought clarity from the commerce ministry on the customs classification of bulk Scotch whisky imports, a dispute that would limit the FTA benefits.

Meanwhile, lower import duties have started supporting margins for some companies.

Amar Sinha, managing director of Allied Blenders & Distillers Ltd, said the agreement could end up benefiting imported Scotch brands more than Indian liquor makers if bulk imports are excluded from the duty concession. "Nearly 80% of Scotch whisky imported into India arrives in bulk and is bottled locally, while only about 20% comes in finished bottles. Together, bottled-in-India and bottled-in-origin Scotch account for roughly 10 million cases in the country," Sinha said.

Under the current arrangement, all foreign firms import whisky from Scotland in large containers, bottle it at Indian facilities as well as mix it to make IMFL or Indian manufactured foreign liquor and sell it in the domestic market. But lower duties could make it cheaper to import fully bottled Scotch rather than bring in bulk spirit for local bottling.

"This could hurt domestic bottling operations and undermine the government's Make in India push," Sinha said. Indian spirits makers frequently utilize vatted spirits and blending techniques to make premium whisky products. A potential 150% duty could then erase the impact of the FTA and could also lead to more inferior imported brands coming into India, he added.

United Spirits, maker of McDowell's, Allied Blenders, maker of Officer's Choice, and Radico Khaitan Ltd said the tariff reduction had begun supporting gross margins to some extent.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

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Un-audited Consolidated Financial Results for the quarter and six months ended September 30, 2026

(INR in Lakhs except earnings per share data)

Particulars	Quarter Ended			Six Months ended		Year ended
	30.09.2026 Un-audited	30.06.2026 Un-audited	30.09.2025 Un-audited	30.09.2026 Un-audited	30.09.2025 Un-audited	31.03.2026 Audited
Revenue from Operations	13,281	12,330	13,179	25,611	24,224	48,873
Profit/(Loss) for the period (before tax and exceptional)	656	(186)	1,361	470	1,153	2,094
Profit /(Loss) for the period before tax (after exceptional)	656	(186)	1,361	470	1,153	505
Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after exceptional)	427	(193)	952	234	719	81
Total Comprehensive Income/(Loss) for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax and Other Comprehensive Income/(Loss) (after tax)]	331	(113)	1,034	218	849	396
Paid-up Equity Share Capital (Face Value - INR 2/- per share)	1,164	1,164	1,164	1,164	1,164	1,164
Other Equity excluding Revaluation Reserves as per the balance sheet				-		2,529
Earnings/(Loss) per share (of INR 2/- each)	(Not Annualised)	(Not Annualised)	(Not Annualised)	(Not Annualised)	(Not Annualised)	
Basic	0.73	(0.33)	1.64	0.40	1.24	0.14
Diluted	0.68	(0.33)	1.56	0.37	1.19	0.13

Notes:

1 The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Financial results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites (www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and on the Company's website "www.digicontent.co.in".

2 The above un-audited consolidated financial results for the quarter and six months ended September 30, 2026 were reviewed and recommended by the Audit Committee and were approved by the Board of Directors at their respective meetings held on November 2, 2026. The Statutory Auditors of the Company have conducted "Limited Review" of these results in terms of Regulation 33 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, as amended from time to time and have issued an unmodified review conclusion.

3 The consolidated financial results have been prepared in accordance with the Indian Accounting Standards ('Ind AS') prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules, 2015, as amended from time to time.

4 Additional Information on Standalone financial results is as follows:- (INR in Lakhs)

Particulars	Quarter Ended			Six Months ended		Year ended
	30.09.2026 Un-audited	30.06.2026 Un-audited	30.09.2025 Un-audited	30.09.2026 Un-audited	30.09.2025 Un-audited	31.03.2026 Audited
Revenue from Operations	29	30	30	59	61	119
(Loss) Before Tax	(233)	(216)	(177)	(449)	(482)	(1,018)
(Loss) After Tax	(233)	(216)	(177)	(449)	(482)	(1,018)
Total Comprehensive (Loss)	(233)	(216)	(179)	(449)	(482)	(1,017)

For and on behalf of the Board of Directors

Sameer Singh
Director
(duly authorised by Board of directors)
(DIN: 08138465)

New Delhi
November 2, 2026

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"REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL"

Nit & System No.	Project Name
NIT No.:6177/ योजना/म.प्र.टू.बो/ 2026 and SYSTEM No.-2026_ MPTB_547154 Dated 02.11.2026	1. Request for Proposal for Appointment of Agency for Development of Tourist Experience/Museum & Immersive Experience Centre and for Operations, Maintenance & Management of Ahilya Lok at Maheshwar, Madhya Pradesh, India.
NIT No.: 6177/ योजना/म.प्र.टू.बो/ 2026 and SYSTEM No.-2026_ MPTB_547162 Dated 02.11.2026	2. Request for Proposal for Appointment of Agency for Development of Experience Curation & Development for Immersive Experience, Interactive Exhibits in museum and for Operations, Maintenance & Management of Atal Smarak Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh, India.

MPTB invites offers for **"Request for Proposal for Appointment of Agencies for Execution/Development of projects as detailed above for Operations, Maintenance & Management of Ahilya Lok Maheshwar and Atal Smarak Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh, India"** The detailed terms & conditions can be downloaded from website https://www.mptenders.gov.in/www.tourism.mp.gov.in For any other information please contact. **Mob. No. +91-9993574567** or e-mail at **jdplg.mptb@mp.gov.in.** Last Date and Time for online submission of the RFP is 19.11.2026 @ 17:00 Hr.

M.P. Madhyam/128902/2026 **MANAGING DIRECTOR**

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EXTRACT OF THE UN-AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND HALF YEAR ENDED 30TH SEPTEMBER, 2026 | (₹ In Crore)

S. No.	Particulars	STANDALONE RESULTS					CONSOLIDATED RESULTS				
		FOR THREE MONTHS ENDED		FOR SIX MONTHS ENDED		FOR TWELVE MONTHS ENDED	FOR THREE MONTHS ENDED		FOR SIX MONTHS ENDED		FOR TWELVE MONTHS ENDED
		30 SEPT. 2026 (Un-Audited)	30 SEPT. 2025 (Un-Audited)	30 SEPT. 2026 (Un-Audited)	30 SEPT. 2025 (Un-Audited)	31 MAR. 2026 (Audited)	30 SEPT. 2026 (Un-Audited)	30 SEPT. 2025 (Un-Audited)	30 SEPT. 2026 (Un-Audited)	30 SEPT. 2025 (Un-Audited)	31 MAR. 2026 (Audited)
1	Total Income from Operations	2,373.21	2,351.36	4,527.25	4,500.89	9,059.45	2,378.57	2,354.53	4,538.33	4,508.16	9,078.97
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items and Share of net profit/(loss) of joint ventures)	461.91	504.29	826.52	850.82	1,623.34	454.14	497.58	814.25	846.62	1,620.90
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax, Share of net profit/(loss) of joint ventures(after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	461.91	504.29	826.52	850.82	1,623.34	454.14	497.58	814.25	846.62	1,620.90
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	347.16	376.75	624.81	634.46	1,221.81	353.66	379.98	622.56	647.26	1,245.74
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	349.66	383.99	629.82	640.73	1,240.93	356.19	387.18	627.55	653.43	1,265.64
6	Equity Share Capital	380.81	380.81	380.81	380.81	380.81	380.81	380.81	380.81	380.81	380.81
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year					12,508.91					12,561.54
8	Earnings Per Share (of ₹ 5/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) -										
	1. Basic (₹)	4.56	4.95	8.20	8.33	16.04	4.64	4.99	8.17	8.50	16.36
	2. Diluted (₹)	4.56	4.95	8.20	8.33	16.04	4.64	4.99	8.17	8.50	16.36

The Standalone and Consolidated Financial results of the Company for the quarter and half year ended 30th September , 2026 have been reviewed by Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors in its meeting held on 2nd November, 2026. The statutory auditors of the Company have carried out limited review of the above results for Quarter and half year ended 30th September, 2026.

Note : The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarter and half year ended Financial Results for September 30, 2026 filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly and Half Yearly Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchanges Websites www.nseindia.com, www.bseindia.com and on company's website www.concorindia.co.in

Scan the QR code to view the Un-Audited Financial Result

Place: Gurugram
Date : 2nd November, 2026

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Regd. Office: CONCOR Bhawan, C-3, Mathura Road, Opp. Apollo Hospital, New Delhi-110076
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For & on behalf of the Board of Directors
Sd/-
(Vivek Gupta)
Director(Finance) & CFO
DIN:11674836

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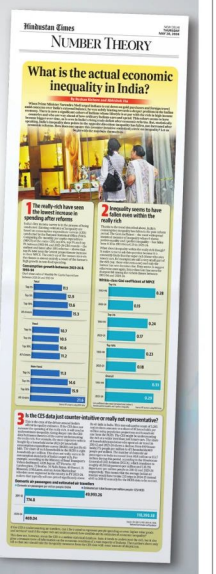
EVERYONE HAS A THEORY OURS HAS THE NUMBERS



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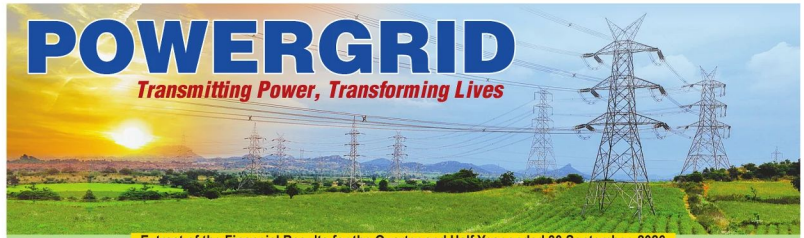

Extract of the Financial Results for the Quarter and Half Year ended 30 September, 2026 (₹ in crore)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Standalone					Consolidated				
		Quarter ended		Half Year ended		Year ended	Quarter ended		Half Year ended		Year ended
		30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	30.09.2025 (Unaudited)	30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	30.09.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)	30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	30.09.2025 (Unaudited)	30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	30.09.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)
1	Total Income	11,899.96	11,348.27	23,270.00	22,605.15	46,995.88	12,055.11	11,670.24	23,751.83	23,114.66	47,684.43
2	Profit before Tax and Regulatory Deferral Account Balances	4,369.26	3,744.13	8,615.58	7,916.40	16,759.10	4,568.44	3,878.17	9,155.76	8,163.92	17,321.03
3	Net Profit after Tax	3,819.08	3,554.80	7,230.03	7,208.03	15,921.00	3,866.16	3,566.08	7,464.58	7,196.66	15,927.95
4	Total Comprehensive Income comprising Net Profit after Tax and Other Comprehensive Income	3,872.49	3,600.98	7,323.51	7,443.92	16,066.78	3,897.32	3,612.26	7,424.53	7,433.60	16,193.78
5	Paid up Equity Share Capital (Face value of share : ₹10/- each)	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60	9,300.60
6	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Balance sheet	96,788.94	89,196.39	96,788.94	89,196.39	90,628.01	97,447.78	89,631.05	97,447.78	89,631.05	91,193.43
7	Securities Premium Account	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28	5,509.28
8	Net worth	1,06,089.54	98,496.99	1,06,089.54	98,496.99	99,928.61	1,06,748.38	98,931.65	1,06,748.38	98,931.65	1,00,494.03
9	Total Borrowings	1,51,207.00	1,35,922.87	1,51,207.00	1,35,922.87	1,48,009.01	1,51,207.00	1,35,922.87	1,51,207.00	1,35,922.87	1,48,009.01
10	Debt Equity Ratio	1.43	1.38	1.43	1.38	1.48	1.42	1.37	1.42	1.37	1.47
11	Earnings per equity share including movement in Regulatory Deferral Account Balances (Face value of ₹10/- each): Basic and Diluted (in ₹) *	4.10	3.82	7.77	7.75	17.12	4.16	3.84	8.03	7.74	17.13
12	Earnings per equity share excluding movement in Regulatory Deferral Account Balances (Face value of ₹10/- each): Basic and Diluted (in ₹) *	4.01	3.26	7.79	6.96	20.15	4.06	3.28	8.04	6.95	20.11
13	Bonds Redemption Reserve	2,440.10	2,938.95	2,440.10	2,938.95	2,721.31	2,440.10	2,938.95	2,440.10	2,938.95	2,721.31
14	Debt Service Coverage Ratio	1.56	1.80	1.46	1.33	1.54	1.65	1.90	1.55	1.37	1.61
15	Interest Service Coverage Ratio	3.51	3.75	3.52	3.87	3.93	4.25	4.36	4.29	4.49	4.57

(*) Figures for the quarters and half year have not been annualized

Notes :

1. The above is an extract of the Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulations 33 and 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The Complete Financial Results are available on the Investors section of our website https://www.powergrid.in and under Corporates Section of BSE Limited & National Stock Exchange of India Limited at https://www.bseindia.com and https://www.nseindia.com respectively. These can also be accessed by scanning Quick Response Code:
2. Previous periods figures have been rearranged/reclassified wherever considered necessary.

Place : Ajmer
Date : 01 November, 2026

For and on behalf of POWER GRID CORPORATION OF INDIA LTD.
Sd/-
Amol Babulal Taori
Director (Finance)
DIN : 11890590

पावरग्रिड POWERGRID

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Website : www.powergrid.in **CIN :** L40101DL1989GOI038121

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A Maharatna PSU

Companies have a solution for the shortage in skilled trade: more women

Te-Ping Chen
feedback@livemint.com

Sammy Cossairt has tried call center work, waiting tables and hoisting concrete. She prefers hoisting concrete.

The 36-year-old tower crane operator in Nashville, Tenn., who works 12-hour shifts, helps lift and move rebar and buckets of concrete from a perch often hundreds of feet in the air. This isn't what she envisioned when she received a liberal arts associate degree more than a decade ago, but after nearly a decade on the job, she feels at home in her crane.

"I'm out in the sun, making my mark on the world," said Cossairt, who makes $120,000 a year. "I think more women would love to get in and make men's money doing this work, if they only knew."

The skilled trades have long been a boy's club. But more women are breaking in, drawn by well-paying jobs that are in high demand. To keep them coming, many companies are courting women like Cossairt through new benefits and perks, including paid maternity leave and more flexibility. They are also trying to create a more welcoming work environment while cracking down on off-color jokes and catcalls on male-dominated jobsites.

The federal government tracks female participation in fields such as construction, and installation and repair, which includes jobs such as plumbers, carpenters and auto technicians. As of last year, women made up about 4.4% of those workers. But they have made mostly steady gains, with that figure rising from 2.9% a decade earlier.

As women make inroads in male-dominated fields, firms look to improve jobsite culture. ISTOCKPHOTO

At Universal Technical Institute's campus in Exton, Pa., career services director Katie Yurick said women are enrolling partly because the industry has grown more tech-infused. Automotive technicians can hook up cars to computers for diagnosis, and plenty of in-demand jobs—such as welding and electrical work—can trade as much on brains and attention to detail as brawn.

"These jobs aren't even dirty jobs anymore," said Yurick, adding that she has also heard from employers who say they are trying to hire women, believing they possess high maturity levels and are detail-oriented.

UTI's student body, which spans 17 campuses across the U.S., is now 8% female, quadruple what it was five years ago. In some areas, such as collision repair and auto refinishing, that figure is even higher, at 19%.

"Our industry needs this workforce," said Maja Ericksen, executive vice president at construction company Mortenson, which in 2024 began offering 12 weeks of paid leave for birth mothers in its skilled workforce. More than 10% of Mortenson's skilled workforce is now female, up from 7% a decade ago.

"There aren't too many careers you feel are AI-proof, and being in the skilled trades is one that isn't going away," Ericksen said.

Women have broadly outperformed men in the labor market in recent years. This partly reflects booming growth in fields that traditionally employ more women, such as healthcare and social assistance, while women also are making inroads in traditionally male-dominated jobs.

Kym Gardner, 39, a project engineer in Charlotte, N.C., said that as a child, she never thought about working in the field. Her mother was a teacher, her father a computer analyst. "No one really talked about it, it wasn't considered to be a career," she said. "The expectation was to go to college."

But in high school, she grew interested in architecture, found a construction mentorship program and quickly fell in love with seeing buildings rise from the ground up. Now the mother of three children, including a 5-month-old, starts her days on site and works remotely in the afternoons—flexibility she said helps give her peace of mind and ensures she doesn't have to sacrifice her caregiving duties.

Her company, Turner Construction, is growing fast and needs all the workers it can get, said president Abrar Sheriff. The company hit $29 billion in revenue last year and expects around $35 billion this year, fueled in part by work on data centers. More worker flexibility, including creature comforts such as heated and cooled bathrooms with running water on worksites, or regularly cleaned breakrooms, are part of the pitch.

"We need more people to come into our industry," Sheriff said.

Elsewhere, construction company Skanska has taken steps such as ensuring female employees have correctly sized gloves, helmets and work boots, rather than forcing them to make do with male-sized gear. Deila Ray, who spent a decade as a pipe welder and now teaches the trade in high school, said she had to shrink her own gloves with fire when she started in the industry.

Skanska this year also started mandating inclusivity for all its team leaders, encouraging them to be more aware of different workers' needs, said Ayesha Adams, who joined Skanska in 2023 as its inaugural director of culture and engagement.

"You can get people all day, but how do you keep them here?" Adams said.

Some states are trying to make work in the trades more accommodating for women. Both Washington and Illinois, for example, have in the last few years passed laws requiring nursing rooms for mothers on construction sites, as well as refrigerators to store breast milk, flexible break schedules and access to water for cleaning.

Construction companies are also tackling another issue: workplace harassment. At Turner, senior leaders there get on a call within four hours of any incident being reported. In one recent case in Texas, a subcontractor's entire project crew of around a dozen men were replaced when that company couldn't identify who had written derogatory graffiti about female employees, said Sheriff, Turner's president.

Part of the challenge is that it doesn't take aggressive comments to make a jobsite feel hostile, said Rebecca Heustess, 42, a tile foreman who makes $65,000 a year in Henry, S.D. Even after 20 years in the trades, she said she regularly encounters men who patronize her or ignore her instructions.

Still, she said she has thick skin and that the jobsite culture has slowly improved. She also loves the work.

"When I leave a job, it's this beautiful shiny sparkly project that I know will be there for years to come," Heustess said. "It's super fulfilling."

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.
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U.S. pushes to restore Russian gas sales to Europe via Ukraine

The idea for an energy ceasefire between Moscow and Kyiv faces resistance in Europe

Yaroslav Trofimov, Drew Hinshaw & Joe Parkinson

The U.S. is backing a quick resumption of Russian natural-gas sales to Europe via pipelines running through Moscow's wartime enemy—Ukraine—as part of negotiations aimed at securing an energy ceasefire ahead of the coming winter, according to U.S., European and Ukrainian officials.

The idea, broached by U.S. envoys Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff during trips to Moscow and Kyiv in September, would involve selling Russian gas via a U.S. intermediary to circumvent European sanctions—and could create a lucrative opportunity for American investors, people who attended the discussions said.

Under current European Union legislation, all purchases of Russian natural gas must be phased out by the end of 2027. Leaders of Europe's biggest nations have said that they have no interest in restoring their dependence on energy supplies from a country they view as their top strategic threat.

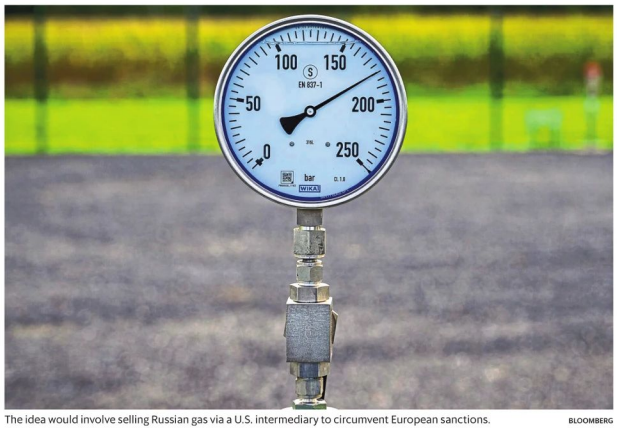
The plan was put on the back burner last month after Ukraine unilaterally stopped striking Russian refineries under pressure from President Trump . Kyiv paused strikes on Russian refineries for almost two weeks as Russia continued pounding Ukraine's energy infrastructure and as Moscow began shipping diesel to the U.S. The U.S. shifted focus to the possibility of a more substantial peace agreement.

Kyiv, however, resumed its air campaign on Friday, launching three attacks on three major Russian refineries in the past three days. This has brought new urgency to the pursuit of a more comprehensive energy ceasefire ahead of three-way peace negotiations that are planned between the U.S., Russia and Ukraine for mid-November in Abu Dhabi. Russia so far has rebuffed American attempts to strike such a deal.

In the view of U.S. negotiators, a Russian comeback to the European natural-gas market would create a powerful incentive for President Vladimir Putin to agree. Using the Soviet-era pipeline network that runs to Europe via Ukraine from the Urengoi gas fields in Siberia would also provide Kyiv with badly needed revenue from transit fees.

White House officials proposed that Russia deposit proceeds earned from these gas sales to Europe into an escrow account in a third-party jurisdiction, so that the Kremlin won't use the money to finance its war, said a senior U.S. official. They have tried to sell the idea to European leaders as a way to lower energy prices ahead of a winter when Europe's gas reserves have reached their lowest seasonal level in several years.

Such pressure represents a complete about-turn from Trump's first administration. Back then, Trump repeatedly chastised German Chancellor Angela Merkel for building the Nord Stream 2 pipeline from Russia. He warned that Nord Stream 2 would make Germany "captive to Russia," and, in late 2019, imposed sanctions on it.



The idea would involve selling Russian gas via a U.S. intermediary to circumvent European sanctions. BLOOMBERG

Just over two years later, Russia—its military funded by energy-export revenues—invaded Ukraine, betting that Europe wouldn't react because of its heavy economic dependence on Moscow.

The war, however, prompted the Europeans to view dependence on Russian natural gas a strategic vulnerability to a hostile power they no longer trust. The EU has passed legislation sharply curtailing Russian gas imports and outlawing them altogether by the end of next year. The current official European position is that the EU won't resume purchases of Russian gas even after a full peace agreement with Russia, let alone as part of a tenuous energy ceasefire that allows Putin to continue the war and provides funding for his military.

EU Energy Commissioner Dan Jorgensen , in an interview with a Hungarian newspaper in October that his office has confirmed, said the ban on Russian gas imports should be permanent.

"I certainly would not trust Russia. Even if there were peace tomorrow, which we all hope for," he said.

The Trump administration is wagering that European resistance will prove to be less rigid than meets the eye.

But in private, some senior European officials are more blunt. A senior Nordic official said the idea of resuming Russian gas purchases goes against everything the Europeans stand for, while a senior official from a large European nation compared it to former British leader Neville Chamberlain sacrificing Czechoslovakia to Hitler in exchange for business deals.

The U.S., for its part, now sees an eventual reopening of Nord Stream as a potentially important component of a larger deal, not just to end the war in Ukraine but to resolve Russia's long-standing friction with America's European allies. Merkel's mistake, a senior U.S. official said, was to pursue the pipeline without first working toward a wider security arrangement with Russia that Moscow could feel comfortable with.

A U.S. official said negotiators had discussed various economic proposals throughout negotiations. Europeans have expressed interest in a proposal that would drastically reduce gas prices across the continent, the official said, adding that any economic agreements would be part of a comprehensive peace deal.

Russia and Germany built the first Nord Stream pipeline to bypass the networks running via Ukraine in 2011. Nord Stream 1, which halted deliveries in August 2022, and Nord Stream 2, which was never put into operation, were badly damaged in underwater explosions attributed to Ukraine in September 2022. Restarting them would take considerable time, even if political and regulatory hurdles could somehow be overcome.

By contrast, the network running through Ukraine, with connections to Slovakia and onward to Austria and Germany, could be restarted almost immediately. Limited quantities of gas continued to flow through it until it was shut down in January 2025, well into the full-scale war between Russia and Ukraine.

Today, just 11% of Europe's natural gas comes from Russia, down from 45% on the eve of the war. U.S. liquefied-natural gas accounts for 30% of European consumption, while Russian gas is imported either via LNG tankers or through the TurkStream pipelines supplying Hungary and Slovakia.

The fallout from Trump's war on Iran could erode Europe's resistance, European officials acknowledge. Qatari liquefied-natural gas shipments remain bottled up inside the Persian Gulf, and a global surge in energy prices has continued even with more oil shipments passing through the Strait of Hormuz. Europe has spent an additional 100 billion euros, about $112 billion, on energy as the result of the war with Iran, according to the EU.

Europe's underground natural-gas storage is about 75% full, and the continent will enter the coming winter with stocks below the nine-year average, according to the EU's energy regulators.

Germany's main opposition party, the far-right Alternative for Germany, has already made the resumption of cheap natural-gas imports from Russia a key part of its campaign ahead of national elections slated for 2028.

It would be easier for Europe to change its position if Kyiv endorsed the gas sales as part of a ceasefire that would prevent energy blackouts and a possible humanitarian catastrophe in major Ukrainian cities, potentially triggering a new exodus of refugees in coming months, diplomats said. That is especially so as Ukraine has run out of air defenses, with the U.S. restricting supplies of Patriot interceptors amid a global shortage caused by the war on Iran.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.
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China's 5,000t digging machines trade war risk to India

Bloomberg
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China has gotten a lot of bargaining power out of its near-monopoly over rare earths. Now it's looking to repeat the trick in a more mundane industry—and perhaps squeeze a key Asian rival. Beijing's newest export controls target construction equipment—including tunnel-boring machines, some of the world's largest and most complex industrial devices. They're used to build subways or drill roads and railways through mountains. China dominates the global market and India is among its main customers.

Building sites might not be an obvious chokepoint in the global economy—unlike the AI technologies that Beijing has also proposed adding to its restricted list, or the rare earths used in smartphones and high-tech weapons. What's more, China's grip on this industry is strong but not absolute, and seeking to turn it into leverage could spur others to catch up.

"Beijing increasingly sees its position as a key global producer of construction equipment in strategic terms," said Kyle Chan, a fellow at the Brookings Institution. "It raises the risks of dependency, and incentivizes other countries to try to de-risk from China." Still, that's hard to do in the short run. Meanwhile wars in Ukraine and Iran have highlighted the growing military importance of underground facilities. And when it comes to India, there's a particular edge to the new curbs due to take effect later this month.

Beijing's newest export controls target construction equipment—including tunnel-boring machines. AFP

Along with tunnel-diggers, they apply to other construction equipment including machines for spraying concrete at high altitudes. Beijing invoked the potential for so-called dual use in military as well as civilian projects. It said "sensitive countries and regions with disputes with China" will face stricter rules. There are reasons for India's leaders to think this language points in their direction.

The Himalayan border between the world's most populous countries has long been a flashpoint and tensions there flared again just last week. India is building railway lines and roads in the area, with an eye on reducing troop mobilization times. They'll need a lot of tunnels.

The inclusion of high-altitude machinery could suggest particular attention to "strategically sensitive terrain," said Sun Chenghao, a fellow at Tsinghua University's Center for International Security and Strategy in Beijing.

"For China, the central concern is where Chinese engineering capabilities are used and whether they could strengthen another country's military infrastructure," Sun said.

China has flexed its muscle as chief exporter of tunnel-diggers in the past. In 2024 it delayed efforts by Germany's Herrenknecht AG — which manufactures some of its boring machines in China— to sell them to India, for use in projects like the Ahmedabad-Mumbai bullet train and the Delhi metro.

A spokesperson for Herrenknecht said the firm is studying the latest Chinese restrictions. For any "priority project," India can shift equipment from other sites, said Ajay Srivastava, founder of the New Delhi-based Global Trade Research Initiative. But there's another catch: China's new curbs apply to components too. "When there is heavy wear and tear in these machines we require regular supply of parts," Srivastava said, so there'll be an impact on the existing stock of machines as well as procurement of new ones.

The inclusion of high-altitude machinery could suggest particular attention to strategically sensitive terrain

India is far from the only buyer of China's tunnelling gear. Beijing state media put the country's global share of the industry at around 70%. The top producer, China Railway Engineering Equipment Group Co. Ltd, says its kit is used in 36 countries including Denmark and France. Besides Herrenknecht, there are other manufacturers in the US and Japan that build potential substitutes. In the long run, China's restrictions could prove a boon to some of them. But for most customers an immediate switch away from a Chinese supplier is difficult.

Apple's $1 tn rally leaves no room for error on earnings

Bloomberg
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The runup in Apple Inc. shares in recent months has left the iPhone maker little room for disappointment when it reports earnings after the bell on Monday.

The stock has climbed 25% from a low in late June, adding roughly $1 trillion in market value, as the company's steady revenue growth and rising free cash flow have offered a haven for investors balked by concerns about heavy spending on AI infrastructure by megacap peers like Alphabet Inc. and Amazon.com Inc.

The gains have left the stock trading at the priciest levels since 2008, making it particularly vulnerable if the company's results fall short of expectations. At 36 times earnings expected over the next 12 months, the shares are almost twice as expensive as the S&P 500 Index, according to data compiled by *Bloomberg*.

"Apple is in the 99% percentile of its historical valuation, and when something is priced so fully, there's risk if something unexpected comes along," said Ben Carew, co-chief investment officer at Tandem Investment Advisors, which holds the stock. "Right now it acts as a flight to safety, but if its growth is weaker than the market anticipates, that would make people feel it isn't as safe, and we could see the multiple get re-rated."

Apple stock has climbed 25% from its late June low. BLOOMBERG

It's a risk that should be familiar to Apple watchers. Three months ago, the stock suffered its worst one-day decline in 16 months after component shortages weighed on its quarterly revenue forecast.

Wall Street is expecting fiscal fourth-quarter revenue to rise 11% to $113.5 billion and net income to increase 6% to $29.2 billion.

While that would cap Apple's best year for sales growth since 2021 at 15%, the expansion is expected to slow in the next two years, according to the average of analyst estimates compiled by *Bloomberg*.

Apple's report will offer the first real insight into the popularity of its new foldable iPhone. The device went on sale last month and the company said demand has been "nothing short of extraordinary," with delivery times being pushed out to next year.

However, analysts believe that could reflect limited supply availability, while reports of Duo screens cracking after limited use could diminish the product's appeal among those who aren't early adopters.

While Apple's revenue growth lags behind most Big Tech peers, the company stands out in free cash flow, which has become a critical metric as investors turn skeptical of the AI spending spree.

NEWS IN NUMBERS

₹5,700 cr
THE ESTIMATED size of potentially fraudulent input tax credit in a suspected GST fraud network involving over 1,500 businesses, identified by Innefu Labs.

$12,000
CITIGROUP'S REVISED three-month price target for a ton of lithium carbonate, cut from $20,000 amid concerns over slowing battery demand.

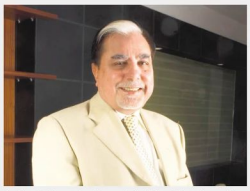
100 acres
THE SIZE of a new township that Reliance Foundation is setting up for orphaned children, senior citizens, and persons with disabilities.

€650 mn
THE VALUE of a naming-rights agreement AC Milan and Inter Milan struck with Italian insurance group Generali for their planned shared stadium.

$1.5 bn
THE AMOUNT Ambuja Cements said on Monday it would invest to increase its cement capacity to 155 million metric tonnes per annum by fiscal 2030.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

ED files case against Subhash Chandra



Subhash Chandra allegedly inflated his net worth to secure LICHFL loans, then defaulted. MINT

The Enforcement Directorate has registered a money laundering case against media baron Subhash Chandra in connection with an alleged loan fraud that caused a ₹1,322 crore loss to Life Insurance Corporation Housing Finance Limited (LICHFL), officials said on Monday.

Chandra is alleged to have inflated his net worth to avail loans from LICHFL and then defaulted on them. The officials said the case has been filed under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), taking cognisance of a CBI FIR.

Responding to the charges, a spokesperson for Zee Entertainment Enterprises Ltd (Z) said the ED filed the case against Chandra in his personal capacity and has no bearing on the company or its operations.

"The company would like to state that the matters pertain to Dr Subhash Chandra and the promoter entities and have no bearing on 'Z' or its operations in any manner," the spokesperson said. The CBI had earlier filed a case on the complaint of LICHFL, based on which the ED registered the money laundering case. PTI

Rupee falls 8 paise to 94.84/dollar

The rupee fell 8 paise to close at 94.84 against the US dollar on Monday, weighed down by a firm greenback in overseas markets.

Forex traders said the Indian rupee is showing signs of near-term stabilisation after recovering sharply against the US dollar in previous sessions.

A positive trend in domestic equities and softening of crude oil prices, however, cushioned the downside. At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened down at 94.90 and fell further to a low of 95.04 in intraday trade. The unit recouped some losses in the closing session to settle at 94.84, down 8 paise from its previous close. PTI

GSMA re-elects Vittal as chairman

Global telecom industry body GSMA's board of directors has re-elected Bharti Airtel executive vice chairman Gopal Vittal as chairman for the upcoming 2027-2028 term, until December 2028, the organisation said on Monday.

As GSMA chair, Vittal oversees the organisation's strategic direction, which represents the world's mobile operators and companies in the broader mobile ecosystem.

"I am honoured to be re-elected as chair of the GSMA board for a second time. As an industry, we are entering a new era in which advanced networks, artificial intelligence and open digital platforms can create significant economic and societal value," Vittal said. PTI

The deal was among a raft of agreements announced with the UAE. REUTERS

OpenAI, UAE state oil firm strike deal

UAE state oil company ADNOC on Monday announced a partnership with OpenAI, saying it would be the world's first energy firm to deploy OpenAI Frontier, an advanced artificial intelligence platform. The deal was among a raft of agreements announced with the UAE as OpenAI chief executive officer Sam Altman attended its flagship oil industry event in Abu Dhabi, which has bet heavily on the technology in a bid to diversify its economy away from energy. Gulf countries have been struggling to export oil since Iran began blockading the Strait of Hormuz, but the US military has been escorting ships through the route. ADNOC said in a statement that OpenAI's models would enable it to be "the first energy company in the world to use this technology to value every barrel while it is still in the ground".

The Abu Dhabi government and OpenAI were launching "the world's first AI-native Machine-Readable Government initiative", the emirate's media office said in a statement. The initiative will enable "AI-powered systems to assist officials with routine regulatory compliance assessments, including those related to issuing permits and certificates", it added. AFP

MINT

Adani's Mumbai airport capacity cuts face pushback

The dispute centres on MIAL's plan to shut Terminal 1 for redevelopment from April

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NEW DELHI

A proposed reduction in Mumbai airport's capacity from April 2027 has intensified a standoff between airlines and Adani Airport, with foreign carriers resisting a plan to shift part of their international operations to the newly opened Navi Mumbai airport.

The Airline Operators Committee-Mumbai (AOC-Mumbai), which represents 46 airlines operating from the airport, again approached the aviation ministry on Monday, seeking protection for existing flight slots. It has argued that airport operator Mumbai International Airport Ltd (MIAL) has not adequately justified the proposed cut.

The dispute centres on MIAL's plan to shut Terminal 1 for redevelopment from April and shift 265 of the 770 weekly international departure slots at Terminal 2 to Navi Mumbai, about 50 km away. The move would cut Mumbai airport's passenger-handling capacity by 5 million passengers a year. Adani is not looking to defer the redevelopment further.

MIAL is a joint venture between Adani Airport Holdings Ltd and state-run Airports Authority of India. Adani also operates Navi Mumbai airport.

In an email to civil aviation secretary Samir Kumar Sinha on 2 November, AOC-Mumbai described the proposed capacity cuts as unilateral and questioned the lack of justification and transparency.

"We are concerned about MIAL's decision to reduce airport capacity by 5 MPPA from S-27 (April), which was categorically communicated by its senior official to all airlines present at the meeting on 28 October 2026, as a unilateral decision, without adequate justification or transparent disclosure of the actual available capacity at CSMIA," the committee said. *Mint* has reviewed a copy of the email.

It also requested that "no historical slots be denied, reduced, cancelled or reallocated unilaterally, without due process and adherence to the MoCA and IATA Slot Guidelines". Under the guidelines, airlines that operate at least 80% of their allocated slots during a season are generally entitled to retain them for the corresponding season the following year.

For an extended version of this story, go to livmint.com

German firms seek banks for India IPOs

Two German companies, Mahle GmbH and Schott Pharma AG, are exploring initial public offerings of their Indian businesses that could raise as much as $400 million each, according to people familiar with the matter, as multinational firms seek to tap the premium valuations commanded by their locally listed peers. Schott Pharma executives met with investment banks last week for a potential IPO of Schott Pharma India Pvt, while auto-parts maker Mahle has invited banks to pitch for roles on a possible listing of its Indian operations this week, the people said, asking not to be identified because the discussions are private. Both Schott and Mahle are expected to appoint advisers soon, they said.

Deliberations are at an early stage and details including the size, structure and timing of the potential offerings could change, the people said. BLOOMBERG

Delhi's daily average AQI climbed to 324, triggering additional pollution-control measures. HT

Delhi air quality turns 'very poor'

Air quality in the national capital slipped into the 'very poor' category on Monday, prompting the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) to activate Stage-II of the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) across the National Capital Region (NCR) with immediate effect.

The city's daily average Air Quality Index (AQI) climbed to 324 on 2 November, triggering additional pollution-control measures.

The decision was taken by the CAQM's sub-committee on GRAP after reviewing the prevailing air quality and forecasts from the India Meteorological Department (IMD) and the Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology (IITM).

Delhi's AQI rose sharply from 117, in the 'moderate' category, on 31 October to 261, in the 'poor' category, on 1 November, before reaching 324, in the 'very poor' category, on Monday, according to the Central Pollution Control Board's (CPCB) daily AQI bulletin.

The CAQM attributed the deterioration to unfavourable meteorological conditions and said forecasts indicated that air quality was likely to remain in the 'very poor' category over the coming days. VIJAY C ROY

Bollywood fails with advance sales script

FROM PAGE 1

out looking full. The audience is wired the same way. A Marvel fan buys on the logo. Most of our audience buys on the trailer and the first reviews. A sales window can only be as long as the decision window, and ours is about two weeks," Misra explained.

Kamal Gianchandani, chief of business planning and strategy at PVR Inox Ltd, said the trend is also driven by consumer behaviour, as most moviegoers in India tend to book tickets and arrive at theaters at the last minute. He pointed out that prolonged advance sales serve primarily as marketing tactics aimed at hardcore fans.

Indian productions are simply not ready that far in advance, according to Sameer Munshi, chief operating officer of Miraj Entertainment Ltd. In contrast, Hollywood studios lock in release dates years ahead, sometimes even before filming begins, allowing their entire marketing apparatus to work backward from a fixed deadline.

"In Hindi cinema, we've at least become better at holding a release date once announced, even if it's locked only months rather than years ahead. But step outside Hindi and the picture changes quickly. For most regional language films, there's hardly any real system around locking a date early, and shifts happen right up to the last few weeks depending on censor board timelines, competing releases or even a bigger film moving into the same slot. That inconsistency alone rules out a 100-day commitment for a large chunk of Indian cinema," Munshi said.

There's also a trust gap. *Doomsday* carries two decades of connected storytelling, so audiences commit the moment a date drops, no trailer needed. Few Indian franchises have earned that blind faith yet, so marketing leans on trailers, music and a concentrated push close to release rather than long-range anticipation, Munshi pointed out. And a large part of the Indian exhibition network still isn't built for a uniform, long-window booking system.

Industry experts said that for a genuinely longer advance booking window to take hold, Indian cinema requires franchises with Marvel-level trust, and studios comfortable locking in release dates long before a film is completed, rather than after. That gap is expected to narrow as pan-India franchises mature.

Release dates frequently shift around box-office clashes and festival windows. MINT

That said, *Doomsday* also highlights another key difference, according to Rohit Dalmia, chairman and managing director of entertainment financing platform CineNow. With more than 70% of its early ticket sales reportedly driven by premium formats, Disney is not merely selling standard seats months in advance; it is monetizing scarcity around an event experience for a massive, established global fanbase.

"Indian cinema certainly has franchises capable of creating similar excitement, but a five-month booking window introduces refund risk, schedule-change risk and the possibility of front-loading demand without necessarily increasing total admissions," Dalmia said. India is more likely to adopt a phased model than immediately move to 100-day nationwide bookings, he added.

For films such as Ramayana, Pushpa, KGF, or those helmed by marquee names like SS Rajamouli or Shah Rukh Khan, producers could potentially release limited premium inventory—such as IMAX screenings, luxury formats, fan premieres, or select opening-weekend shows—significantly earlier, while keeping the broader show schedule to open closer to release.

"That would allow studios to measure genuine demand, create marketing momentum, and generate early cash without requiring every exhibitor to commit an entire programming schedule months in advance. *The Doomsday* example is particularly useful because its early strategy concentrated on premium inventory. India could adopt the same principle: sell certainty early, allocate flexibility later," Dalmia said. "Over time, better demand forecasting, digital ticketing data, and more screens should make longer booking windows easier," he added.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Tata battery JV's China director leaves

FROM PAGE 1

According to company filings with the corporate affairs ministry reviewed by *Mint*, the two firms had entered into an intellectual property agreement in FY26 covering two types of lithium battery technologies for electric vehicles (EVs), nickel manganese cobalt (NMC) and lithium ferrous phosphate (LFP) battery technologies.

Agratas is looking to scale up battery manufacturing, with a 20 GWh plant in Gujarat and a 40 GWh facility in the UK, with Jaguar Land Rover lined up as its first major customer as part of a ₹5,000-crore deal between the two firms.

The board member's exit is significant because AESC's presence on the board gave the technology partner a say in Agratas' strategy and growth plans as the company prepares to begin manufacturing and scale up operations. *Mint* could not independently ascertain why Chin, who serves as AESC's general counsel, stepped down.

As per the filings, Chin joined the board in December 2024 as an additional director after AESC picked up a 12% stake in Agratas. He was later appointed a director in July 2025.

Agratas and AESC declined to comment on the issue. "AESC does not comment on the details of commercial arrangements with individual partners. Questions about Agratas's board composition are best directed to Agratas," a spokesperson for the company told *Mint*.

Mint reported first in August 2025 that AESC had joined the board Agratas with a 12% stake.

In an earlier statement to *Mint*, AESC had said it has not invested in Agratas and that its shareholding was the result of a commercial arrangement between the two firms.

Founded in 2023, Agratas is among the Tata Group's newest businesses set up under chairman N. Chandrasekaran, alongside Tata Digital and Tata Electronics. The venture is part of the group's push to build domestic lithium-ion battery manufacturing capabilities, joining Reliance Industries Ltd in efforts to develop a technology and supply chain long dominated by Chinese companies.

According to Agratas' FY26 filing, the company had six directors on its board as of 31 March: chaired by Chandrasekaran, with JLR chief executive P.B. Balaji, Sucharita Choudhury (Tata Sons president of corporate affairs) and Gordon Chin serving as non-executive directors, and N.V. Sivakumar (former PWC executive) as an independent director. Thomas Flack is the managing director and CEO of the firm.

The filings show Chin had attended all the four meetings held by the Agratas board in FY26, indicating a close involvement with the firm.

Agratas said it was investing in R&D facilities and personnel to absorb the technology shared by its partner and build internal capabilities in battery manufacturing.

AESC, meanwhile, described the arrangement as a joint venture in its UK filings, saying the partnership was set up to design, develop and manufacture battery solutions.

The boardroom exit also brings the role of technolgy partnerships in Agratas' manufacturing plans into focus.

"Companies developing cells at scale could benefit from having an engineering, sourcing or supplier-development presence there, or from structured partnerships with Chinese technology and equipment companies," said Alekhya Datta, director at electricity and renewables division at The Energy and Resources Institute (Teri). "The important point is that such a presence should have a clear technology-absorption strategy: Indian engineers learn the process, develop suppliers and bring that capability back into Indian plants."

The financial filings of Agratas' Indian parent show the company had recognized ₹317 crore in services received from AESC Apollo in FY25, which fell to ₹186 crore in FY26. The Indian company's outstanding trade payables, the money owed, to AESC Apollo were down to ₹5 crore as of March 2026, from ₹38 crore a year earlier, the filings showed.

The other remaining payments to the technology partner are linked to capital expenditure, which declined to ₹297 crore from ₹430 crore in FY25. It includes estimated payments for milestones that had not been achieved by the end of the fiscal year.

Strategic shift

AESC's presence on the board gave the technology partner a say in Agratas' strategy and growth plans.

- **11 December 2024** — AESC and Agratas enter into a joint venture agreement
- **12 December 2024** — AESC's Gordon Chin joins Agratas board as additional director
- **31 March 2025** — AESC gets 12% stake in Agratas
- **18 July 2025** — Gordon Chin elevated to director
- **24 August 2026** — Agratas details role of AESC, says IP agreement in place
- **1 October 2026** — Gordon Chin leaves board of Agratas

Source: AESC, Agratas filings

mint

HOW POLICY CAN TACKLE THE DEMOGRAPHIC RESET

Policymakers must address three tracks of a resetting demographics, while ensuring inter-generational well-being.

HowIndiaLives.com
feedback@livemint.com

The dominant demographic story about India is that it is a country of young people. Statistically, that is true: India's median age is estimated to be 29.2 years. It has close to a billion people of working age (15 to 64 years). But that is set to change. There are slow, yet significant, shifts in population structure that will lead to a demographic transition in the coming years.

To understand why, visualize the country in terms of three age slabs: children (0 to 14 years), working-age population (15 to 59 years) and older adults (60 years and above). The number of babies born in India peaked sometime in the early-2000s; by 2011, the share of children in the population had started declining. The share of working-age adults in the population is projected to peak by 2031, and then decline slowly.

As people live longer and fewer children are born, the share of those aged 60 and above—currently, about 10% of the population—is projected to double after two decades. These trends are all occurring at different speeds. By 2047, the target year to attain *Viksit Bharat* (developed India), all three shifts will be well under way. The result is that India will move towards a very different population structure.

This is not a crisis. Demographic shifts occur slowly, so there is a long runway before India loses its "youthful" profile. But being aware of how the arithmetic is changing is crucial to rework policy priorities. The needs of each demographic cohort—children, working-age adults and the elderly—are distinct, yet deeply interconnected. This calls for a three-track policy approach, with each track geared towards managing the demographic reset, while ensuring inter-generational well-being.

POPULATION REBALANCING

The first track could focus on fertility, but viewed through the lens of population rebalancing, rather than population control. Research this year from the Economic Advisory Council (EAC) to the Prime Minister suggests that despite a steady decline in population growth, existing population schemes are driven by the old fears of a "population explosion". As a result, national family planning programmes reward terminal methods such as surgical sterilizations.

These methods appear misplaced in the current scenario, when the total fertility rate (TFR)—the average number of children a woman would give birth to during her lifetime—is declining. It has even dropped below the replacement rate (TFR of 2.1 needed for a generation to replace itself without accounting for migration) in some states. For instance, Andhra Pradesh achieved below-replacement fertility more than two decades ago, largely by encouraging female sterilization. By 2024, nearly 70% of married women in the state were sterilized. Yet, it budgeted to incentivize more sterilizations per capita as compared with Uttar Pradesh, which has a higher fertility rate and where only 17% of married women have undergone sterilization.

The good news is that states have started changing their approach to population management. For instance, in 2026-27, Andhra Pradesh has not budgeted any fiscal resources to incentivize male or female sterilization (EAC working paper). Telangana and Rajasthan have withdrawn the two-child norm for local elections, and Madhya Pradesh for government jobs.

> A new Keralam law proposes a comprehensive legal framework, including registration and regulation of elder care centres, and legal assistance to the elderly

However, these policies are unlikely to result in a jump in births. Developed countries have tried monetary incentives for decades with almost no impact. Demographers cite a tipping point of 1.5. Once TFR goes below that level for an extended period, it alters social norms and pushes countries into a low-fertility trap (*Lutz, Skirbekk, and Testa, 2006*).

Data from the Sample Registration System (SRS) showed that eight states had slipped below the TFR tipping point by 2024, led by Delhi, Kerala, Telangana and West Bengal. It is likely that more states have followed or will follow. This is a vicious cycle: the rarer it is to have children, the less likely are future generations to become parents.

A pro-natal stance could reverse this doom loop by setting up "network effects"—in effect, by making it more common and normal to have more children. Indeed, social scientists note that the decision to have children is strongly influenced by friends, peers, and colleagues (Cavendish, *Financial Times*, 2026).

ELDERLY LIVING

The second policy track should focus on the elderly. A recent study of longevity in India suggests that older adults want to do well along four dimensions: economic security, freedom to participate in work or community service, health and well-being, and social connectedness (Rohini Nilekani Philanthropies, Dalberg Advisers, Ashoka Changemakers, 2026). Ageing-related initiatives could address these gaps while drawing on international best practices. Policies for older adults could therefore be shaped around two broad ideas.

One, unlike in the West, families are the primary caregivers for most aged Indians. Notwithstanding the rapid growth of senior living homes, sending elders into such communities is not popular, with most households preferring to rely on external informal help if required. This underscores an urgent need to develop a dependable and affordable body of caregivers.

Keralam has taken the lead by passing a landmark law for elderly care last month. The law proposes a comprehensive legal framework, including registration and regulation of elder care centres, improvement in care-giving training and standards, and provision of financial and legal assistance to the elderly. A recent report by Niti Aayog set out a comprehensive framework for caregiving, highlighting the need for standardized training, accreditation and quality assurance, and improved remuneration and career paths for caregivers. If implemented, the recommendations will go a long way towards creating a robust caregiving ecosystem.

Other countries offer insights on supporting home-based elder care. China has a 9073 elder care model: 90% of the elderly are cared for at home, 7% in community care and 3% in elderly-living institutions. After a decade of pilot testing, China formally launched a long-term care insurance system this year to provide professional services or financial support for basic nursing and care, including home-based care, for the elderly and disabled. The scheme is expected to achieve nationwide coverage by 2028.

Singapore's policies aim to promote inter-generational care. To enable older adults to age in their own homes, the government of Singapore provides "proximity" housing grants to help adult children live near their parents; and grants tax relief to eligible working mothers if grandparents provide childcare.

In the Indian context, given the government's fiscal constraints and comparatively lower household incomes, neither scheme can be directly transplanted. But they can be tested in specific states or districts. For example, grants that enable multiple generations to live near or with each other may reduce outmigration of young adults from tier-II and tier-III cities. Alternatively, states could incentivize elder-friendly housing for multi-generation families in satellite towns to take the pressure off crowded metropolises.

ALL-ROUND HEALTH

Two, many older adults face health challenges, which adds to the financial and emotional pressures of elder care. The healthy life expectancy at birth for Indians—the number of years a person can live with full health—is merely 58 years, much lower than the actual life expectancy of 73 years (WHO). India offers limited health coverage for all senior citizens above the age of 70 years under the Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana, and there is little effort to promote preventive healthcare. For instance, over 23% of adults aged 60 years or more were estimated to be overweight, leading to higher risk of diabetes and cardio-vascular disease.

Measures such as the creation of safe public spaces where older people can be physically active, community centres for social and intellectually stimulating activities, and vigorous campaigns to drive healthier food choices could improve health outcomes for the elderly. The efforts could be initiated by states and handed over to the private sector, and could count as corporate social responsibility (CSR) initiatives.

Accredited Social Health Activists (ASHAs) have the potential to facilitate ageing-related initiatives on the ground, as they already engage routinely with families for maternal and child health services. ASHA workers may be retrained to provide geriatric advice, screen for simple age-related ailments and guide towards early treatments. In ageing southern states, some ASHA workers may be trained exclusively for geriatric care, and incentivized with additional remuneration to make this shift.

This is a proven strategy: community health workers have been successfully deployed for preventive elder care in many countries. In Indonesia, the Posbindu programme provides community-based health promotion, disease prevention, and health screening services for the elderly. Nepal, culturally close to India, has gone a step further by mobilizing active older adults to serve as community health volunteers to promote health education and good practices. This aligns with what the average older adult wants: research suggests that one in three elderly Indians would like an opportunity to volunteer (RNP, etc., 2026).

Combating loneliness is another important dimension of elder health care. To this end, Vietnam is experimenting with state-funded daycare centres that provide health services, companionship and care to seniors. Singapore has over 200 active ageing centres across the island that offer activities to boost the physical, mental and social health of seniors. Keralam, in collaboration with NGOs, runs "Pakal-veedu" day care centres, which provide food, healthy activities, and counselling for the elderly; it is working to upgrade some of them into fully-equipped community resource centres. To be sure, there are multiple citizen-driven groups working in eldercare in other states, but formalizing these efforts through official channels, as Keralam is doing, could have a greater impact.

Social messaging, backed by actual action, can change the narrative around ageing. The experience of older adults brings crystallized intelligence into organizations and communities. Businesses can tap this wisdom by retraining and reskilling older employees. Programmes in continuing education and lifelong learning could be initiated by the government but supported (including with training resources) by the private sector.

India already has a large network of non-government organizations, private sector initiatives and citizen-led efforts to address the needs of its elderly population. The Niti Aayog's Darpan portal lists over 100,000 non-profits working in this sector. What is missing is coordination, information sharing and collective action by the various actors in this sector. Therefore, creating common platforms that pool insights could help the government, private sector and NGOs to work together.

CITIES FOR WORKFORCE

The third and most important policy track should address the working population. This cohort is crucial as it supports both children and older adults. Here India can take a leaf out of China's playbook, which aims to build "youth-development oriented cities"—places where young adults want to work, live and raise families.

To this end, Chinese cities compete to offer the best deals: temporary free accommodation for job seekers, subsidized youth hostels, and family-friendly public spaces and activities. China has also linked its old and young astutely by pledging to convert its "silver economy" into an economic engine by 2035. To this end, the government is encouraging a range of eldercare products and services, including technology embedded care services, elder-friendly products, rehabilitation aids, and humanoid robots. The silver economy provides careers to the young and the end-output eases quality of life for the elderly—a win-win solution.

India has taken some steps in this direction: the government's Senior-care Ageing Growth Engine (SAGE) scheme, launched by the Department of Social Justice and Empowerment, supports startups focused on developing products for senior citizens. Given that Niti Aayog estimates the size of the silver economy to be over ₹73,000 crore, clearly, there is potential to encourage more entrepreneurship and innovation in this sector.

India's demographic reset calls for a shift in thought and design of policy. Specifically, policies for each age group must align with the overall goal of achieving a balanced population pyramid. A fertility policy that enables families to have the number of children they desire, an ageing policy that allows older adults to live with health and purpose, and a workforce policy that supports care responsibilities can reinforce one another. Together, these three tracks can ensure that each generation is supported without placing an undue economic or social burden on the other.

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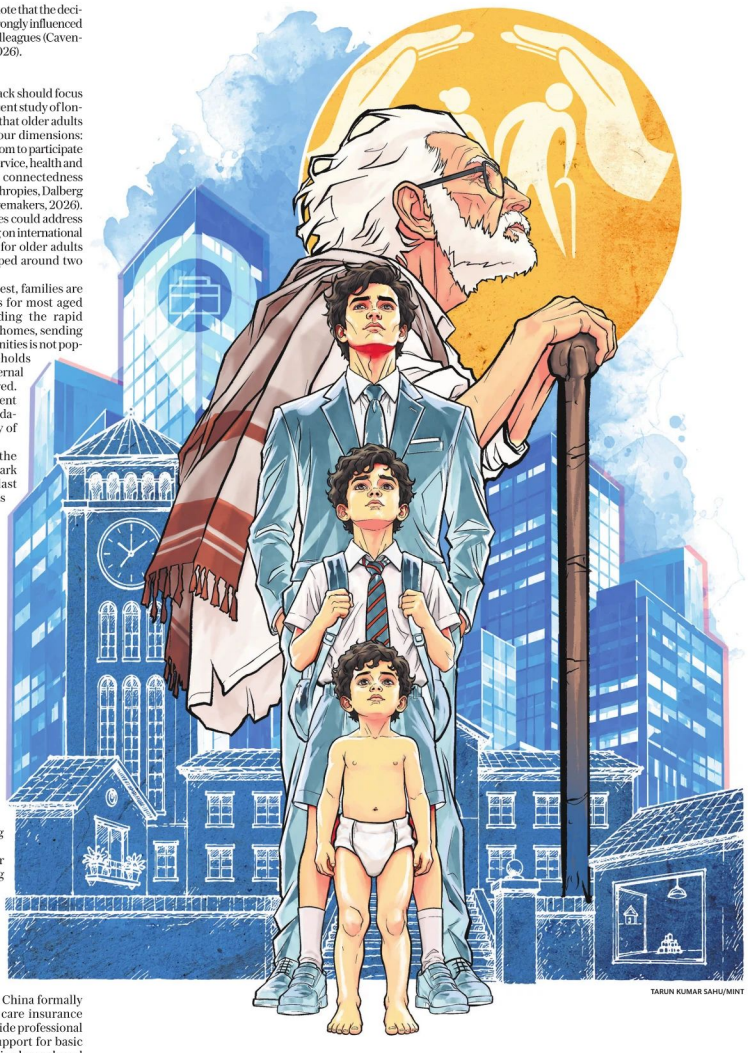

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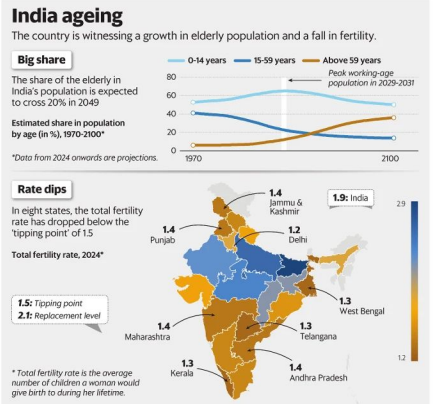

mint KEY NUMBERS

29.2 YEARS

India's estimated median age. The country has close to a billion people of working age (15 to 64 years) today.

10%

Current population share of Indians aged 60 and above. The percentage is projected to double by 2050.

58

Number of years Indians can expect to live with full health. Actual life expectancy is 73 years, per the WHO.

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Festive splurge: celebrate without compromising financial security

About 83% of surveyed Indian households plan to dip into savings to fund festive purchases, raising concerns

Ananya Grover
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MUMBAI

The festive season traditionally brings the highest consumer spending among Indian households. A recent report by YouGov and Rukam Capital found that 60% of Gen Z shoppers increase their spending during major festivals, with 25% spending significantly more and 35% somewhat more, reflecting the pull of festive consumption.

But the world around us is changing. News of layoffs in the IT sector, muted salary hikes and inflation inching up again warrant a closer look at how households spend and splurge. We spoke to individuals to gauge the mood and to experts on how households should respond to this changing financial climate.

Why people splurge

Diwali is usually when families want to celebrate, buy something new and gift friends and relatives. The festive spirit makes spending part of the occasion. Preeti Zende, a Sebi-registered investment adviser and founder of Apanadhan Financial Services, said people also tend to spend impulsively because of the fear of missing out (FOMO) fuelled by social media influencers, especially during the festive rush.

Many people also have extra money in hand through bonuses or variable pay, which can tempt them to treat it as "free money" for celebrations, said Arindam Banerjee, professor and programme director of the Masters of Applied Finance & Wealth Management at SP Jain School of Global Management, rather than save or invest it.

The market is designed to reinforce this mood. Retailers, banks and digital platforms all target consumers with offers during this period, lowering their resistance to spending. "Cashback, no-cost EMIs, limited-time deals and social pressure all arrive together," Banerjee said.

In a normal year, Banerjee added, this may be manageable for a household with a stable income. But this year, households may need to tread more carefully before committing to large purchases.

What's different this time

In fact, many households have already begun exercising financial prudence. According to Sachin Taparia, founder and CEO of LocalCircles, urban households are likely to spend an average of ₹20,000 this festive season, down from around ₹45,000 last year. They are scaling back mainly on big-ticket purchases, with no tax tailwind comparable to last year's GST cuts and credit becoming costlier after the RBI's 7 October rate hike, adding to pressure on household budgets.

In its latest survey, LocalCircles found that 31% of the 22,904 respondents had no discretionary spending planned this festive season. "People are not making big-ticket purchases as phones and appliances have become costlier, anxiety about white-collar job security is making employees hold back and small business owners are also facing competition from quick commerce giants," Taparia said, pointing to broader economic anxieties.

The steady stream of layoff announcements in the IT sector is adding to the uncertainty. US-based AI firm Innodata abruptly fired nearly 550 Indian employees on Monday, while Microsoft has extended a massive global voluntary exit offer to its 23,000-strong Indian workforce, with a 1 December deadline. Oracle has downsized about 10% of its local team, or roughly 3,000 employees, in its latest engineering-heavy job cuts.

> **Job uncertainty, muted salary hikes and rising inflation are also prompting some families to rein in festive spending**

Reports indicate that it may extend a Voluntary Separation Programme (VSP) to remaining Indian managerial roles as it builds out massive AI data centre infrastructure, deepening concerns over job security.

Banerjee explained that when an IT professional loses a job, the financial shock extends well beyond the individual. Many households have a home loan, a car EMI, school fees and often parents in another city to support. A mid-level professional who loses a job may also take longer to find an equivalent role than during previous downturns. Households should therefore plan for a longer period without income rather than assume a quick recovery, he said, especially given the uncertain hiring outlook.

That is exactly what Savrat Vaish, a Delhi-based sales manager, is planning to do. He intends to put most of his Diwali bonus into savings and is also cutting down on midnight food orders and designer clothes. "I want to enjoy Diwali, but also maintain financial discipline amid the uncertainty," he said, putting long-term security first.

Saurabh Singh, an assistant finance manager, is also cutting out unnecessary expenses. He plans to avoid excess spending because he has several expenses lined up for which he has been saving through mutual funds from an early age. Even while redeeming his mutual funds, he has decided to not use the entire funds but deploy a portion of it along with his Diwali bonus back into investments when the timing is right, keeping future financial goals in focus.

Spend without the hangover

Even as LocalCircles' survey points to lower spending this season, a large section of households will still fund festive purchases, to varying degrees, from their savings. In the survey, 83% of the 23,451 respondents said they planned to dip into savings to some extent, while 16% said they would rely entirely on savings to fund their spending. That is a worrying sign, given the uncertain income outlook.

For those considering dipping into savings, Taparia poses an important question: "How many more festivals can you celebrate from savings unless your earnings increase?" The concern extends beyond one festive season to long-term financial security.

Using savings to fund festivities can leave household finances nursing a hangover long after the celebrations are over.

According to Banerjee, savings act as insurance against income loss. Using them for discretionary purchases now means entering what could be a difficult few months with a thinner financial cushion. "If celebrations must be funded, use the monthly surplus and leave the reserve alone," he said, to preserve financial resilience.

But households should be careful not only about dipping into savings. Purchases financed through credit offers such as no-cost EMIs also need scrutiny. EMIs and festive financing can make a ₹1.2 lakh television feel like a ₹10,000-a-month decision.

"The problem is that the EMI lasts long after the festival and if your income stops in month three of a twelve-month plan, you are left with nine payments and no salary," Banerjee said, turning a short-term indulgence into a liability.

Anurag Mehra, director of Expert Panel, a debt resolution and loan management platform, said aspirational consumers looking to upgrade often take loans during the festive season, particularly when they have limited savings and are drawn to advertised no-cost EMIs or e-commerce sales.

"Consumers should therefore assess the total cost of borrowing, their existing EMI commitments and their repayment capacity before taking a festive-season loan," he said, to avoid straining future cash flows.

Banerjee recommends a simple discipline: set a fixed festive budget in cash or a separate account, wait 48 hours before making any purchase above a predetermined amount, and pay upfront wherever possible, rather than rely on easy credit.

Families dependent on the IT sector that receive a festive bonus or variable pay this year should put 70% directly into a liquid emergency fund and reserve 30% for gifts, sweets and celebrations. "That way the family still celebrates, and most of the windfall goes toward protecting against a possible income gap next year," Banerjee added.

Zende advises households to plan well in advance and start shopping a few months before the festival. This spreads expenses over time and reduces the temptation to buy impulsively out of FOMO. Festivals come around frequently, she said, and overspending on one occasion can make the following months harder, when routine expenses resume.

If a deal or offer is too good to pass up, she said it is acceptable to tap the emergency fund, provided households have the discipline to replenish it in the next quarter. She also cautions against pausing investments and recommends that at least a third of the Diwali bonus should go towards topping up existing investments, to maintain long-term financial discipline.

None of this means having a joyless Diwali. It is about enjoying the season while staying mindful of the financial realities of the moment. This year, the best buy may be a bigger financial cushion for the future, rather than another expensive indulgence that offers fleeting gratification.

Scan the QR code to read an extended version of this story.

Don't let Diwali dent your savings

As households rethink purchases and dip into savings, here's a checklist to assess whether your Diwali spending is stretching your finances.

Sticking to essentials

Savrat Vaish (28)
Sales manager

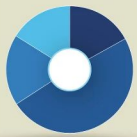
"I am cutting back on midnight food orders and designer clothes advertized on Instagram."

Saurabh Singh (28)
Assistant finance manager

"I am sticking to essential expenses and have postponed buying electronics until next year."

Dipping into savings

% of households that that plan to dip into their savings to fund festive spending this season and to what percentage



Number of responses: 23,451

Source: LocalCircles 2026 Mood of the consumer survey

The festive spending test

Is your festive shopping stretching your finances? If you answer yes to most of these questions, take a hard look at your festive spending and consider cutting back.

- Am I buying something I could comfortably do without?
- Am I rushing to buy because of a limited-time deal or FOMO?
- Can I afford this without exceeding my festive budget?
- Would paying for this require dipping into savings earmarked for other purposes?
- Will I need an EMI or credit because I cannot comfortably pay for it upfront?
- Would the repayments be difficult to manage if my income were to stop temporarily?
- Am I buying this before giving myself 48 hours to think it over?
- Am I spending my Diwali bonus even though my emergency fund needs strengthening?
- Would my emergency savings after this purchase cover less than six months of essential expenses?
- Will I have to pause investments or delay an essential payment to afford this?

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POWER POINT
SHYAM SEKHAR

We welcome your views and comments at
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COULD INVESTORS BE WARMING UP TO LARGE-CAPS AGAIN?

Mutual fund investing has rarely been as skewed as it is now. Capital has persistently chased small- and mid-cap funds, with lump-sum investments flowing into these categories. Investors have shunned blue-chip-heavy large-cap funds, while much of the incremental SIP growth has also come from small- and mid-cap schemes. The prevailing belief was that large-caps could no longer match their growth potential.

Strong inflows helped small- and mid-cap stocks remain resilient for several quarters. However, two factors have changed the picture: a sharp spike in commodity prices and the hefty valuation premium these market favourites command over the rest of the market. Discerning investors are trimming positions in overvalued stocks, while selling pressure is mounting on companies that disappoint even marginally on quarterly results. Investors are also factoring in the impact of sustained commodity inflation on demand, sales growth and margins.

Meanwhile, falling large-cap valuations have widened the gap with market favourites. Investors are increasingly recognising the appeal of large-caps, given their discount to historical valuations, potential to revive growth and superior balance sheets. They also have the capacity to return capital through share buybacks. Management-led buybacks remain a possibility despite investor apathy.

Promoters are increasing stakes in bluechips through preferential issues. Bajaj Finance is a prime example. In deeply unpopular sectors like life insurance, promoters are raising stakes at historically low valuations. ICICI Life is another example. Management teams and boards are signalling confidence in companies whose merits the market continues to overlook. Yet, this has not translated into broader investor interest. Aversion to large-cap investing remains at a historic high.

> Low valuations, strong balance-sheets and buy-back potential are boosting bluechip appeal

Early signs of rotation

The tide could be turning, although it is too early to call. The sharp correction in September and October has revived the question of whether blindly buying small-cap funds at any valuation can continue to work. The absence of growth in large-caps, coupled with relentless foreign institutional investor (FII) selling, continues to weigh on performance and sentiment. Mid-cap and small-cap fund performance has also begun to weaken this results season.

Companies held by these funds are being punished for missing stretched expectations. Stocks are falling even when quarterly performance is reasonable, while earnings disappointments are triggering sharper drawdowns as investors unwind positions they once held with conviction. This erosion of conviction carries a broader warning for investors bidding up IPO prices on listing and chasing companies reporting strong quarterly results during favourable earnings cycles.

Meanwhile, falling valuations are creating contrarian opportunities in several cheap bluechips, though buying remains selective. The recent IT stock rally shows how confidence can return to a sector that was widely disliked after a sharp correction.

The growth question

Recovery will be slow and painful, with investors having to climb a wall of fear. Still, fatigue with expensive small- and mid-caps could trigger a rotation towards attractively valued large-caps. The sharp rebound in bluechip IT stocks could spread to other beaten-down sectors where valuations are difficult to ignore. Uncertainty over when growth will return in consumption and pharmaceuticals, and when net interest margins and return on assets will improve in banking and financial services, remains the main obstacle to this rotation.

As visibility improves, more signals will provide directional confidence. Growing scepticism towards overvalued companies could redirect capital towards businesses where value is more evident. Even small positive developments could attract investor attention, while relatively minor negatives may be overlooked.

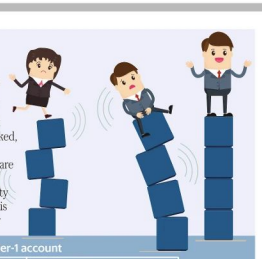
Investors could gradually begin bargain-hunting in bluechips. Slowly, the wheels of the market would start turning.

For now, investors are only beginning to reassess their aggressive investment stance as overvalued stocks weaken. The rest of the results season could accelerate this shift. Mutual fund investors may need to review and reposition their portfolios before the tide turns decisively.

Shyam Sekhar is chief ideator and founder of ithought Financial Consulting LLP.

Check how your NPS investments are faring

There are very few retirement products that help you accumulate a retirement nest egg and one such product is the National Pension System (NPS). It is a market-linked, defined-contribution product that needs you to invest regularly in the funds of your choice. The returns are based on the performance of the fund that you choose. There are eleven pension fund managers to choose from and one of the ways to do that is by tracking the returns. Here is a breakdown of the performance of different funds—equity fund, government bond fund and corporate bond fund—of the private sector NPS. This NPS table show returns for pension fund managers who have completed at least 1 year



Returns (in %)

Fund Manager	Tier-1 account: Equity fund 1 year	Equity fund 3 years	Equity fund 5 years	Government bond fund 1 year	Government bond fund 3 years	Government bond fund 5 years	Corporate debt fund 1 year	Corporate debt fund 3 years	Corporate debt fund 5 years
Axis Pension Fund Management	-9.66	7.93	-	1.14	5.92	-	2.53	6.83	-
Aditya Birla Sun Life Pension	-6.44	9.29	8.17	1.16	6.3	5.72	2.14	6.79	6.08
DSP Pension Fund	-9.65	-	-	0.82	-	-	2.77	-	-
HDFC Pension Fund	-8.45	9.35	7.9	0.94	5.84	5.32	2.68	7.17	6.36
ICICI Pru. Pension Fund	-7.73	9.9	8.67	1.37	6.09	5.48	2.96	7.11	6.23
Kotak Mahindra Pension	-10.41	9.11	8.35	0.85	5.62	5.24	3.23	7.15	6.21
LIC Pension Fund	-8.88	8.52	7.85	0.91	6.17	5.6	2.42	6.74	5.92
SBI Pension Funds	-7.67	7.26	6.92	1.04	6.25	5.58	2.92	7.13	6.21
Tata Pension Fund	-7.11	10.8	-	0.5	5.69	-	2.22	6.91	-
UTI Pension Fund	-9.26	9.85	8.48	1.12	6.21	5.64	2.93	7.02	6.12
NPS Equity Index	-8.3	9.61	8.24	NPS Govt. Security Index 0.98	6.48	5.71	NPS Corporate Bond Index 2.58	6.55	5.97
Benchmark index									

Non-Government POP returns data as on 31 October 2026

Source: Npstrust.org.in

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How to value foreign partnership interests

Harshal Bhuta

ASK MINT
NRI TAXATION

I returned to India in 2018 after working in the US, having become a partner in a Delaware LLP while a non-resident. I have not disclosed this investment in my Indian tax returns and now wish to declare it under FAST-DS 2026. Since the LLP closes its accounts on 31 December, how should I calculate my investment's value as at 31 March 2026, as required under the scheme?

– Name withheld on request

Under FAST-DS 2026, a taxpayer can declare foreign assets acquired using income earned outside India while a non-resident, which were not disclosed in Schedule FA after becoming an Indian resident. This is subject to the condition that the asset's value as at 31 March 2026 does not exceed ₹5 crore. Since you contributed capital to the US-based LLP while a non-resident and did not disclose your partnership interest in Schedule FA after returning to India, you would be eligible to declare it under the scheme, subject to the valuation limit.

The FAST-DS Rules, 2026 prescribe a specific process for valuing your LLP interest. First, determine the LLP's net assets as at 31 March 2026. Since the LLP follows a calendar-year accounting period ending on 31 December, its books will not ordinarily close on valuation date. However, a statement of accounts reflecting its assets and liabilities as on 31 March can be prepared. The scheme does not specifically require audited financial statements for valuation.

Once the net assets as at 31 March 2026 have been determined, the rules require a two-stage allocation:

• First, an amount equal to the LLP's capital is allocated among the partners in their capital-contribution ratio.

• The remaining net assets are then allocated in the dissolution entitlement ratio or, if the agreement does not specify such a ratio, in the profit-sharing ratio.

• Sum of the two amounts allocated to a partner constitutes the value of that partner's interest. Accordingly, the total amount allocated to you under these two steps represents the value of your partnership interest in the LLP for the purposes of FAST-DS 2026.

If the value of your partnership interest does not exceed ₹5 crore, you are eligible to declare it under FAST-DS 2026 by paying the prescribed fee of ₹1 lakh.

Harshal Bhuta is co-founder and country co-head, International Tax and FEMA at Ascentium India.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at **mintmoney@livemint.com** and get them answered by industry experts.

OUR VIEW

MINT

Empowering mayors to lead Indian cities

State governments need to give up control over urban land, institutions, and resources, so that city governments are able to fulfil their mandate and deliver local services effectively

Speaking at the National Urban Conclave in Odisha, Niti Aayog member Rajiv Gauba said that India's cities should not be governed from state capitals. Reiterating the recommendations of a Niti Aayog report on city governments, Guaba called for directly elected mayors with five-year terms, stronger municipal finances and devolution of responsibilities to local governments.

More than three decades after the 74th Constitutional Amendment recognized municipalities as institutions of self-government and identified 18 functions for devolution, elected city governments remain weak. A 2024 CAG review found that typical municipalities fully controlled only 4 functions. Essential responsibilities—including urban planning, land-use regulation, water supply, sewerage, major roads, public transport, slum improvement and fire services—remain partly or wholly with state agencies. Residents may prefer better drainage to a flyover or reliable buses to a metro system. These choices depend on local circumstances. Yet, these decisions are often made by different state agencies that are not accountable to local governments. Within municipal corporations, state-appointed commissioners often wield far more authority than elected mayors. Citizens confronting flooded streets or unreliable buses are unable to demand accountability from local councillors.

Elected mayors can make a difference, but only if they have control over personnel, budgets and key civic departments. Stronger executive authority must be matched by municipal council scrutiny, transparent budgets and community participation. What matters is a coherent structure of power and accountability, not merely how mayors are elected. Finances are equally important. Estimates suggest expenditure by local governments accounts for just over 1% of GDP in India, while their employees account for just over 10% of all public employees. In contrast, local governments account for more than half of public spending in China according to a paper titled 'City power and urban fiscal crises: the USA, China, and India.'

For long, state governments have complained of being under-funded by the Union government. Yet states now account for over 60% of government expenditure, among the highest shares globally. It is time they extended to local governments the empowerment they have demanded for themselves, and now enjoy.

The principle of subsidiarity provides a guide: decisions should be taken at the lowest level capable of handling them effectively. India's urban future will be shaped by countless decisions about streets, buildings, services and neighbourhoods. Those decisions need institutions close enough to understand local needs and accountable enough to respond.

The Union government could encourage reform by linking urban mission funding to measurable devolution, financial transparency and regular elections, as Gauba suggests. But the critical decisions rest with states, which have been reluctant to relinquish control over urban land, institutions, and resources. The political challenge is for a state government to empower cities early in its term, make the new arrangements deliver results, and earn political dividends in subsequent elections. If even one chief minister delivers on this agenda, it would serve as a role model for the entire country.

GUEST VIEW

We need caution in interpreting India's festive consumption rise

Demand is up but is being funded through savings and gold loans even as income growth is weak

KRITIMA BHAPTA
is a research associate, Centre for Social and Economic Progress.

India's festive season is round the corner, and as every year, it is being closely watched as a test of consumer spending. Early indicators point to a strong season. Wholesale vehicle shipments to dealers hit record levels in September, while retail sales reached 11.23 lakh over the 10 festive days including Navratri and leading up to Dussehra.

This raises a natural question: how are households financing this spending, particularly when income growth for large sections of the population has remained modest?

Measuring festive consumption directly is difficult. Therefore, motor vehicle sales serve as a good proxy. They are among the largest discretionary purchases Indian households make, many timed to coincide with Navratri, Dhanteras and Diwali.

They also allow us to distinguish between income groups. For example, passenger cars largely reflect the purchasing power of the salaried, upper-income urban households, especially sport-utility vehicles (SUVs), while two-wheelers are a closer measure of rural, semi-urban and informal demand.

This Navratri was driven by mass-market buyers. Its fair comparison would be with Navratri 2024, since last year's festival lasted a day longer and coincided with goods and services tax (GST) cuts, prompting many buyers to make purchases that they had been putting off. This made last year's retail sales unusually high, and thus set up a high statistical base for comparison with this Navratri. Sales this year, as a result, show a 6.5% fall from last year.

Against 2024, however, retail data issued by the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations shows two-wheeler registrations rising by over 32%, compared with 10% for passenger cars. Does this mean rural, semi-urban and informal consumers are finally earning more?

Income trends suggest not. In each of the past five years, rural wage growth has stayed between 4% and 6.6% and rural inflation between 5% and 6.9%, so pay has just kept pace with prices. To cope with this prolonged squeeze, households drew on their savings. Household net financial savings fell from around 7.9% of gross domestic product (GDP) in 2018-19 to 5.3% in 2022-23. They have since recovered to 7% in 2024-25, but are still below pre-pandemic levels.

With incomes rising slowly and savings yet to be rebuilt, the strength of festive demand points to another source of financing: household borrowing or retail credit.

In 2023, the Reserve Bank of India tightened prudential rules for banks on issuing unsecured personal loans and credit cards, thereby raising the cost of such loans. The measure had its intended effect. Credit card debt, which was growing at over 31% a year during the 2023 festive months, slowed to under 18% a year later and to under 5% in 2025. Figures for this year's festive months are not yet out, but in August, card balances grew just 3.6%, suggesting that households have become more cautious about taking on debt or that banks continue to be careful about lending.

The broader credit data, however, point to a change in what households borrow against. Lending against gold jewellery had risen 7% over the 2023 festive months and 61% over those of 2024; in 2025 it grew about 127%. Figures for 2026 stop at August, but the pattern holds: in the year to August 2026, gold lending was up 83% and card balances 3.6%. Higher gold prices explain only part of this increase. Even after adjusting for prices, the physical volume of gold pledged with banks has grown around fourfold since 2019.

Aggregate data cannot, of course, link an individual gold loan to a particular purchase, and money is fungible across household needs, including informal businesses. Lenders, though, have begun to say so themselves. Piramal Finance estimates that 15-23% percent of the industry's new gold loans in 2025-26 went to people already three months behind on another loan. Nevertheless, the sharp slowdown in card borrowing, occurring at the same time as a steep rise in gold-backed credit, suggests that many households have substituted one form of borrowing for another in order to sustain consumption.

This has two implications.

First, policymakers need to be careful in how they interpret household financial health. A slowdown in credit card debt does not mean that households are borrowing less. The risk has not disappeared; it has simply shifted from the swiping machine to the bank vault.

Second, while gold-backed lending is considerably safer for banks than unsecured credit, it leaves household finances heavily exposed to a single asset class. If global gold prices correct, the cushion supporting this consumer credit could weaken.

Strong festive sales are a welcome boost for the economy. The more important test, however, lies beyond the festive season: whether consumption can be sustained by broad-based income growth, rather than by financial workarounds and borrowing against family gold.

These are the author's personal views.

10 YEARS AGO

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Earnings pick up in Q2, but no turnaround yet

JUST A THOUGHT

"Building sustainable cities— and a sustainable future— will need open dialogue among all branches of national, regional and local government.

BAN KI-MOON

MY VIEW | MUSING MACRO

Don't give up capital gains tax due to rupee weakness

AJIT RANADE

is senior fellow with Pune International Centre

Persistent foreign selling of Indian equities has revived demands to reduce or abolish long-term capital gains (LTCG) tax. Another proposal is to keep the tax but impose it only on the foreign investor's dollar gains. This would ensure their taxes get reduced to the extent rupee depreciation eats into their profits. These demands arise from a genuine concern about weakening capital inflows and the consequent pressure on the rupee. But surrendering a substantial revenue stream would leave the underlying causes of rupee pressure largely untouched.

LTCG tax revenue yielded ₹1.29 trillion in 2024-25, up from ₹72,249 crore the previous year. These collections came both from domestic and foreign investors. Hence, any proposed concession needs a reliable estimate of revenue forgone and evidence of the additional investment it would attract. Naive expectations that foreign money will return cannot substitute for that assessment.

There is also a basic question of fairness. Tax on LTCG is a direct tax similar to that on salaries, profits and interest. Income from rising share prices should contribute to public revenue too. Complete exemption would unfairly favour listed equities over other investments. Moreover, greater dependence on consumption taxes, and tilt toward indirect taxes, places an unfair and relatively heavy burden on poorer households.

What motivates foreign investors? They undoubtedly consider the tax regime. They also compare earnings prospects, valuations, exchange rates and opportunities elsewhere. It is not clear whether an LTCG cut alone can bring them back. Chief economic advisor V. Anantha Nageswaran has said that the boom in global artificial intelligence (AI) investments is a hurdle in attracting capital, since India is not yet an AI investment destination. Also, risk-free yields have risen globally. Hence, a modest tax concession cannot reliably overcome these issues.

Indian equities remain expensive due to heavy domestic buying. Monthly systematic investment plan contributions have grown to more than ₹32,000 crore. Sustained domestic demand absorbs foreign sales and supports high valuations. That is another factor influencing overseas investors. However, domestic purchases cannot replace the foreign exchange that leaves the country when foreign investors withdraw. Equity prices and the rupee can, therefore, face different pressures.

Pressure on the rupee has also come from the steep fall in net foreign direct investment (FDI). Despite healthy gross inflows, stronger outflows due to repatriation and Indian companies investing abroad caused net FDI to fall to close to zero in 2024-25. The policy task is to make domestic opportunities also sufficiently attractive as foreign ones. It is net, not gross inbound investment, that provides external financing, which is crucial to plug the current account deficit. What is left is plugged through a drawdown of reserves.

When portfolio investors withdraw and other inflows prove inadequate, the rupee faces pressure. Expensive imported oil compounds the problem. Persistent inflation above trading partners' levels can weaken the currency over time. Additionally fiscal expansion, which raises demand without corresponding supplies, can increase imports and inflation. Investors assess these conditions alongside the credibility and predictability of policy. Rupee pressure, thus, has multiple causes.

Such a move raises several questions while offering no assurance of protection for the rupee

The proposal to tax foreign investors only on their dollar gains is also problematic. Recall that a foreign investor assumes currency risk voluntarily. It is possible to cover that risk by buying a forward cover. But if an investor chooses to stay unhedged, then that choice should not justify a tax concession when faced with a currency loss. Covering the currency risk of a foreign investor is a burden on the Indian exchequer.

Domestic savers also bear the consequences of depreciation through costlier imports and reduced purchasing power. They have no comparable claim to adjust every taxable receipt for movements in the dollar. Preferential treatment for foreign investors would need a stronger justification than disappointing returns. Further, exemptions reserved only for foreigners could encourage round-tripping, wherein domestic investors send funds overseas and bring them back under a foreign identity.

Greater currency stability requires price stability, credible fiscal management, predictable regulation and attractive domestic investment opportunities. Stability does not mean defending a particular exchange rate regardless of changing economic conditions. The Reserve Bank of India's sale of reserves helps reduce volatility. But its currency management cannot replace external earnings and investment inflows.

Export earnings provide foreign exchange and cushion against any change in investor preferences. Strengthening exports is a priority, and there have been encouraging signs. Trade agreements also help. Trade policy needs emphasis on competitiveness, which rides on infrastructure, affordable imports and ease of doing business.

Tax policy must provide continuity. Since investors make long-term commitments, repeated changes in rates and holding periods complicate their decisions. Tax concessions can't be knee-jerk reactions. The issue of securities transactions tax should not be mixed up with LTCG. India needs a stable capital gains regime and a credible response to currency weakness. Sacrificing the former offers no assurance of securing the latter.

MY VIEW | STAT-CRAFT

India is escaping poverty but is it turning economically secure?

The World Bank's findings on falling poverty are welcome but we need to ensure that people who exit poverty don't slip back

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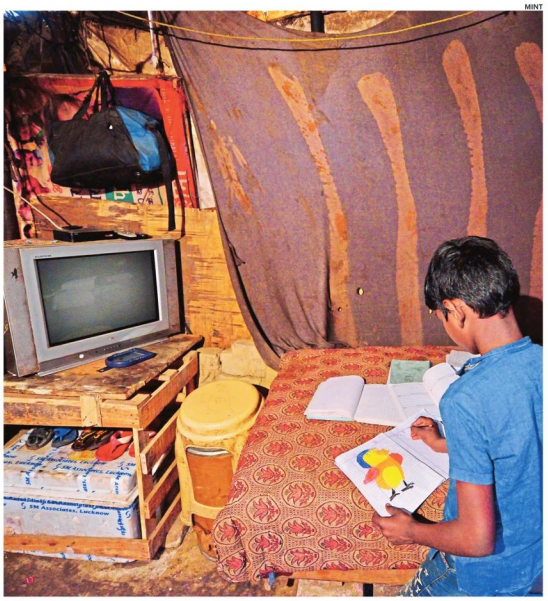

MINT

India's latest poverty estimates have sparked a wider debate about the country's economic progress. The World Bank's findings are seen by some as evidence of remarkable achievement in poverty reduction, while others question how these gains coexist with persistent inequalities. A closer examination of the evidence reveals a more nuanced story. India has made substantial progress in reducing deprivation, but the distance between escaping poverty and achieving lasting economic security remains considerable.

The World Bank's October 2026 *Poverty & Equity Brief* estimates that extreme poverty, measured at $3 per person per day in 2021 purchasing power parity (PPP) terms, declined from 27.1% in 2011 to 2.6% in 2023. At the higher $4.20 threshold, poverty fell from 57.7% to 16.1%, lifting an estimated 496 million people above that line. These achievements reflect economic growth, expanding employment and social protection programmes.

But another figure in the same report changes the perspective. At $8.30 per day, the international poverty benchmark for upper middle income countries, about 80% of Indians remain below the threshold. These figures are not contradictory. They represent different standards of consumption. India has substantially reduced extreme deprivation, but the journey towards broadly shared prosperity remains incomplete.

This distinction is frequently lost in public debate. Poverty reduction measures movement above a specified minimum standard of living. Inequality describes how economic resources are distributed. Economic security is more demanding: the capacity to sustain living standards, withstand unexpected shocks and invest in a better future. A household may escape poverty without acquiring the stable income or financial reserves needed to remain above it.

The World Bank's findings illustrate this challenge. Between 2017 and 2023, India's employment increased by about 134 million people, nearly twice the increase in its working age population. Much of this expansion came from rural women entering paid employment. Yet, real earnings were broadly unchanged, with employment growth concentrated in relatively low productivity activities. More people working is encouraging, but employment quality and remuneration ultimately determine whether households achieve lasting economic advancement.

Understanding this transition requires examining something India has historically measured less systematically than consumption: household income. The National Statistics Office's consumption surveys provide the principal foundation for the World Bank's poverty estimates. They offer indispensable evidence about living standards but cannot independently establish how households earn their livelihoods or whether their financial position is improving.

India's absence of a regular official household income series is, therefore, a significant statistical gap. The National Council of Applied Economic Research pioneered household income surveys, while People Research on India's Consumer Economy (PRICE), through its ICE 360° programme, continued these by collecting detailed evidence on household earnings, expenditure and savings.

These surveys provide a complementary perspective. Household income inequality, measured by the Gini coefficient, declined from 0.475 in 2004-05 to 0.395 in 2015-16, rose sharply to 0.528 during the pandemic and moderated to 0.410 in 2022-23. This trajectory reveals longer-term improvement, severe disruption during covid and subsequent recovery. It also illustrates why conclusions about inequality depend on the period examined and the economic variable measured.

The World Bank's consumption Gini index of 23 for 2023 appears considerably lower than PRICE's household income Gini of 0.410 for 2022-23, equivalent to 41 on the same numerical scale. But the estimates measure different distributions, using different surveys and reference periods. Consumption is generally more evenly distributed than income because households smooth expenditure through savings, borrowing, remittances and public transfers. Comparing these figures without recognizing their differences creates apparent contradictions where none necessarily exist.

Importantly, the World Bank acknowledges limitations in its estimates. It notes that substantial welfare gains between the 2022-23 and 2023-24 consumption surveys may reflect both genuine improvements and better measurement. It also cautions that surveys may inadequately capture affluent consumption, potentially understating inequality. Such transparency should encourage careful interpretation rather than diminish confidence in the findings.

Geography adds another dimension. Around 57% of India's remaining poor are concentrated in a belt stretching from Uttar Pradesh to West Bengal. Although poverty has declined across much of the country, future progress increasingly depends on raising productivity, improving employment quality and expanding income opportunities in regions where deprivation remains concentrated.

India's next development challenge is, therefore, not simply to move more people above a poverty threshold, but ensuring that those who cross it continue moving upwards. Food subsidies and public transfers protect consumption, particularly among vulnerable households. Lasting advancement, however, depends on productive employment, rising real earnings, financial resilience and opportunities for mobility.

The World Bank's findings should neither be dismissed because inequality persists nor interpreted as proof that India's development challenges have been resolved. Both positions overlook the complexity of economic transformation.

The next chapter of India's development story should be judged not merely by how many people cross the poverty line, but by how securely they remain above it and how far they can rise beyond it.

MINT CURATOR

Is China soon going to have its own 'Made in Japan' moment?

The country's firms may no longer feel the need to hide their origin

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The lesson from Japan is that pride of place is part of the product. REUTERS

In 1970, my uncle came back from Japan with a battery-operated Godzilla. Eleven-year-old me loved it. But a couple of weeks later, the monster stopped wobbling around on its thick metal legs. I sadly reached for an explanation that today would be called a meme: What did you expect, it was made in Japan.

The year my Godzilla went kaput, that punchline for shoddiness already had been around for more than two decades. Take this short item from February 1953 in *The New Yorker*'s Talk of the Town column: "A youthful recipient, at Christmas, of a furry mechanical bear—one that came in a box stamped 'Made in Japan'—had occasion to operate on it, and discovered that, apart from its skin, it consisted largely of a Schlitz beer can." Even the country's most famous export in the late 1950s and '60s, the transistor radio, wasn't completely reliable.

But by 1970, 'Made in Japan' as an insult was getting unfair. My Godzilla-gifting uncle had in fact been to Expo '70 in Osaka, such a historic showcase for the country's artistic and commercial prowess that its centrepiece, Tower of the Sun, still proudly stands and is a recognizable Japanese pop-art icon more than a half-century later.

In the years leading to that fair, Japan had been assiduously establishing a reputation for exacting excellence. Tokyo held the Summer Olympics in 1964—the first time the games had taken place in Asia—which became the backdrop for the introduction of the Shinkansen, the record-setting intercity bullet train.

Meanwhile, the cameras and lenses of Nippon Kōgaku were converting American photojournalists and eventually whole generations of amateurs. The quality was so unexpected from a country long ridiculed for the calibre of its goods that the 1964 Stanley Kubrick movie *Dr. Strangelove* had a character saying, "Strange thing is that they make such bloody good cameras." Nippon Kōgaku is now called Nikon. As for the primary manufacturer of the transistor radio, the company was originally called Totsuko. Today, we know it as Sony. Scores of global brands now radiate Japanese quality around the world.

I was reminded of Nikon's rise while reading my colleague Wes Kosova's story on the global ascendance of Chinese consumer brands—and how Shenzhen-based Viltrox has crept into the elite ranks of the world's best camera-lens makers. That led me back to 'Chinamaxxing.' I thought the trend would vanish. But it hasn't. Instead, the concept has grown. We are no longer talking about merely the grassroots adoption in the West of almost stereotypical Chinese habits such as drinking hot water, but rather the overpowering force of high-quality Chinese exports around the world.

The European Union (EU)—home to some of the most competitive and technically advanced automakers in the world—has become a thriving market for Chinese EVs and hybrids. As an HSBC Global Investment Research report concluded in June: "Chinese cars are better." While US consumers still scoff, that's only because they have little experience with the vehicles, the result of a virtual ban rooted in 100% tariffs. Europeans know better, having gone head-to-head with Chinese producers in both price and quality. It's a major flex by the People's Republic—and it has led the EU to defend its turf with tariffs on EVs since 2024 and to negotiate quotas with Chinese carmakers this year, just as it did with Japanese automakers in the 1990s.

Of course, apart from their Labubu charms dangling from bags, many ordinary consumers don't realize that many of the products and retailers they like are from China. The companies themselves seem to hide that fact. I had to click several times on the Viltrox website to get to a chronology that said the brand had its origins in China. And there are other forms of disguise. Miniso, the lifestyle shop and toy store, is based in Guangzhou, but has a logo that echoes the Japanese fast-fashion giant Uniqlo. Impersonations like these reflect an innate creative diffidence and do little to dissipate China's reputation for copying. It's almost as if the admission of country of origin might taint them by association with the infamously cheap stuff of compatriot Temu, the online marketplace operated by PDD Holdings which was founded in Shanghai but established its legal domicile in the Cayman Islands while headquartered in Dublin.

The reticence may change as China's consumer companies get more confident about where they're from. The lesson from Japan is that pride of place is part of the product, which was true even when 'made in Japan' wasn't a compliment. I kept my non-working Godzilla on the shelf for years—I think it's still somewhere in the old family home in the Philippines—unwilling to give it up because, after all, it was made in Japan. ©BLOOMBERG

MY VIEW | A VISIBLE HAND

Make way for a new 'Fragile Five' group of countries

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During an economic milestone event in 2013 called the "taper tantrum," a Morgan Stanley analyst coined the term "Fragile Five." Turkey, Brazil, India, South Africa and Indonesia were counted among them because they faced declining currencies, soaring bond yields, high inflation and large external debt burdens, which were insufficiently covered by their local reserves. This fragility was manifest when extremely low global interest rates were "tapered" back towards normalcy.

Today's Fragile Five belong entirely to the Group of Seven (G7) countries, which are the most developed in the world. The Fragile Five in 2026 are France, Italy, the UK, Germany and the US. And they are fragile not only in economic terms but also in a societal context.

As interest rates have normalized around the world after covid and the stagnation of the 2010s decade, developed markets with high debt loads have felt the impact. These democracies had piled on the debt to cushion the impact of both crises, but rising interest rates have increased debt service costs and rising inflation has caused government expenditure to rise at the same time. This has the effect of expanding the primary deficit and the fiscal deficit at the same time. Add to this toxic economic cocktail the dramatic increase in oil prices, and you have the makings not only of economic distress but also social unrest.

No country today reflects this fragility more than France. Student protests ostensibly triggered by school conditions in Paris's poor northern suburbs have widened into a cost-of-living revolt. These student-led protests are being held in the backdrop of France having a fiscal deficit of over 5% of gross domestic product (GDP), unemployment at 8.3% and high fuel prices. In France, these protests are eerily reminiscent of the May '68 riots. Those riots from nearly six decades ago scarred and polarized France. What began as student protests then morphed into a general strike with over 11 million workers joining in. The widespread rioting, police action and eventual general election left an indelible mark on French society. The degree of street violence was very high. Now, as then, the police has been accused of using a heavy-handed approach to containing the riots.

There are differences too. Unlike now, France in 1968 was in the late stage of an economic boom widely referred to as *Les Trente Glorieuses* (the glorious thirty) post-war years. While both protests were student-led, the proximate cause for the May '68 protests were university conditions. The earlier riots moved rapidly from Nanterre University to the wealthy left bank of the Seine in Paris. Today's riots were catalysed in the disadvantaged areas surrounding Saint-Denis and are clearly sparked by economic angst among those less well-off in France. Conservatives in France have always considered the May '68 riots as left-wing protests. They think so of today's riots too, but more neutrally they are cross-ideological and anti-establishment in character.

France, Italy, the UK, US and Germany from the developed world are now matchboxes in a societal context

The other four countries—the UK, Italy, Germany and the US—embody some of France's fragility syndrome. UK has a budget deficit of 4% of GDP, unemployment of 5% and inflation of 3.1%. Because of this evolving fragility, the UK has had seven prime ministers in the last 10 years. One of them, Liz Truss, lasted only 49 days, forced out when her budget included unfunded tax cuts that sparked a meltdown in its gilt market. While smaller than France's, Italy had its worst unrest over cost-of-living since mid-October, with clashes and looting in several northern Italian cities and fuel-price blockades in the south. Italy's debt-to-GDP is 140% and its unemployment is 5.7%.

In the US, President Donald Trump is the least popular president at the mid-term point in eight decades. There are many reasons for this, but affordability and inflation top the list. The US federal government debt has crossed $40 trillion, total local and federal debt-related budget deficit is now nearly 8% of GDP and total debt-to-GDP is about 126% (20% higher than the immediate post-World War II peak). Germany, though fragile, is the least at risk of the five. German debt-to-GDP is still well under 100% and its fiscal deficit is only a bit higher than the Maastricht-established norm of 3%. Despite this, Germany's Gen Z has issued a call for a protest planned soon. Beyond the G7, Belgium with a 5% of GDP fiscal deficit and Spain with 10% unemployment have already seen street protests and would qualify in the "fragile" category.

Developed democracies cushioned their societies from the ill-effects of the global financial crisis and covid with massive fiscal spending. Real incomes, youth jobs and public services lagged after the cushion ended. As interest rates have normalized, and fears of artificial intelligence taking away jobs has grown, five of them—France, Italy, the UK, US and Germany—are worthy of being called the new Fragile Five. Not in the same economic sense of currency weakness (their currencies are free and floating) and debt default but in terms of societal unrest. The G7 fiscal scaffolding is showing its weakness as the Strait of Hormuz-related oil price shock manifests in the same way as external vulnerability manifested itself for emerging markets when extremely low rates were normalized through the taper.

P.S: "He who slings mud generally loses ground," said American diplomat Adlai Stevenson.

Evaluating risks of festivities for the neurodiverse

Social rules demand one kind of celebration, but it's time to be more mindful, make changes and let each guest participate in their way

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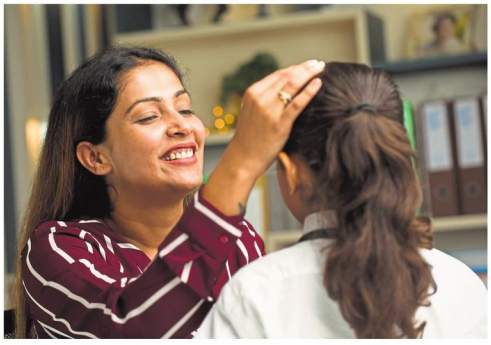
PHOTOGRAPHS FROM ISTOCKPHOTO



Every year, even before the lights go up for Diwali, parents of neurodivergent children are busy planning, evaluating risks and dreading the festivities. I have been that parent, worried about navigating this time of the year for my neurodivergent child.

To protect my neurodivergent child, we would vacation during the festive season, much to the disappointment of my extended family. I would worry about the knowing glances and unwanted comments from family. Battling these anxieties, I wondered why we let the burden of preparation fall on the neurodivergent child and their caregiver or parent, instead of being able to lean on a more supportive, understanding society.

Neurodivergence is an umbrella term to describe brains of children and adults that do not process sensory input, social cues, attention and change in an expected manner. It includes individuals who are on the autism spectrum, have attention deficit hyperactivity disorder, dyslexia, dyspraxia (learning differences) or Tourette Syndrome, with or without a formal diagnosis.

It describes a difference, not a deficit, and it is different for every individual.

These differences show up more during celebrations, when the environment is filled with noise, crowds, strong smells, unfamiliar food, broken routines and the expectation of visible cheer.

A festival that is celebratory for most can feel exhausting for a neurodivergent adult or a child. The impact is more pronounced in a child as they are learning to regulate themselves. A child's struggle is so often misread as bad behaviour by adults, when it is actually a mismatch between the child's inner world or personality and their environment.

For a child who processes sensory input differently, or who depends on predictability to feel safe, festivals can feel overwhelming. When that child struggles or doesn't act as per people's expectations, the usual verdict from judging relatives is that the little one is "difficult," "shy," "spoilt," or "needs more exposure." Rarely does an adult consider that maybe the environment was not conducive for the child. My child, for example, would retreat from the celebration to play with pets. But, years of training my extended family worked and they don't mind him stepping away to regulate himself any longer.

One needs to make the environment conducive for the child to enjoy the festivities in the way they know best, even though it could be inconvenient for the people participating in it. Here are some of my learnings as a parent of a neurodivergent child.

For any neurodivergent person, it is good to know what they are getting into. Talking through the festival plan weeks ahead, rather than a night before, using a picture schedule, photos from festivals gone by, or a social story are very helpful in setting the stage for the child.

It makes the unknown known and leaves no surprises. It is also necessary to make the child aware of what to expect by sharing details about what will happen, in what order and for how long. Specifics matter, and it is better to say that they will be at the celebration for an hour, instead of "for some time".

Keep triggers away as sensory stimulation causes immense discomfort for neurodivergent children. The common triggers include firecrackers, perfumes, new clothes that could itch or have tags, loud music, flashy lights, among others.

> Festivals can feel overwhelming for a child who processes sensory input differently and relies on predictability

Reach for earplugs, noise cancelling headphones and sunglasses. Also, test new outfits with comfortable fabrics and keep familiar alternatives in hand. These should be part of the child's festive gear.

Your child needs to return to a familiar meal, a nap, scheduled recovery time between events, and a wind-down ritual. In an unfamiliar environment, your little one could carry something familiar, like a favourite toy or a blanket. For my son, it is his favourite food in any form.

Autonomy matters, too; your child should decide which parts of the festivities they want to participate in because Diwali celebrations are not part of their regular day. A child who lights a single diya and then retreats is still participating. Consider involving the child to hand out sweets or arranging flowers which gives the much-needed structure in an unstructured setting.

Opting out should always be an acceptable answer. Keep an exit route. Don't carpool; arrive in your own vehicle with just the child and a caregiver or the parent. Knowing they can leave usually lowers anxiety, and often means the child stays longer.

The bigger question that has been plaguing me is why families need to deal with this situation by themselves. To lighten their load, a host can play a conscious and active role. There is no better time than the festive season to be inclusive.

The simplest thing to do is to plan for a quiet room. Discourage fireworks or warn the family with a neurodivergent child when they are going to begin. Serve simple food along with festive must-haves, and don't take it personally when a child eats very little. Greet children without demanding hugs or eye contact. Stop asking questions about why the child will not talk to the guests and start asking what would make it easier for the child to be comfortable. It's alright to check with the family if the child would like to eat early or choose to leave early.

Festive events at schools, residential communities and office parties with families can also offer quiet rooms and advance schedules to make it easier for parents of neurodivergent children to plan their day. These accommodations don't require much effort, but need genuine intent.

Most hosts are unfamiliar about how to communicate with a neurodivergent child and make them feel included. The first thing to know is that a meltdown by such a child is actually a response to sensory overload, and not misbehaviour.

A child who wants to leave early is asking for regulation and is not being rude. When parents decline an invitation, they are protecting their child, not being antisocial.

We often measure the success of a festival by how it looks in pictures, the attendance and how children and adults perform joy. It's time to change these rules and be mindful of whether each guest felt included and accepted. Small adjustments and being mindful of your guests can go a long way in making everyone feel a sense of belonging in the festive season.

ISTOCKPHOTO

Work your abs like the star footballer Thierry Henry

This three-step ab routine is a complete workout for a stronger core

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Arsenal legend Thierry Henry's commitment to fitness long after hanging up his football boots is evident. Henry, 49, has a simple and well-rounded ab routine that targets and tests muscles in different ways: through flexion, stability and rotation. No core workout can promise visible abs, but certain movements like these help those muscles build strength.

HANGING WEIGHTED CRUNCHES

Performed on a pull-up bar, this movement works your core for control while the upper body stays steady. Grip a pull-up bar, slightly wider than shoulder width. Let your body hang and stabilise, making sure you don't swing. Tighten your core and bring your knees towards your chest. Finish it by returning to your starting position. Let your abs do the work rather than the momentum of the swing. Ensuring your body is stable will make this exercise effective. Henry grips a 20 kg dumbbell between his feet but if you're a beginner to hanging exercises, do it without weights and slowly progress.

WEIGHTED SINGLE-ARM SIT-UPS

It is a single-sided sit-up, and one side of the abs work harder than the other, targeting the obliques of the side which is holding up the weight. Henry does this with a 20 kg dumbbell, but it can be performed just as well with a lighter one. The weight should be held above your shoulder with an extended arm and the wrist stacked above the shoulder. A heavy weight will cause the wrist to collapse, so don't try to ego lift. Since a weight overhead works on shoulder stability as well, there is a level of coordination required between your upper body and core.

> The focus is on three main movement patterns: flexion, stability and rotation

What's unique here is that the way the feet are planted on the floor matter. Beginners can keep their legs folded at the knees so the soles touch the floor and can be used to drive up the body along with the free hand also on the floor to help balance the body. As you progress, you can slowly start extending your legs. Henry does a version with his legs fully extended and very little help from the free hand.

WEIGHTED SIDE PLANK HOLD

This exercise builds on a high plank with a movement, adding some challenge to the static exercise. Start in a conventional high plank. Remain in a high plank on two feet and one arm. Take a weight on the other arm, extend it upwards to the side and hold for at least 10-15 seconds. Bring it down, and use the other hand to lift the weight up, rotating your torso in the process. In this entire movement, your hips have to be in line with the rest of your body, not dropped. It mainly targets the obliques with the rotational movement. Your core muscles, glutes and shoulders, which keep you steady throughout the exercise are strengthened too. The weight increases the difficulty level, but a straight body and controlled rotation are more important. This is not to be confused with a side plank where the whole body is turned to one side with the ankles stacked.

Creating awareness is the missing first step in menopause care

A first-hand account of visiting menopause clinics in Mumbai launched by the state government this year

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ISTOCKPHOTO

The nurse gave me an annoyed look: "You see how busy we are. One nurse has to look after 50-60 patients. Please ask someone else." I was at the gynaecology ward on the seventh floor of Mumbai's K.B. Bhabha Municipal General Hospital, assuming it was the place to enquire about the menopause clinic launched at Maharashtra government hospitals in January.

I spent the next 30 minutes enquiring about the clinic's location and finally found my answer in the casualty ward. I was told to visit the gynaec out-patient department at 8am the next day. The following morning found me in a clean, nearly empty waiting room that smelt faintly of phenyl. Near the entrance was a large poster in Marathi announcing the *Rjonivrutti* (Marathi for menopause) clinic. The poster explained the condition and the care offered, including consultation with a doctor, diagnostic tests, psychological counselling, advice for diet and lifestyle changes, guidance to improve bone health, medicine availability and check-ups.

The menopause clinics were launched in public and select private hospitals in January in Maharashtra, making it the first state in India to introduce a dedicated service for affordable menopause healthcare. Medical advice for women going through menopause is available largely to those in high income groups, and this is the first instance of efforts being made to include women from other income groups.

Despite the good intentions, the lack of awareness is apparent—most of the women at the menopause clinic that morning were young or expectant mothers. Nevertheless, I headed to the oayment counter at the hospital's entrance to register, paying ₹10. (Sidenote: I would have paid ₹3,000 to my gynaecologist.)

By the time I returned with the registration slip, there were four female gynaecs seated around a large table, taking the history of the patients, each one close enough to overhear the other patients' issues. I was there for perimenopause-related challenges, and the doctor got down to the little details and went through the essential checklist: hot flushes, irregular periods, sleep problems, mood issues and body change. Finally, she did a physical examination, recommended blood tests, an ultrasound and asked me to come back with the reports. When I asked for her name, she diplomatically refused to share and said one of the other doctors would see me if she was busy.

Dr Namrata Tiwari, from the gynaecology department of King Edward Memorial (KEM) Hospital, one of Mumbai's oldest public medical institutions, says her patients tend to hesitate while sharing their history. Similar to the two visits to Bhabha Hospital, I had to go to KEM twice to find the menopause clinic.

There, the menopause OPD runs from 9:30 am to 11:30 am on Wednesdays. The notice is easy to miss, instead they could have run it on the big TV screen—which was playing a video on endometriosis the time I was there—to grab more attention. Tiwari said that she had written a script for a menopause awareness video for use in the OPD on such screens earlier this year, but production is still in the pipeline.

During my second visit, in the time allotted for menopausal women, the waiting area was fairly empty. There were only two women who seemed to be in their fifties and we got talking. They were clueless about the clinic and were there for other concerns. They showed me a small slip of paper handed to them by a junior doctor. It had specifics of plastic gloves needed for an internal physical examination. One pair was for ₹82 which made them grumble given that they paid ₹10 for the consultation. "Recently, we have run out of gloves and the patients need to buy them from outside," Tiwari says.

Making medicines available for free is part of the package in these government-run menopause clinics. Tiwari shows a list of medicines that was sent to the hospital's pharmacy when the initiative was launched in January. There were supplements including Vitamin D and calcium, oral estradiol tablets, progesterone tablets and estradiol vaginal cream for dryness. Tiwari shares they have team of doctors, including a psychiatrist, for the clinic and pulls out her phone to show their WhatsApp group, 'Menopause clinic KEM'.

"Honestly, not a lot of people have benefitted because there's a lack of awareness," says Dr. Tiwari. "Now, we pick patients from the ward or general OPD and refer them to this clinic. I have informed my colleagues too." She says the way it works is that women don't visit specifically for menopause, and doctors diagnose them based on their symptoms and refer them to the clinic.

Even social media lacks information in this regard. Menopause reels in Marathi by content creators highlight symptoms and management tools, but they don't mention the government clinics. Women-focussed NGOs in Maharashtra work in the field of menstrual and antenatal health but menopause continues to remain unaddressed.

While lack of awareness is one part of the problem, creating a mindshift change is the bigger challenge because women from lower income groups are not yet empowered to advocate for their health. The state government-run menopause clinics were introduced more than 10 months ago, but are unlikely to be of help if no one shows up.